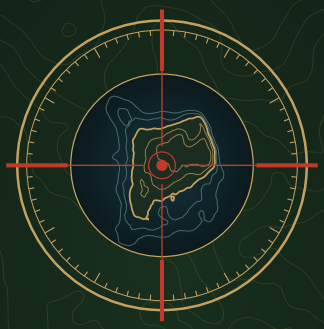
HOMO VENANDUS

Reason, Sovereignty, and the Venatic Constitution of the Human in Richard Connell's "The Most Dangerous Game"

WRITTEN BY CLAUDE OPUS 5.5 — ASSEMBLED BY ANDREW VAN BLAIR



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Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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Abstract

This dissertation undertakes a sustained philosophical, mythographic, and media-archaeological reading of Richard Connell's "The Most Dangerous Game" (*Collier's*, 19 January 1924), a magazine story whose pedagogical ubiquity and transmedial fecundity stand in inverse proportion to the critical attention it has received. Against the prevailing treatment of the story as a machine for suspense or a parable of "man versus man," it argues that Connell's narrative constitutes a primal scene of what I term the *venatic paradigm*: the historically sedimented structure through which Western modernity has organized the relations among reason, sovereignty, narrative, property, and technique around the figure of the hunt.

The argument turns on a single textual hinge. When General Zaroff enumerates the attributes of the "ideal quarry"—courage, cunning, and "above all" the capacity to reason—he restates, as a hunting specification, the classical definition of the human as *zōon logon echon*, *animal rationale*. The faculty that the humanist tradition from Aristotle to Kant invoked to exempt the human from the condition of thing, price, and prey becomes, on Ship-Trap Island, the qualification for pursuit. I name the subject so constituted *homo venandus*—the human as that which is "to be hunted"—and argue that the story discloses this condition not as a perversion of humanism but as its concealed operational logic.

Four theses organize the study. The thesis of *venatic inversion* holds that the story converts the criterion of moral considerability—reason in the Cartesian-Kantian line, sentience in the Benthamite line voiced by Whitney—into a criterion of sporting value, exposing the convertibility of dignity into price. The thesis of *venatic reversibility* holds that, because the hunt's only exit is the assumption of the hunter's position, Rainsford's victory reproduces the sovereign office it defeats; the story's terminal ellipsis and its superlative bed re-enact the succession rite of the King of the Wood at Nemi, a structure I name the *Nemorensian loop*. The thesis of the *literalizing island* holds that Ship-Trap Island is a machine for converting figures into practices—"hunters and huntees," the "vibrations of evil" broadcast by an "evil place," "the best sport in the world"—so that the narrative's horror is the collapse of metaphor into act. The thesis of the *double game* holds that the title's amphiboly (game as quarry; game as rule-bound contest) resolves in favour of the second sense: the most dangerous game is the ludic-contractual form that converts coercion into consent and slaughter into sport.

Methodologically, the dissertation develops a *venatic hermeneutics* that braids genealogical philosophy (Aristotle, Hobbes, Hegel, Nietzsche, Heidegger, Derrida, Agamben, Chamayou); comparative mythography (the *Odyssey*, Actaeon, Theseus and the brigands of the Isthmus, Nimrod, *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, *The Tempest*, Frazer's Nemi); the economic sociology of predation and leisure (Veblen, Pascal, Kierkegaard, Bataille); the philosophy of play and the mathematics of pursuit (Huizinga, Caillois, Suits, von Neumann, the lion-and-man problem); and a transmedial archive running from Paleolithic hunting imagery and Renaissance painting through the 1932 RKO adaptation and the human-hunt literature and cinema it seeded (*Rogue Male*, "The Seventh Victim," *Battle Royale*, *The Hunger Games*, *Predator*, *Squid Game*) to video games, cybernetic targeting, and drone warfare. Situating the story within a synchronic constellation of 1924—the Johnson–Reed Act, the Leopold and Loeb murder, Kafka's "Der Bau," Babel's Cossack stories, and the Taung Child—it reads Connell's text as a seismograph of the hunt's migration from the imperial game preserve into the juridical, scientific, and technical infrastructure of modernity.

The dissertation concludes by proposing a post-venatic ethics grounded not in the quarry's victory but in the dismantling of the island: an ethics that begins, with Whitney, from a shared understanding of fear, and ends in the refusal of the game-form itself.

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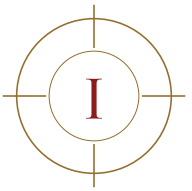
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Note on the Text, Translations, and Citation

Quotations from "The Most Dangerous Game" follow the text first published in *Collier's* on 19 January 1924, now in the public domain; because the story circulates in innumerable reprints with divergent pagination, it is cited without page reference. Classical, medieval, and early modern works are cited by their standard divisions—book, chapter, section, line, Bekker or Stephanus number, or fragment—so that any edition may be used; where a widely reprinted public-domain translation is quoted, it is named on first use. Translations from French, German, Latin, and Russian not otherwise attributed are my own.

Modern scholarship is cited author–date in the text; a consolidated bibliography follows Chapter Eight. Where an argument rests on a conjectural etymology or an onomastic resonance rather than documentary evidence, it is flagged as such, and no thesis of the dissertation depends on any single conjecture of that kind.


SHIP-TRAP ISLAND
a conjectural chart
CARIBBEAN SEA
false channel lights
the leap
San Lucar
the château
on a high bluff
three days
the fall
Death Swamp
quicksand
N
course of the yacht,
bound for Rio



CHAPTER ONE

The Answer to a Parlour Question

Ship-Trap Island as Primal Scene

§ 1.1

The Question Before the Story

Every title answers a question it does not print. Richard Connell's is unusually exact about the question it presupposes. Among the big-game hunters of the Anglo-American imperial world—the authors and readers of Frederick Courteney Selous's *A Hunter's Wanderings in Africa* (1881), of John Henry Patterson's *The Man-Eaters of Tsavo* (1907), of Theodore Roosevelt's *African Game Trails* (1910)—the identity of the most dangerous game was a perennial parlour controversy, argued over port and adjudicated, provisionally, by the scars of its disputants. Lion, elephant, rhinoceros, leopard, and buffalo each had partisans; the later canon of the "Big Five" preserved the dispute as a hierarchy of difficulty, a list of the animals most likely to kill the man who hunted them on foot.

Connell stages the controversy with deliberate economy. Rainsford, contemplating the mounted head of a Cape buffalo in General Zaroff's dining hall, offers the received answer: "I've always thought ... that the Cape buffalo is the most dangerous of all big game." The general, after a pause occupied by "his curious red-lipped smile," corrects him: "No. You are wrong, sir. The Cape buffalo is not the most dangerous big game." The title is the general's answer, withheld from the dinner table and printed above the story. The most dangerous game is the human being.

Yet the answer is less stable than the riddle-form implies. The English noun *game* carries a semantic doubleness that the story exploits without naming. Old English *gamen* designated joy, amusement, and sport; Middle English extended the word to the practice of the chase, and thence, by metonymy, to the animals chased. The Middle English romance that offers the closest structural analogue to Connell's narrative—*Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, to

which Chapter Four returns—turns precisely on this doubleness. It opens with a "Crystemas gomen" that is at once a festive pastime and a wager on a severed head, and proceeds through three days in which the host's hunting of deer, boar, and fox is intercut with another game played in his castle's bedchamber, where the guest is the quarry.

Connell's title therefore admits two parsings. On the first, "the most dangerous game" names a quarry: the human, ranked above buffalo and tiger on a scale of lethality. On the second, it names a form: a contest, a rule-bound practice, the "sporting proposition" that Zaroff invokes, with audible quotation marks, as the condition of his pleasure. This dissertation contends that the story's deepest argument resides in the slide between these parsings, and that the second ultimately absorbs the first. The quarry is dangerous because it reasons; but what is most dangerous is the game—the ludic and contractual apparatus through which coercion is reconstituted as consent, slaughter as sport, and the human as prey. The story's alternative title in later reprints, "The Hounds of Zaroff," displaces the emphasis once more, from the quarry and the contest to the instruments of pursuit; Chapter Four will argue that the hounds, too, are a thesis.

That a magazine story of under nine thousand words should bear such weight requires justification, and the justification is partly quantitative. "The Most Dangerous Game" appeared in *Collier's* on 19 January 1924, with illustrations by Wilmot Emerton Heitland, in a mass-circulation weekly whose fiction pages traded in the compressed ironies and terminal reversals of the O. Henry tradition. Connell had taken the O. Henry Memorial Award's second prize the previous year for "A Friend of Napoleon," and the new story was selected for the award's annual anthology, *O. Henry Memorial Award Prize Stories of 1924* (Williams, ed., 1925). It passed into the American secondary-school curriculum, where it remains among the most frequently anthologized of American short stories, and where it is typically deployed to teach the elementary grammar of narrative: exposition, rising action, climax, the taxonomy of "conflict." Terry W. Thompson has suggested that it may be the most popular short story ever written in English (Thompson 2018).

Its afterlife beyond the classroom is more extensive still. Beginning with the RKO adaptation of 1932, produced by Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack on jungle sets shared with *King Kong*, the story seeded a transmedial genre—the human hunt—whose lineage runs through Robert Wise's *A Game of Death* (1945), Robert Sheckley's "The Seventh Victim" (1953) and Elio Petri's *La decima vittima* (1965), Cornel Wilde's *The Naked Prey* (1965), John McTiernan's *Predator* (1987), John Woo's *Hard Target* (1993), Koushun Takami's *Battle Royale* (1999), Suzanne Collins's *The Hunger Games* (2008), and Hwang Dong-hyuk's *Squid Game* (2021), and which now inhabits the asymmetrical multiplayer architectures of the video game. Few modern short narratives have proved so generative of form.

The qualitative justification is the more important. The story's philosophical content has generally been treated as self-evident, its moral as exhausted by the reversal that teaches the hunter "how an animal at bay feels." The pedagogical frame is itself symptomatic. The story is taught as a lesson in plot because plot, in the tradition this dissertation examines, is already a

form of pursuit: the reader tracks, the narrative evades, and suspense is the interval between the scent and the kill. To teach "The Most Dangerous Game" as an exemplar of narrative structure is to concede, without noticing, the thesis the story advances about structure itself—that the forms through which a culture organizes its experience of time, conflict, and resolution may be forms of the hunt. The chapters that follow attempt to notice.

§ 1.2

Homo Venandus: Statement of Theses

The central textual hinge occurs at Zaroff's dinner table, after the general has explained that hunting "had ceased to be what you call 'a sporting proposition,'" that it had become "too easy," and that "there is no greater bore than perfection." He frames the remedy as a problem of specification: "I wanted the ideal animal to hunt," explained the general. "So I said, 'What are the attributes of an ideal quarry?' And the answer was, of course, 'It must have courage, cunning, and, above all, it must be able to reason.'" Rainsford's objection—"But no animal can reason"—receives the most consequential sentence in the story: "My dear fellow, there is one that can."

The exchange recapitulates, in compressed and parodic form, the longest-running definitional project of Western philosophy. Aristotle distinguishes the human as the only animal possessing *logos* (*Politics* I.2, 1253a9–10); the scholastic tradition codifies the formula as *animal rationale* Descartes, denying reason to animals, renders them automata (*Discourse on Method*, Part V); Kant grounds the dignity (*Würde*) of persons—their exemption from the economy of price (*Preis*)—in rational nature, which exists as an end in itself (*Groundwork*, 4:428–435). In each case reason performs a double function. It defines the human, and it exempts the human, marking the line beyond which beings may not be used, bought, or killed at will.

Zaroff retains the definition and inverts the exemption. Reason ceases to ground inviolability and becomes the specification of sporting value: his captives "can reason, after a fashion. So they are dangerous," and because they are dangerous they are worth hunting. The faculty that was to remove the human from the category of game becomes the attribute that places it at the category's summit.

I designate the subject so constituted *homo venandus*. The phrase is formed on the gerundive of the Latin deponent *venor, venari*, "to hunt": *venandus*, "that which is to be hunted," with the gerundive's characteristic shading of obligation—"that which ought to be hunted." It stands in deliberate relation to three prior coinages. Against Linnaeus's *homo sapiens*, it records that sapience is here the predicate of prey. Against Johan Huizinga's *homo ludens* (1938), it records that the play-form, far from constituting an autonomous sphere of freedom, can serve as the very medium of domination.



TABLE 1.1 *Three criteria of considerability in "The Most Dangerous Game."*

Against Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995)—the figure of archaic Roman law who may be killed but not sacrificed, whose life is included in the juridical order solely through its exposure to death—it records a distinctive surplus. Zaroff's quarry may be killed, but must be killed *well*. The bare life of *homo venandus* is not merely exposed but solicited: fed, exercised, furnished with "an excellent hunting knife," brought into "splendid physical condition," so that its resistance may yield the aesthetic and epistemic satisfactions of a worthy pursuit. *Homo venandus* is bare life elevated to the dignity of an opponent, and it is the elevation, not the denial, that constitutes the horror.

From this hinge four theses follow.

The first is the thesis of **venatic inversion**. The story's opening dialogue sets two criteria of moral considerability against each other, and the dinner scene supplies a third that neither interlocutor anticipates (Table 1.1). Rainsford, dismissing the jaguar's perspective—"Bah! They've no understanding"—speaks the Cartesian idiom in which the absence of reason licenses indifference. Whitney, conceding the premise while shifting its ground—"Even so, I rather think they understand one thing—fear. The fear of pain and the fear of death"—speaks the idiom of Jeremy Bentham, for whom "the question is not, Can they *reason*? nor, Can they *talk*? but, Can they *suffer*?" (*An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation*, ch. XVII). Zaroff converts reason from a criterion of exemption into a criterion of eligibility.

The dissertation reads this tripartite structure as a staged genealogy of the animal question in modern ethics. Zaroff's position is not an aberration from the rationalist tradition but its

reductio, in which Kant's distinction between dignity and price collapses into a single scale of sporting worth: "a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them."

The second is the thesis of **venatic reversibility**, and of what I call the **Nemorensian loop**. In the hunt as Connell constructs it, the quarry has no exit except by occupying the hunter's position. Rainsford survives by becoming, in technique, temperament, and finally in place, what he flees. He builds a "Malay mancatcher," digs a "Burmese tiger pit," and, recalling "a native trick he had learned in Uganda," lashes his knife to a springy sapling; he declares himself "still a beast at bay"; he kills his host in the host's bedroom; and he sleeps in the host's bed.

The final sentence—"He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided"—is commonly read as a terse note of triumph. I read it as an act of succession. James George Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* with the priest of Diana at Nemi, the *rex Nemorensis*, a figure who prowled his sacred grove by night with a drawn sword, "a priest and a murderer," who held office until he was "himself slain by a stronger or a craftier." Connell's story re-enacts the Nemi rite in the idiom of the Jazz Age. The goddess of the hunt still presides; succession is still by murder; and the new king, unlike his Frazerian predecessor, sleeps—which is to say that he does not yet know what office he has inherited. Reversibility, on this account, is not a moral symmetry that restores justice but a structural law that reproduces sovereignty.

The third is the thesis of the **literalizing island**. Ship-Trap Island is, before it is anything else, a place where figures of speech are taken at their word. Rainsford's sociology of "hunters and huntees" becomes a literal partition of the island's population. Whitney's conjecture that "an evil place can, so to speak, broadcast vibrations of evil" is fulfilled, minus its "so to speak," by the false channel lights through which Zaroff will "help Providence a bit." "The best sport in the world" becomes the sport whose stake is the world's best animal. The island converts metaphor into practice, and the dread it inspires in sailors is the dread of a place where language loses its *as if*. This thesis links Connell's technique to a modernist procedure, executed most rigorously by Kafka, in which horror arises from the collapse of figurative distance.

The fourth is the thesis of the **double game**. Building on the title's amphiboly, the dissertation argues that the decisive danger lies in the game-form: in the three-hour start and the three-day term, the "option" of the knout, the "word as a gentleman and a sportsman," the formal congratulation offered to the victor. The rules do not restrain the violence; they consecrate it. Chapter Five accordingly reads the hunt through the philosophy of play (Huizinga, Caillois, Suits), the theory of contract (Hobbes on covenants extorted by fear), and the formal theory of games, and argues that the "sporting proposition" is the form in which modern sovereignty learned to disguise the decision over life as a contest between equals.

Taken together, these theses support a general claim. The hunt is not merely one practice among others through which modern power has been exercised—a claim established with great force by Grégoire Chamayou's history of manhunts (2010)—but a scene in which the human, as a category, is produced, tested, and allocated. Hunting is anthropogenic in a double sense. The paleoanthropological imagination of the twentieth century repeatedly derived the human from the hunt ("Man the Hunter"), even as the fossil record increasingly suggests

that the hominin lineage was shaped as much by being hunted; and the political history of modernity repeatedly decided the boundaries of humanity by deciding who might be hunted. Connell's story is the minimal model—the primal scene—of this double anthropogenesis.

§ 1.3

Venatic Hermeneutics: Method and Archive

A study that claims the hunt as a matrix of the human must reflect on its own procedures, for interpretation is itself, in a tradition reaching back to the Greeks, a venatic art. Carlo Ginzburg's essay on the evidential paradigm (1979) located the origins of conjectural knowledge—the knowledge of the physician, the connoisseur, the detective, and the psychoanalyst—in the hunter's capacity to reconstruct an unseen event from footprints, broken branches, tufts of hair, and droppings. He ventured, further, that the first narrative may have been the hunter's: a sequence of events deciphered from tracks.

Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's study of *mētis* (1974) showed that the Greek concept of cunning intelligence was elaborated through the technical vocabulary of hunting and fishing—the net, the noose, the lure, the doubling-back of the fox, the polymorphous camouflage of the octopus—and that *mētis* is the intelligence by which the weaker party prevails over force. Roland Barthes's analysis of the hermeneutic code in *S/Z* (1970) identified, among the devices by which narrative defers its truth, the *leurre*: the snare, the deliberate misdirection. The three accounts converge on a single proposition. Reading is tracking, and narrative is a trap.

The method of this dissertation, which I call *venatic hermeneutics*, takes that proposition at its word—an apt gesture for a study of the literalizing island. It proceeds by three operations.

The first is **genealogical tracking**: following the spoor of the ideas Connell's characters articulate back to their originators. Rainsford's "two classes" and Zaroff's "Life is for the strong, to be lived by the strong, and, if needs be, taken by the strong" are tracked through Thucydides' Melian Dialogue, Aristotle's doctrine of natural slavery, Hobbes's state of nature, Sade's libertine cosmology, the Darwinian and Spencerian vocabularies of struggle and fitness and T. H. Huxley's dissent from them, Nietzsche's master morality, Dostoevsky's extraordinary men, and the eugenic hierarchies of Madison Grant and Lothrop Stoddard.

The aim is not the attribution of influence in the philological sense. Connell—a Harvard graduate, newspaperman, and advertising writer who had served in France with the 27th New York Division and edited its camp newspaper, *Gas Attack*—left no record of having read Nietzsche or Veblen, and the argument does not need him to have done so. Its aim is the reconstruction of a discursive ecology: the field of available statements within which a story written for a mass weekly could make a Russian aristocrat speak like a degraded Nietzschean and an American sportsman speak like a Spencerian, without either seeming improbable to readers in 1924.

The second is **comparative mythography**: placing Connell's narrative within the long series of hunted guests, devouring hosts, transformed hunters, and murderous successions that runs from the Cyclops episode of the *Odyssey* and Ovid's Actaeon through Bluebeard, Prospero, and Dracula. Here the dissertation observes a caution that Wittgenstein addressed to Frazer. The comparative method's value lies not in explaining a practice by its supposed origin, but in producing a "perspicuous representation" (*übersichtliche Darstellung*) that makes connections visible by arranging cases (*Remarks on Frazer's Golden Bough*, written 1931). The mythic parallels assembled in Chapter Four are offered in that spirit: not as sources, but as an arrangement in which the story's structure becomes legible.

The third is **transmedial tracking**. It follows the story's structure across cinema, television, prose fiction, comics and manga, painting, taxidermy, and the video game, and into domains that are not media in the ordinary sense—the mathematics of pursuit and evasion, the cybernetics of anti-aircraft prediction, the doctrine of targeted killing. It treats adaptations, imitations, and analogues not as derivatives to be measured against an original, but as a population of variants through which the venatic paradigm reproduces, mutates, and occasionally criticizes itself. In this respect the dissertation borrows from media archaeology the conviction that the history of a form is legible in its recurrences and dead ends as much as in its lines of descent.

Two commitments govern the archive. The first is historicity. The hunt has a history, and that history is one of property, empire, war, and technique; the claim that the hunt constitutes the human is a historical claim about the persistence and mutation of a structure, not a claim about an invariant human nature. The paleoanthropological speculations that appear in this chapter and in Chapter Eight are treated as part of the archive—as twentieth-century stories about the hunt—rather than as its foundation.

The second commitment is attention to the story's racial, colonial, and class diction. Zaroff's catalogue of quarry—"sailors from tramp ships—lascars, blacks, Chinese, whites, mongrels"—is not incidental color. It is the precise point at which the story touches the eugenic science, immigration law, and racial taxonomy of its moment, and the point at which its central conceit becomes most dangerous. The general's taxonomy is quoted in order to be anatomized, not repeated.

A final remark concerns tone. The story is a sardonic entertainment, and its humor—"It's like finding a snuffbox in a limousine"—is part of its argument. Connell's first collection (1922) was a book of humorous tales, and the general's wit is the story's most efficient vehicle for its horror. An adequate reading must therefore attend to irony as a structural rather than an ornamental feature. The story's jokes are its traps.

§ 1.4

The State of the Field and the Shape of a Lacuna

The scholarly literature devoted to "The Most Dangerous Game" is small relative to the story's circulation, and most of it falls into three categories. The first is pedagogical: teaching editions, study guides, and classroom apparatus that treat the story as a vehicle for narrative structure, suspense, and the vocabulary of conflict. The second is generic and historical: accounts of the "slick" magazine fiction of the interwar period, within which Connell figures as a skilled practitioner of the twist ending, and occasional essays, such as Terry W. Thompson's centenary reading (2018), that situate the story in its moment. The third is cinematic: discussions of the 1932 adaptation within the histories of RKO, of pre-Code horror, and of the production cycle that yielded *King Kong*, where the shared sets, shared performers, and shared producers have attracted more attention than the source. Where the story has been invoked in broader cultural argument, it has usually served as an emblem—a shorthand for the manhunt—rather than as an object of sustained analysis.

The fields that bear most directly on the story's ideas have, by contrast, flourished, though largely without reference to it.

The history and philosophy of hunting extends from José Ortega y Gasset's *Meditations on Hunting* (1942), with its argument that one does not hunt in order to kill but kills in order to have hunted, through Paul Shepard's *The Tender Carnivore and the Sacred Game* (1973), to the critical histories of Matt Cartmill's *A View to a Death in the Morning* (1993), John M. MacKenzie's *The Empire of Nature* (1988), Harriet Ritvo's *The Animal Estate* (1987), and Daniel Justin Herman's *Hunting and the American Imagination* (2001).

American cultural history has examined the hunter as a figure of national mythology—most influentially in Richard Slotkin's account of "regeneration through violence" (1973)—and as a figure of racialized masculinity, in Gail Bederman's study of manliness and civilization (1995) and in Donna Haraway's anatomy of taxidermy, eugenics, and the American Museum of Natural History, "Teddy Bear Patriarchy" (1984–85).

Animal studies, reshaped by Jacques Derrida's lecture on the animal that therefore I am (delivered 1997; published 2006) and his seminars on *The Beast and the Sovereign* (2001–03), by Cary Wolfe's *Animal Rites* (2003), and by Agamben's *The Open* (2002), has made the boundary between human and animal a central problem of political philosophy.

The political theory of the manhunt has been transformed by Grégoire Chamayou's *Les chasses à l'homme* (2010), which reconstructs the history of hunting human beings from antiquity to the policing of undocumented migrants, and by Achille Mbembe's account of necropolitics (2003), the sovereign power to dictate who may live and who must die. Game studies, founded by Huizinga and Roger Caillois and formalized by Bernard Suits, supplies the vocabulary for analyzing the hunt as a rule-bound practice. Narrative theory—from Barthes and Peter Brooks's *Reading for the Plot* (1984) to Ginzburg and to Ursula K. Le Guin's critique

of the "killer story" in "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986)—has repeatedly identified pursuit and capture as figures, and sometimes as the origin, of plot itself.

The lacuna, then, is not an absence of relevant thought but an absence of convergence. To my knowledge no study has read Connell's story as the point at which these literatures intersect: as a text in which the philosophical problem of the animal, the political problem of the manhunt, the economic problem of leisure, the ludic problem of rules, and the narratological problem of pursuit are staged simultaneously and in relation. The story's brevity has worked against it. Its compression, which makes it so serviceable a teaching instrument, has encouraged readers to treat it as a single idea efficiently delivered, when it is better understood as a densely layered assemblage whose apparent simplicity is itself an effect of the trap.

Two contributions follow from occupying this intersection. The first is interpretive: a reading that accounts for details commonly passed over—the radio metaphor of the opening, the .22 cartridge, the astrakhan trim of Ivan's uniform, the hound named Lazarus, the Spanish bark *San Lucar*, the works of Marcus Aurelius in Zaroff's library, the bed itself—and shows them to be load-bearing.

The second is theoretical: the articulation of the venatic paradigm as a concept capacious enough to relate Chamayou's political history, Agamben's biopolitics, Veblen's sociology of predation, Huizinga's theory of play, and Ginzburg's evidential paradigm, while remaining answerable to a single text that, in under nine thousand words, already performs their synthesis.

§ 1.5

1924: A Constellation

"Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen"—ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars—Walter Benjamin wrote in the epistemo-critical prologue to his study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928). A constellation does not explain its stars; it arranges them so that a figure becomes visible. The year of the story's publication offers such an arrangement. None of the events assembled in Table 1.2 is a source of Connell's narrative, and most post-date its composition. Together they disclose a figure the story traces with uncanny precision: the migration of the hunt from the imperial game preserve into law, science, crime, literature, and the museum.

Consider first the law. Four months after Connell's story appeared, the Johnson–Reed Act established national-origins quotas designed to curtail immigration from southern and eastern Europe and to bar immigration from Asia. Its intellectual scaffolding was the race science popularized by Madison Grant's *The Passing of the Great Race* (1916) and by Lothrop Stoddard's *The Rising Tide of Color* (1920) and *The Revolt Against Civilization: The Menace of the Under Man* (1922). Grant was a member of the Boone and Crockett Club, the elite hunting and conservation society founded by Theodore Roosevelt and George Bird Grinnell

TABLE 1.2

A constellation of 1924.



	DATE (1924)	Event	*Venatic resonance*
1	19 JANUARY	"The Most Dangerous Game" appears in *Collier's*	*The human named as supreme quarry*
2	21 JANUARY	Death of Lenin; the Bolshevik succession struggle opens	*The regime Zaroff fled; succession as a contest to the death*
3	APRIL–DECEMBER	Hitler, imprisoned at Landsberg, composes the first volume of *Mein Kampf*	*Racial "struggle" elevated to a political program*
4	10 MAY	J. Edgar Hoover becomes acting director of the Bureau of Investigation	*The manhunt as a bureaucratic function of the state*
5	21 MAY	Leopold and Loeb murder Bobby Franks in Chicago	*Murder as experiment by self-styled supermen*
6	26 MAY	Johnson–Reed Immigration Act signed into law	*Human "stock" sorted by race science*
7	3 JUNE	Death of Kafka; "Der Bau," written that winter, left unfinished	*The monologue of a creature awaiting its predator*
8	JUNE	E. M. Forster, *A Passage to India*	*A dead man taken for an animal in the colonial night*
9	IN THE COURSE OF THE YEAR	Babel's "My First Goose" first published	*The intellectual's initiation through a kill*
10	IN THE COURSE OF THE YEAR	Patterson sells the Tsavo man-eaters to the Field Museum, Chicago	*The man-eater converted into a museum trophy*
11	NOVEMBER	Thomas Mann, *Der Zauberberg*	*A leisure-class enclave; a duel between ideologues*
12	LATE NOVEMBER	Raymond Dart receives the Taung skull (described in *Nature*, 1925)	*The ancestor as prey*

in 1887, and a founder of the New York Zoological Society. The milieu that codified the ethic of "fair chase" for animals produced the period's most influential taxonomy of human worth.

Zaroff's catalogue of quarry and his judgment that "a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them" are the language of this milieu, spoken without its euphemisms. Stoddard's "Under-Man," the human residue that civilization cannot assimilate, is the general's "scum of the earth." Chapter Two pursues the connection.

Consider next crime. On 21 May, Nathan Leopold and Richard Loeb, gifted sons of wealthy Chicago families, murdered fourteen-year-old Bobby Franks in an attempt at a perfect crime, persuaded—Leopold especially—that their superior intellects placed them beyond ordinary morality in the manner of the Nietzschean *Übermensch*. Clarence Darrow's defense that summer indicted the philosophy rather than the defendants, arguing that they had absorbed from their reading a doctrine they were too young to resist. The case gave the American public a vocabulary for what Zaroff had already embodied in print: murder as an intellectual experiment, conducted for the satisfaction of a superior mind, upon a victim chosen for his availability.

The case passed into Patrick Hamilton's play *Rope* (1929) and Alfred Hitchcock's film (1948), in which a former teacher who had expounded a doctrine of superior men recoils in horror when two of his admirers enact it. The recoil mirrors Rainsford's at the dinner table, when the sportsman who had divided the world into "hunters and huntees" hears his own philosophy spoken back to him in earnest.

Consider the state. In May, J. Edgar Hoover assumed direction of the federal Bureau of Investigation, whose professionalization over the following decade made the manhunt a bureaucratic, scientific, and publicly spectacular function of the American state. Its eventual emblem, the "Ten Most Wanted Fugitives" list of 1950, is a ranked inventory of quarry that converts pursuit into a public game.

Consider literature. In the winter of 1923–24, in Berlin, Kafka wrote "Der Bau," the monologue of a burrowing creature that has built an elaborate fortress against an unseen enemy and whose security is consumed by listening for its approach. He died in June, leaving the story without an ending. It is the purest phenomenology of the hunted in modern literature, written in the months in which Connell's predator went to press.

In the same year Isaac Babel published "My First Goose" (*Moi pervyi gus'*), later collected in *Red Cavalry* (1926). A bespectacled intellectual attached to a Cossack division wins acceptance from the troopers by seizing a goose in the yard of his billet and cracking its head beneath his boot; the Cossacks then invite him to share their meal. The kill admits the man of letters to the community of violence, and the community seals the admission at table—the sequence of Zaroff's island, where the hunt and the dinner are one institution. Babel's narrator and Connell's general even share a gesture. Demonstrating how his reef crushes ships, Zaroff "dropped a walnut on the hardwood floor and brought his heel grinding down on it."

Consider, finally, science and the museum. In 1924, after lecturing at the Field Museum of Natural History in Chicago, John Henry Patterson sold to the museum for five thousand

dollars the skins and skulls of the two lions that had killed workers on the Uganda Railway at Tsavo in 1898; the skins, which had served for a quarter-century as his floor rugs, were reconstructed and mounted for display (B. Patterson 2004). The predators of laborers—many of them indentured workers brought from British India, the class from which Zaroff's "lascars" also came—became trophies, and the trophies became an exhibit. Rainsford's knife-trap, the reader will recall, was "a native trick he had learned in Uganda."

In the last weeks of the year, Raymond Dart, in Johannesburg, received the fossil skull of a juvenile hominin from the lime works at Taung, which he described in *Nature* in February 1925 as *Australopithecus africanus*. Dart later became the most influential advocate of the hypothesis that the human lineage had been forged by predatory violence ("The Predatory Transition from Ape to Man," 1953), and his "killer ape" passed through Robert Ardrey's popularizations into the opening sequence of Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968). Later taphonomic work reached a different conclusion about the Taung Child itself: the damage to the skull is consistent with the talons of a large eagle (Berger and Clarke 1995; Berger 2006). The ancestor discovered in the year of "The Most Dangerous Game" was not a hunter but a quarry.

The constellation does not prove that Connell knew any of this, and it would not matter if he had. Its value is diagnostic. In 1924 the hunt was ceasing to be primarily a sport of empires and becoming a principle of sorting, a model of mind, a function of the state, and a theory of origins. Connell's story, written for a weekly read on commuter trains and in waiting rooms, registered that transition with the sensitivity of a seismograph: an island where a sportsman's metaphor became a social order, and where the question "what is the most dangerous game?" turned out to be a question about what it means to be human.

§ 1.6

Overture at Sea: The Yacht as Philosophical Dialogue

The story opens not with action but with argument, and the argument takes place at sea. The setting inherits one of philosophy's oldest figures. In Book VI of the *Republic*, Plato represents the city as a ship whose owner is larger and stronger than his crew but somewhat deaf and short-sighted, and whose quarrelling sailors, ignorant of navigation, deride the true pilot as a mere stargazer (488a–489a). Connell's yacht preserves the allegory's structure while reversing its emphases. The vessel is driven by an engine, not steered by an art; the darkness is total, so that even the hunter's celebrated eye fails; and the only figure credited with privileged perception is the sailor, whose knowledge Rainsford dismisses as superstition. The ship of state has become a pleasure craft, and the question of who should govern it has been displaced by the question of who may be hunted from it.

The island is introduced by name before it is seen. "The old charts call it 'Ship-Trap Island,'" Whitney says. "A suggestive name, isn't it?" The remark is the story's first act of self-reference.

It announces the allegorical apparatus and solicits the reader's suspicion—and in doing so performs the operation it names. A trap whose name is printed on the chart is still a trap; forewarning belongs to its design, since the knowledge of danger is precisely what draws the hunter. The reader who registers the suggestiveness of the name and reads on is in Rainsford's position: alerted, and therefore all the more securely caught.

The darkness is rendered through a vocabulary of upholstery. It is "palpable," pressing "its thick warm blackness in upon the yacht"; it is "like moist black velvet"; to peer into it is "like trying to see through a blanket"; the sea, earlier, had been "as flat as a plate-glass window." These figures register the perceptual habitus of a leisure class for which even the abyss presents itself as a furnished interior—velvet, blanket, and the plate glass of the department-store vitrine. Benjamin observed that the bourgeois interior of the nineteenth century, with its plush, its covers, and its cases, was an apparatus for preserving the imprints of its inhabitant —"Wohnen heißt Spuren hinterlassen," to dwell means to leave traces—and that the detective story was born in pursuit of those traces ("Paris, die Hauptstadt des XIX. Jahrhunderts," 1935). Rainsford's velvet night belongs to the same order. It is an interior in which traces will be left and read, and from which the next movement of the story, the tracking of a cartridge to a château, follows with the inevitability of a detective plot.

The exchange that follows is a philosophical dialogue in miniature. Whitney: "We should have some good hunting up the Amazon. Great sport, hunting." Rainsford: "The best sport in the world." Whitney: "For the hunter ... Not for the jaguar." The amendment introduces a parallax, a second vantage on the same act, and it is the story's ethical seed. Rainsford's reply —"Don't talk rot, Whitney ... You're a big-game hunter, not a philosopher"—insists on a division of labor between action and reflection that the story will dissolve; within hours the general will describe himself with the words "mine is an analytical mind."

To the question "Who cares how a jaguar feels?" Whitney answers, "Perhaps the jaguar does," attributing to the animal a point of view irreducible to the hunter's—what Thomas Nagel would later call the subjective character of experience, the fact that there is something it is like to be a given creature ("What Is It Like to Be a Bat?", 1974). Rainsford's "Bah! They've no understanding" is the Cartesian rejoinder. Whitney's concession-and-correction—"Even so, I rather think they understand one thing—fear. The fear of pain and the fear of death"—transfers the ground of community from understanding to vulnerability.

Whitney's position deserves more than its customary description as "sympathetic." It is Benthamite in its criterion and Hobbesian in its anthropology. For Hobbes, "the passions that incline men to peace are fear of death," desire of commodious living, and the hope of obtaining it by industry (*Leviathan*, ch. 13). Fear is not reason's opposite but its precondition, the universal passion from which the covenant arises. To say that the jaguar understands fear is to say that it is already, in principle, party to the only covenant that matters—a covenant the hunt violates.

In Hegel's account of lordship and bondage, likewise, it is the bondsman's total fear—the fear of death, "des absoluten Herrn," the absolute lord—that dissolves his attachment to mere

life and opens his path toward self-consciousness (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, §194). The story will put Rainsford through precisely this fear. The question it leaves open, which Chapter Five pursues, is whether the fear makes him a bondsman on the way to freedom or a lord-in-waiting.

Rainsford's rejoinder is a compact ideology. "Nonsense … This hot weather is making you soft, Whitney. Be a realist. The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees. Luckily, you and I are the hunters." Each phrase can be tracked.

"Hot weather is making you soft" draws on the climatic determinism of the period, which held that tropical heat enervated northern constitutions and dissolved their moral firmness—a doctrine given scholarly form in Ellsworth Huntington's *Civilization and Climate* (1915) and medical form in the colonial diagnosis of "tropical neurasthenia." "Be a realist" invokes the oldest argument of the strong against the weak, whose classical statement is the Athenian envoys' reply to the Melians: right, as the world goes, is in question only between equals in power, "while the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must" (Thucydides V.89, trans. Crawley). "Two classes" echoes, with a sportsman's breeziness, the article in which Dostoevsky's Raskolnikov divides humanity into the "ordinary," who must obey, and the "extraordinary," who have the right to step over (*Crime and Punishment*, Part III, ch. 5).

The neologism "huntees" borrows the suffix of the passive party to a legal or commercial instrument—lessee, payee, mortgagee, employee—and so lends the quarry the status of a party to a contract, an anticipation of the general's "option." And "luckily" concedes, perhaps without its speaker's intending it, that the distribution of roles is a matter of fortune rather than nature. Rainsford's social Darwinism contains its own refutation in a single adverb: what luck has assigned, luck can reassign. The story reassigns it by nightfall.

The dialogue's pivot is geographic. "Do you think we've passed that island yet?" The theory is no sooner stated than its proving ground is sought on the horizon, and the conversation turns to the island's reputation. "Cannibals?" Rainsford suggests. The joke carries more weight than its speaker knows. The Caribbean is the etymological birthplace of the word *cannibal*, which entered European languages from Columbus's renderings of the name of the Caribs as reported by the Taíno, and was fixed in the colonial lexicon as the name for the man-eater beyond the pale of civil society (Hulme 1986).

In the waters from which the word came, Rainsford invokes it as a joke; the story's revelation will be that the man-eater on Ship-Trap Island is a European aristocrat who delegates the eating to his dogs. Montaigne had anticipated the inversion in "Des cannibales" (1580): "je pense qu'il y a plus de barbarie à manger un homme vivant qu'à le manger mort"—there is more barbarity in eating a man alive than in eating him dead—and the civilized tormentors of the living are the true barbarians. Whitney's answer completes the topology: "Hardly. Even cannibals wouldn't live in such a God-forsaken place." The island lies beneath savagery, in a zone the colonial imagination cannot assign even to its own constitutive Other. It is a zone of exception.

The sailors know it. Captain Nielsen, "that tough-minded old Swede, who'd go up to the devil himself and ask him for a light," has said only that "This place has an evil name among seafaring men," and then asked, "Don't you feel anything?"—"as if the air about us was actually poisonous." The sailor lore has a documented ancestry. William Strachey's account of the wreck of the *Sea Venture* on Bermuda in 1609, a source of *The Tempest*, reports that the islands were "called commonly the Devil's Islands" and were "feared and avoided of all sea travellers alive above any other place in the world." The reputation attached to an archipelago whose reefs wrecked ships and whose seabirds' nocturnal cries were, by later report, taken for the voices of devils. Ship-Trap Island inherits both: the reef, and the cry in the dark.

The poisonous air invites a historical gloss. Readers in 1924, six years after the Armistice, did not need to be told what air could do, and Connell's own war had been spent editing a camp newspaper titled *Gas Attack*. The war is absent from the yacht's conversation and present in its atmosphere; it surfaces explicitly at the dinner table, when Zaroff appeals to Rainsford's "experiences in the war."

Whitney's "mental chill; a sort of sudden dread," felt on a windless night over a sea like plate glass, is dread in the precise sense that Kierkegaard (*Begrebet Angest*, 1844) and Heidegger (*Sein und Zeit*, §§30, 40) distinguish from fear: an affect without determinate object, disclosing not this or that danger but the uncanniness of a situation as a whole. Rainsford's diagnosis—"One superstitious sailor can taint the whole ship's company with his fear"—is the crowd psychology of Gustave Le Bon (*Psychologie des foules*, 1895), in which affect spreads by contagion.

Whitney's counter-hypothesis is the most remarkable sentence of the overture: "Sometimes I think evil is a tangible thing—with wave lengths, just as sound and light have. An evil place can, so to speak, broadcast vibrations of evil." In 1924 the verb had only recently changed its meaning. To broadcast had been to sow seed by scattering it by hand; in the early 1920s it came to mean transmission by radio to an indiscriminate audience. Whitney's metaphor contains both senses—a sower and a signal—and the story will literalize both. The evil place does broadcast: it emits false lights to lure ships onto its reef. And the hand that sows them belongs to a man.

§ 1.7

The Fall, the Scream, and the Spoor

Left alone on the afterdeck, Rainsford "indolently puffed on his favorite brier." "The sensuous drowsiness of the night was on him. 'It's so dark,' he thought, 'that I could sleep without closing my eyes; the night would be my eyelids—'" The fantasy of sleeping open-eyed is an image of perfect security, in which vigilance and rest become one. It is also an attribute that ancient natural history assigned to the hare, which Pliny reports sleeps with its eyes open (*Naturalis Historia* XI). The hunter imagines himself, unawares, in the posture of his quarry.

The reverie is broken by three shots. "Somewhere, off in the blackness, someone had fired a gun three times." Rainsford's ears, "expert in such matters," classify the sound as hunting. A different convention would classify it otherwise: among woodsmen, three shots are a signal of distress. The story's first acoustic event is thus ambiguous between the hunter's report and the victim's appeal for help, and Rainsford, the expert, hears only the first.

He climbs onto the rail "to get greater elevation"; his pipe, striking a rope, is knocked from his mouth; he lunges for it, loses his balance, and falls. The fall is caused by a reach for comfort —the pipe, emblem of the contemplative leisure Rainsford had just distinguished from "philosophy"—and the elevation sought for vision produces blindness. "The cry was pinched off short as the blood-warm waters of the Caribbean Sea closed over his head."

Three details structure the episode. The first is the sea's temperature. "Blood-warm" makes of the immersion at once a baptism and a bleeding: the water into which the hunter falls is already the medium of the kill. The second is the cry "pinched off short," which is rhymed, a page later, by the scream of the hunted creature "cut short" by a pistol shot. At the level of acoustic pattern the story has identified hunter and quarry before its plot does.

The third is the yacht's indifference. Rainsford shouts, swims, and watches the yacht's lights become "faint and ever-vanishing fireflies" before they are "blotted out entirely by the night." The scene restages the composition of the *Landscape with the Fall of Icarus* attributed to Pieter Bruegel the Elder, in which a ship sails serenely on while a pair of legs disappears into the sea beside it. The vessel of civilization has somewhere to go, and does not stop for the fall of one of its own.

Rainsford orients himself by gunfire. "Rainsford remembered the shots. They had come from the right, and doggedly he swam in that direction." Ashore, he reasons: "Where there are pistol shots, there are men. Where there are men, there is food." The syllogism is the castaway's first act of social theory, and it inverts Hobbes with a precision that is difficult to think accidental. For Hobbes, where there are men without a common power there is war; for Rainsford, the sign of violence is the sign of society, and the report of the gun is the promise of the dinner table. The story will vindicate both propositions at once.

Then comes the sound the story never explains and never forgets. "Rainsford heard a sound. It came out of the darkness, a high screaming sound, the sound of an animal in an extremity of anguish and terror." The next sentence is the hinge of the overture: "He did not recognize the animal that made the sound; he did not try to." The failure is not epistemic—in the dark, Rainsford could not have known whose voice it was—but ethical. He does not *try* to recognize the suffering voice; he uses it as a beacon, and "with fresh vitality he swam toward the sound."

Stanley Cavell's distinction between knowing and acknowledging (1969) is exact here. The problem posed by another's pain is not a deficit of knowledge but a demand for acknowledgment, and Rainsford's refusal to try is a refusal of that demand. The scream is the only testimony the story affords to Zaroff's actual victims—a sailor, presumably, from the wreck of the *San Lucar*—and the hunter-hero classifies it as the noise of an animal.

In the same year, Forster's *A Passage to India* staged a structurally identical misrecognition. A motor car on the Marabar road is struck in the dark by an unseen creature, taken for a hyena or a buffalo, which the Nawab Bahadur privately believes to be the ghost of a man he had run down years before. In both texts the colonial night converts the dead and the dying into animals, and in both the conversion is accomplished by a refusal of attention.

The scream ends with "another noise, crisp, staccato." "Pistol shot," Rainsford mutters, "swimming on." Within minutes he reaches the rocks, hauls himself up a cliff, and, "safe from his enemy, the sea," flings himself down at the jungle's edge and tumbles "headlong into the deepest sleep of his life."

The superlative deserves emphasis, for it has a partner. The story is bracketed by two superlative sleeps: "the deepest sleep of his life," taken on the ground at the margin of the jungle like an exhausted animal, and the final bed, never "a better," taken in the sovereign's chamber after the sovereign's death. The narrative's trajectory runs from ground to bed, from the castaway's sleep to the king's, and the whole of the hunt intervenes as the price of the transition.

The Homeric template is unmistakable. Odysseus, cast ashore on Scheria after his raft is shattered, burrows into a bed of leaves and sleeps until he is found by Nausicaa and led to the house of Alcinous, the paradigm of perfect hospitality (*Odyssey* 5.474–493; Book 6). Connell's castaway sleeps the same sleep and wakes to the same journey toward a great house. But the house, as Chapter Four argues, belongs to the Cyclops rather than to Alcinous, and the guest will leave it only by the host's death.

Waking, Rainsford reads the ground. "Some wounded thing—by the evidence, a large animal—had thrashed about in the underbrush; the jungle weeds were crushed down and the moss was lacerated; one patch of weeds was stained crimson. A small, glittering object not far away caught Rainsford's eye and he picked it up. It was an empty cartridge. 'A twenty-two,' he remarked. 'That's odd. It must have been a fairly large animal too. The hunter had his nerve with him to tackle it with a light gun.'"

The passage is Ginzburg's evidential paradigm in action, and a demonstration of how the paradigm fails. Rainsford's inferences are locally impeccable: from crushed weeds to struggle, from the stain to a wound, from the cartridge to the weapon. He then reconstructs a narrative —"I suppose the first three shots I heard was when the hunter flushed his quarry and wounded it. The last shot was when he trailed it here and finished it"—and in doing so becomes the story's first internal storyteller, the hunter whose tracks have become a tale.

Every step is correct except the category. The anomaly he registers, a small-calibre cartridge for a large animal, is the clue that the quarry was neither large nor an animal in his sense, but a creature whose danger lies elsewhere than in its mass: a human being, killable with a .22, dangerous only because it reasons. Rainsford's ontology admits only animals as game, and so the clue is absorbed as a compliment to the hunter's nerve. Holmes's reproach to Watson —"You see, but you do not observe" ("A Scandal in Bohemia," 1891)—applies to the expert with peculiar force, since it is expertise itself, the habituated classification of evidence, that

produces the blindness. The reader is invited to commit the same error, and most first readers do. The cartridge is the story's *leurre*.

Finally, the trail. Rainsford finds "the print of hunting boots," which point along the cliff "in the direction he had been going," and he follows them. The detail is easily passed over, but it is exact: the tracker tracks the hunter, not the quarry, and therefore arrives not at a carcass but at a house. The hunter's spoor leads home. Following the traces of the predator, Rainsford walks into the predator's interior—which is to say, into the logic of his own inferences, completed.

§ 1.8

The Threshold: Château, Gargoyle, Cossack

Night falls again before Rainsford sees the lights. "His first thought was that he had come upon a village, for there were many lights. But as he forged along he saw to his great astonishment that all the lights were in one enormous building." The misperception compresses a political theory. What appears from a distance as a community—a village, a plurality of households—resolves on approach into a single house that has absorbed the luminous signs of collective life.

Aristotle distinguished the rule of the household (*oikos*), in which the master governs wife, children, and slaves despotically, from the rule of the city (*polis*), in which free equals govern and are governed in turn (*Politics* I). Ship-Trap Island has no polis. It has only an *oikos* swollen to the scale of a world: a household sovereignty that has annexed the forms of public life—lights, dining hall, library, a "training school"—while abolishing the plurality that gives those forms their meaning.

The building is a Gothic set-piece, assembled with the economy of a writer who expected his readers to recognize its components: "a lofty structure with pointed towers plunging upward into the gloom," a "palatial château" on "a high bluff," where on three sides "cliffs dived down to where the sea licked greedy lips in the shadows." The sea's lips anticipate the general's—his smile, a few paragraphs later, shows "red lips and pointed teeth"—so that the island and its master share a mouth.

"'Mirage,' thought Rainsford." But the "tall spiked iron gate," the stone steps, and "the massive door with a leering gargoyle for a knocker" are "real enough; yet above it all hung an air of unreality." Freud, five years earlier, had located the uncanny (*das Unheimliche*) in the return of the familiar in estranged form, and had found the word's semantic history folding *heimlich*—homely, of the house—into its opposite ("Das Unheimliche," 1919). Zaroff's château is the uncanny in the architectural register: a home whose every amenity—soup, champagne, a "very excellent bed"—is a component of a trap. The knocker "creaked up stiffly, as if it had never before been used." No one has knocked here before, because no one arrives at this door by choice. Guests come by wreck.

The door opens "as suddenly as if it were on a spring," and Rainsford stands "blinking in the river of glaring gold light that poured out." The image is the first of the story's two great

lighting effects—the second is the general's switch, flicked on to reveal Rainsford behind the bed curtains—and it encodes a hunting technique. To jacklight is to hunt at night by casting a strong light into an animal's eyes, so that it freezes, dazzled, and is shot where it stands. The sporting codes of the period condemned the method as the antithesis of fair chase, and many American jurisdictions prohibited it by statute. Rainsford is jacklighted on the threshold. The same principle, enlarged to the scale of the sea, governs the false lights by which Zaroff wrecks ships on his reef: the island is a jacklight for vessels.

Out of the light comes "the largest man Rainsford had ever seen—a gigantic creature, solidly made and black bearded to the waist," holding "a long-barreled revolver" pointed "straight at Rainsford's heart." "Out of the snarl of beard two small eyes regarded Rainsford." The servant at the door is the Cyclops at the mouth of the cave: enormous, hirsute, without speech, guarding the threshold of a host who devours his guests.

His uniform is specified with a costumer's precision—"a black uniform trimmed with gray astrakhan"—and the specification rewards attention. Astrakhan is the tightly curled fleece of karakul lambs taken at or shortly after birth. The hunter's servant is trimmed with the skins of the most proverbial of prey animals, and the detail inaugurates a chain of lambs that runs through Nietzsche's parable of the lambs and the birds of prey (*Zur Genealogie der Moral* I.13), La Fontaine's "Le Loup et l'Agneau," and, at the far end of the century, the screaming lambs of Thomas Harris's *The Silence of the Lambs* (1988).

Rainsford introduces himself in the idiom of his class. "Don't be alarmed ... I'm no robber. I fell off a yacht. My name is Sanger Rainsford of New York City." The formula—name, city, the faintly comic "I fell off a yacht"—presents credentials that presuppose a world in which such credentials matter, and they produce no effect: "The menacing look in the eyes did not change." Repeated, the self-introduction degrades: "I'm Sanger Rainsford of New York ... I fell off a yacht. I am hungry." In two utterances the celebrated hunter is reduced from a name to a need.

The giant's only answer is to raise the hammer of his revolver with his thumb—and then, at the sight of a man on the staircase, to salute, click his heels, and stand at attention. The instantaneous conversion of threat into deference discloses the grammar of the household. The servant's violence is an instrument held in suspension by the master's presence, and it will be released by the master's sign.

The master descends "the broad marble steps," "an erect, slender man in evening clothes." He speaks "in a cultivated voice marked by a slight accent that gave it added precision and deliberateness," and his first words are an act of recognition: "It is a very great pleasure and honor to welcome Mr. Sanger Rainsford, the celebrated hunter, to my home ... I've read your book about hunting snow leopards in Tibet, you see."

The recognition is bibliographic. Zaroff knows Rainsford as an author before he knows him as a man, and the relation between them is mediated from the first by the print culture of the hunt—the shelf of memoirs, record books, and travel narratives through which the hunting gentry of several empires constituted themselves as a transnational readership. Bene-

dict Anderson's account of the "imagined community" generated by print capitalism (1983) applies, with a sinister modification, to this fraternity. It is a community imagined through the shared consumption of narratives of killing, whose members recognize one another as authors and readers of the same genre.

The choice of Rainsford's subject is itself significant. The snow leopard of the Tibetan highlands stood at the outer edge of imperial hunting in the 1920s, a trophy from a frontier that British arms had forced open in 1903–04. Half a century later Peter Matthiessen would make the same animal the object of a pilgrimage in which the seeker never sees what he seeks (*The Snow Leopard*, 1978)—the precise inverse of Rainsford's genre, in which the animal is seen in order to be shot.

The general's face is described in two movements. "Rainsford's first impression was that the man was singularly handsome; his second was that there was an original, almost bizarre quality about the general's face." The hair is "a vivid white," but the "thick eyebrows and pointed military mustache" are "as black as the night from which Rainsford had come"; the eyes "black and very bright"; "high cheekbones, a sharp-cut nose, a spare, dark face—the face of a man used to giving orders, the face of an aristocrat."

The portrait is physiognomic in the tradition of Johann Caspar Lavater, but its details also belong to a darker science. Cesare Lombroso's criminal anthropology (*L'uomo delinquente*, 1876) catalogued among the atavistic stigmata of the "born criminal" enormous jaws and high cheekbones, and attributed to him a craving "not only to extinguish life in the victim, but to mutilate the corpse." Zaroff's face fuses the aristocrat's physiognomy with the criminal's—a fusion that Thorstein Veblen had already theorized, without the phrenology, in his argument that the leisure class preserves into the industrial age the archaic traits of predatory barbarism (*The Theory of the Leisure Class*, 1899). The general is made of the night Rainsford came from; his brows are its color. He is the darkness given a face.

The threshold closes on a confession disguised as a pleasantry. "Ivan is an incredibly strong fellow," the general remarks, "but he has the misfortune to be deaf and dumb. A simple fellow, but, I'm afraid, like all his race, a bit of a savage." "Is he Russian?" "He is a Cossack," said the general, and his smile showed red lips and pointed teeth. "So am I."

The smile is Dracula's. Stoker's count, too, received his English guest in an isolated castle with elaborate courtesy, and Jonathan Harker noted the sharpness of his teeth and the "remarkable ruddiness" of his lips. The self-identification is the first explicit avowal of the story's thesis: the civilized host and the "savage" servant are of one race.

The Cossack is, moreover, the Russian counterpart of the American frontiersman: the free warrior of the steppe borderlands, mythologized by Gogol in *Taras Bulba* (1835; revised 1842) and by Tolstoy in *The Cossacks* (1863), and absorbed into the tsarist state as its frontier cavalry and its instrument of domestic repression. Rainsford, whose idiom is that of Roosevelt's strenuous life, and Zaroff, a Crimean landowner who "commanded a division of Cossack cavalry," are mirror images. They are two frontier aristocracies, each of whose frontiers had closed—the American by the census of 1890, as Frederick Jackson Turner announced in 1893;

the Russian by the revolution of 1917—meeting on a Caribbean island to discover what the hunt becomes when there is no frontier left on which to hunt.

The servant's name supplies a final resonance. Ivan, mute and enormous, "once had the honor of serving as official knouter to the Great White Czar." He bears the name of the tsar whose *oprichniki* rode with dogs' heads at their saddles, emblems of their office of hunting down treason, and the name of the Karamazov brother who tells, in the chapter titled "Rebellion," of a Russian general who set his pack of hounds upon a serf child before the eyes of the child's mother. Chapter Two takes up that general.

§ 1.9

Itinerary of the Dissertation

The remaining chapters follow the story from the dinner table to the bed, and outward from the island into the archive.

Chapter Two, "Red in Tooth and Reason," reconstructs the genealogy of the general's philosophy. Beginning from Zaroff's credo—"Life is for the strong, to be lived by the strong, and, if needs be, taken by the strong"—it tracks the argument of the strong through Thucydides and through Aristotle's doctrine that war against men "intended by nature to be governed" is a species of the art of hunting (*Politics* I.8, 1256b); through Hobbes, Sade, and the Darwinian vocabularies of struggle; through T. H. Huxley's comparison of the animal world to "a gladiator's show" and Nietzsche's parable of the lambs and the birds of prey; to Dostoevsky's hounding general and the eugenic science of Grant and Stoddard. It closes by setting Zaroff's criterion of quarry against Descartes, Bentham, and Kant, and against Montaigne's observation that the Romans, once habituated to the slaughter of beasts in the arena, proceeded to men.

Chapter Three, "The Leisure of the Predator," reads the general's ennui—"There is no greater bore than perfection"—through Pascal's analysis of *divertissement*, in which men seek the chase and not the catch; Schopenhauer's pendulum between pain and boredom; Kierkegaard's aesthete; Baudelaire's Ennui, dreaming of scaffolds as he smokes; Chekhov's seagull, destroyed by an idle man for want of anything to do; and Heidegger's 1929–30 lectures on profound boredom and the animal's poverty in world. It relates boredom to capital ("I had invested heavily in American securities") and to the Veblenian economy of the trophy, culminating in a reading of Zaroff's library—where the heads are kept—through Benjamin's dictum on the documents of culture and barbarism, Conrad's Kurtz, and the dioramas of the American Museum of Natural History.

Chapter Four, "Hosts, Hounds, and Heads," assembles the mythic architecture of the hunted guest: Polyphemus and the violation of *xenia* Actaeon devoured by his own hounds, and Giordano Bruno's allegory of the hunter transformed into his quarry; Theseus and the brigands of the Isthmus, among them Sinis the pine-bender; Nimrod, "a mighty hunter before

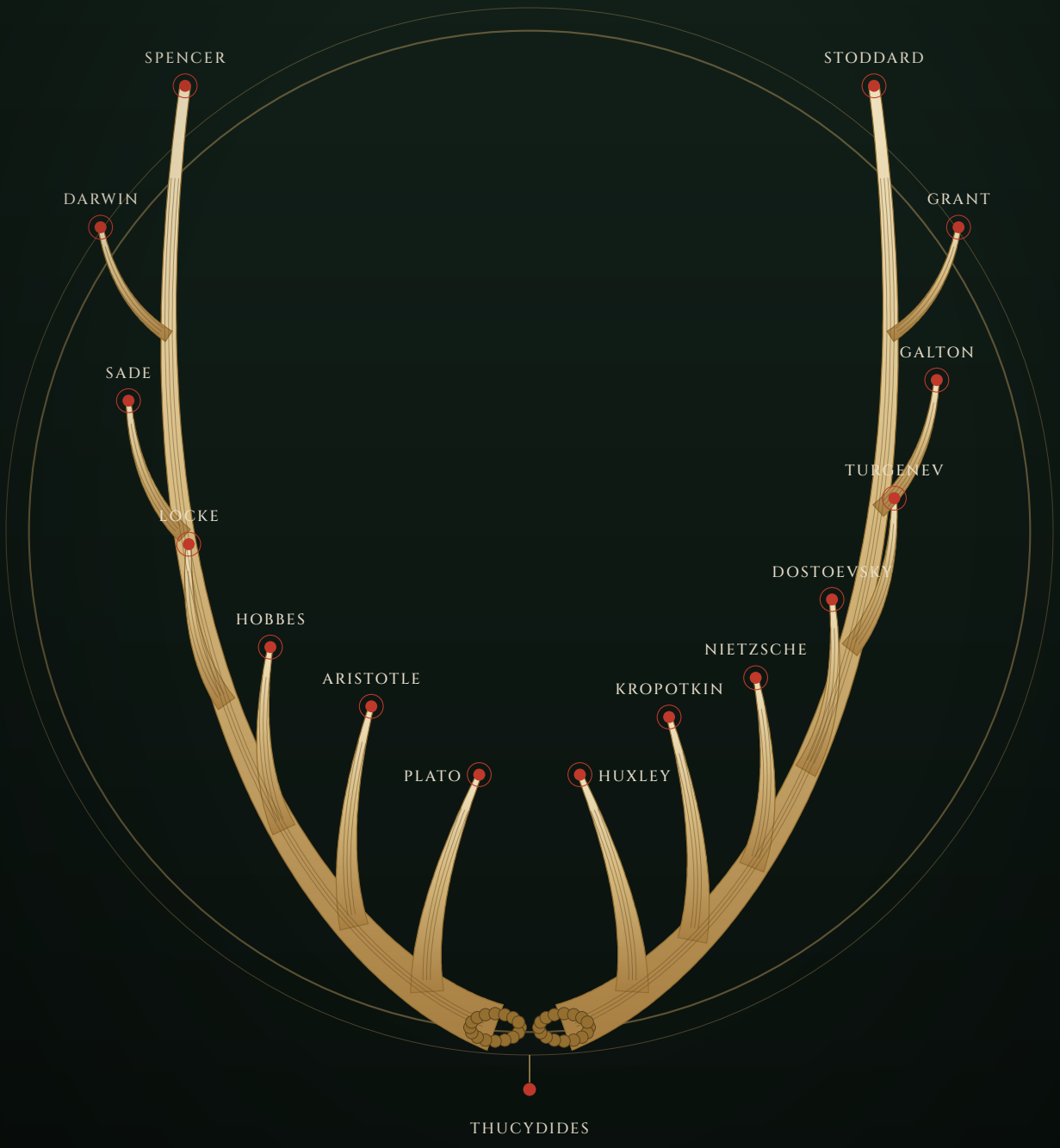
the Lord," read by Augustine as a hunter of men; the three hunts of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* Bluebeard's chamber; Prospero's spirit-hounds; Dracula's castle; the hound Lazarus; and Frazer's King of the Wood.

Chapter Five, "The Rules of the Game," analyzes the hunt as a rule-bound practice: the three-hour start, the three-day term, the "option" of the knout, the "word as a gentleman and a sportsman," the cry of "Outdoor chess!" It draws on Huizinga, Caillois, and Suits; on Hobbes's covenants extorted by fear and Marx's "doubly free" worker; on Hegel's struggle for recognition as read by Kojève; and on the formal theory of pursuit and evasion, from von Neumann's minimax theorem of 1928 to the lion-and-man problem.

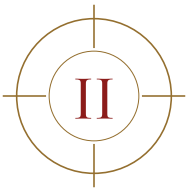
Chapter Six, "Islands of Doctor Zaroff," situates the story among the islands and hunts of speculative fiction—Swift's Houyhnhnms, Defoe's cannibals, Verne's Nemo, Wells's Moreau, Morlocks, and Martians, Conrad's Kurtz, London's Wolf Larsen, Saki's interlopers, Buchan's bored gentlemen in *John Macnab*, Household's *Rogue Male*—and their descendants in Sheckley, Philip K. Dick, Stephen King, Takami, Collins, *Westworld*, *The Promised Neverland*, and *Hunter* × *Hunter*.

Chapter Seven, "From Ship-Trap to Kill Chain," follows the story into the media and machines of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries: the 1932 film and its successors, the Zodiac cipher, the video game, the cybernetic "ontology of the enemy," the mathematics of pursuit, the drones named *Predator* and *Reaper*, and the extraction economies of surveillance.

Chapter Eight, "Homo Venandus," gathers the argument into a venatic theory of the human. It returns to Ginzburg's hunter-reader and to Detienne and Vernant's *mētis* to the Taung Child and the hunted ancestry of the hominin line; to Le Guin's carrier bag; and to Emmanuel Levinas's dog Bobby, who greeted the prisoners of a Nazi camp as men when their guards did not—a counter-figure to the hound Lazarus. It reads the story's terminal ellipsis as the place where the paradigm conceals its mechanism of succession, and argues for a post-venatic ethics that begins not with winning the game but with dismantling the island.



the argument of the strong



CHAPTER TWO

Red in Tooth and Reason

A Genealogy of Predatory Philosophy

§ 2.1

The Symposium of the Strong

The philosophical substance of "The Most Dangerous Game" is delivered at table. Between the borsch and the Turkish coffee the story stages a symposium in the strict sense—a drinking party whose conversation turns on first principles—and Connell furnishes its setting with care. The dining hall has "a medieval magnificence about it"; it suggests "a baronial hall of feudal times with its oaken panels, its high ceiling, its vast refectory tables where twoscore men could sit down to eat." About the walls hang "mounted heads of many animals—lions, tigers, elephants, moose, bears." At the great table the general sits "alone."

Three features of the setting bear on the argument. The first is its feudalism: the hall is baronial, and the sovereignty it houses is that of a lord over a domain, not of a citizen in a city. The second is its monasticism. "Refectory" names a monastery's dining hall, and the château is in more than one respect a monastery of the hunt. Its abbot avows "but one passion," smokes a cigarette that smells "like incense," keeps "pupils" in a cellar, and describes his vocation in the language of election: "God makes some men poets. Some He makes kings, some beggars. Me He made a hunter."

The house's true model is Rabelais's Abbey of Thélème, the anti-monastery of the well-born whose single rule was *Fay ce que vouldras*—do what you will—and whose inmates, among their other pleasures, rode out hawking and hunting (*Gargantua*, 1534, chs. 52–57). Zaroff's "If I wish to hunt, why should I not?" is Thélème's rule rendered as a rhetorical question. The third feature is emptiness. A table built for forty seats one man. The symposium has a single permanent member, and its guests are recruited from the sea.

The general's credo, when it comes, has the cadence of a liturgy: "Life is for the strong, to be lived by the strong, and, if needs be, taken by the strong. The weak of the world were put here

to give the strong pleasure. I am strong. Why should I not use my gift? If I wish to hunt, why should I not? I hunt the scum of the earth: sailors from tramp ships—lascars, blacks, Chinese, whites, mongrels—a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them."

The first sentence is a tricolon of prepositional phrases, and an American reader in 1924 could hardly fail to hear in it the most famous tricolon of the national liturgy: government "of the people, by the people, for the people," pronounced over the graves at Gettysburg in a war fought to decide whether human beings could be owned. The democratic formula is turned inside out. Lincoln's prepositions distribute sovereignty to all; Zaroff's concentrate it in a class, and the third clause—"taken by the strong"—converts the right of government into a right of killing.

The second sentence introduces a teleology. The weak "were put here." The passive voice conceals an agent, and the agent is Providence, whom Zaroff will later claim to "help ... a bit." This is not Darwinism, which removed design from nature, but its reverse: a theodicy of pleasure, in which the existence of the weak is justified by its use to the strong. Aristotle had reasoned that "if nature makes nothing incomplete, and nothing in vain, the inference must be that she has made all animals for the sake of man" (*Politics* I.8, 1256b20–22, trans. Jowett); Zaroff extends the "for the sake of" from animals to the weak of his own species. Hegel had called history the "slaughter-bench" (*Schlachtbank*) on which the happiness of peoples is sacrificed to the ends of Spirit (*Vorlesungen über die Philosophie der Geschichte*, Introduction). Zaroff dispenses with Spirit and keeps the bench.

The third and fourth sentences—"I am strong. Why should I not use my gift?"—borrow the vocabulary of vocation. "Gift" is talent in its scriptural sense, and the parable of the talents (Matthew 25:14–30) condemns the servant who buries his gift rather than putting it to use. Max Weber had shown how the Protestant concept of the calling (*Beruf*) sanctified worldly activity as the fulfilment of a divine assignment (*Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus*, 1904–05). Zaroff's calling is aristocratic rather than Puritan, but its structure is the same. The hunt is not merely his pleasure but his duty, and to refuse it would be a sin against the gift.

The final sentence names the quarry, and its key phrase has a double pedigree. "The scum of the earth" is the Duke of Wellington's description of the rank and file who won his battles —"We have in the service the scum of the earth as common soldiers," he wrote in 1813—and it is the aristocratic officer's word for the men he commands and spends.

Its deeper ancestor is Pauline. In 1 Corinthians 4:13 the apostle describes himself and his companions as *perikatharmata*, the offscourings of the world. The Greek named the refuse of purification and, in the cults of the Ionian cities, the human scapegoats—the *pharmakoi* —whose expulsion or death cleansed the community. Paul's revaluation turned the scapegoat into the elect. Zaroff reverses the revaluation. His "scum" are chosen, as René Girard argued scapegoats are always chosen, from the margins of the social body—foreigners, the poor, the mixed (*La violence et le sacré*, 1972). Yet they are killed without sacral meaning: not to purify

a community, since there is none, but to entertain a man. That is the formula of *homo sacer*, killable without sacrifice, completed by the surplus of sport.

Rainsford's response is the story's moral pivot: "But they are men." The general's reply is its philosophical one: "Precisely. That is why I use them. It gives me pleasure. They can reason, after a fashion. So they are dangerous." In five short sentences Zaroff concedes the humanity of his quarry and converts it into the qualification for the hunt. The rest of this chapter tracks the lineage of each move—teleology, vocation, hierarchy, the right of the strong, the criterion of reason—to show that none is the general's invention. His originality lies only in their combination, and in his willingness to act.

§ 2.2

The Art of Acquisition: Plato, Aristotle, and the Hunting of Men

Zaroff believes he has "invented a new sensation." The Greeks had already classified it. In Plato's *Sophist*, the Eleatic Stranger demonstrates the method of division on the humble figure of the angler, locating him among the acquisitive arts, then within hunting (*thēreutikē*), then within the hunting of creatures that live in water (218e–221c). The demonstration rehearses the real inquiry, and when the Stranger turns to the sophist he finds him on the same tree: among the hunters of land animals, of tame animals, and of the tamest animal of all, man (221c–223b). The hunting of men, he explains, divides into a violent branch—piracy, kidnapping, tyranny, war—and a persuasive one, which includes oratory, courtship, and the sophist's art of hunting rich and well-born young men for a fee.

The taxonomy illuminates the dinner table. Zaroff hunts Rainsford twice. He hunts him first by persuasion—flattery, champagne, a philosophy offered as a gift, the invitation "We will have some capital hunting, you and I"—in the hope of acquiring a companion. Only when persuasion fails does he pass to the violent branch. The general is a sophist before he is a tyrant, and the order is significant: the story's first hunt is a conversation, and Rainsford is quarry from the moment he sits down to eat.

Xenophon's *Cynegeticus*, the oldest surviving Greek treatise on hunting, approaches the connection from the other side. It praises the chase as an education in endurance and courage, a training for war and for virtue, and it closes by contrasting the hunter, who pursues animals, with the sophist, who hunts the rich and the young (ch. 13). The Greek discourse of hunting recognized from its beginnings that its central metaphor could be turned on human beings, and set itself the task of policing the line.

Plato's *Laws* polices it by legislation. The Athenian Stranger observes that "hunting" names a great variety of practices, including many kinds of hunting of men, in war and in friendship, some praiseworthy and some not (VII, 822d–824a). He forbids the young the fishing that

relies on nets and weirs and the night-hunting of land animals with snares and traps, as the pursuits of idle and unmanly souls. He reserves honour for the hunting of four-footed beasts with horses, hounds, and spears, in which the hunter exposes his own body.

The hierarchy maps onto Connell's story with uncanny exactness. Zaroff, with his hounds, his pursuit on foot, and his self-imposed handicap, practises the noble hunt of the *Laws*. Rainsford survives by the servile arts that Plato excludes: the snare, the pit, the concealed blade, the night. The quarry's intelligence is, in the Greek scheme, a low intelligence—*mētis*, the cunning of the weak—and the story's sympathy lies, against the Platonic hierarchy, with the trapper.

Aristotle completes the classical doctrine by placing the hunt at the foundation of the economy. Nature, he argues, has made plants for the sake of animals and animals for the sake of man. "And so, in one point of view, the art of war is a natural art of acquisition, for the art of acquisition includes hunting, an art which we ought to practise against wild beasts, and against men who, though intended by nature to be governed, will not submit; for war of such a kind is naturally just" (*Politics* I.8, 1256b23–26, trans. Jowett).

The sentence is the charter of the venatic paradigm. It inserts the hunting of men into the definition of the natural economy, and it makes the criterion of huntability a defect of the rational faculty. The natural slave, Aristotle had argued, is one who "participates in rational principle enough to apprehend, but not to have, such a principle" (I.5, 1254b22–23). Zaroff's captives, who "can reason, after a fashion," occupy exactly the Aristotelian position.

Sparta institutionalized the doctrine. Plutarch, drawing on Aristotle's lost *Constitution of the Lacedaemonians*, describes the *krypteia*: the magistrates sent the most discreet of the young warriors into the countryside, "equipped only with daggers and such supplies as were necessary," and by night they killed every helot they caught (*Lycurgus* 28, trans. Perrin). Plutarch adds the detail that unlocks Zaroff's legalism. On entering office, the ephors "made formal declaration of war upon the Helots, in order that there might be no impiety in slaying them." The declaration converts murder into lawful killing by fiat, and its annual repetition shows that its purpose was not strategic but juridical and religious.

Zaroff's rules perform the same operation. "I assure you I do not do the thing you suggest. That would be barbarous," he tells Rainsford, who has accused him of shooting down men. What he does is a game, with a start, a term, and a prize. The rules are the general's declaration of war upon the helots; they remove what he calls "that unpleasant word."

One inversion deserves notice. In the *krypteia* the hunters carry the daggers and provisions. On Ship-Trap Island it is the quarry who receives "a supply of food and an excellent hunting knife." The Spartan youth's equipment has passed to the helot, and the transfer marks the difference between an institution of terror and a sport. The terror required only that the helot die. The sport requires that he resist.

The Aristotelian charter had a second life in the conquest of the Americas. At Valladolid in 1550–51, Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda invoked the doctrine of natural slavery to argue that war against the peoples of the New World was just, and Bartolomé de las Casas answered him. Las

Casas's *Brevísima relación de la destrucción de las Indias* (1552) had recorded the conquerors' practice of hunting men with dogs bred and trained for the purpose, and their wagers on who could cleave a man in two, or strike off his head, with a single blow. The wager is the sporting proposition in its colonial form, and the dogs are the ancestors of Zaroff's pack. Chapter Four will meet them by name.

§ 2.3

Wolf's Head: Hobbes, Locke, and the Outlaw

The Latin tag that has come to stand for Hobbes's anthropology began as a line of comedy about strangers. In Plautus's *Asinaria*, a merchant declines to trust a man he does not know: "lupus est homo homini, non homo, quom qualis sit non novit"—a man is a wolf, not a man, to a man who does not know what sort he is (line 495). The wolf in Plautus is the unknown guest, and the cure for lupinity is acquaintance, which is why the ancient institutions of hospitality labored to turn strangers into known men. The general, it should be noted, knows his guest before he meets him; he has read his book. Acquaintance, on Ship-Trap Island, does not cure the wolf. It selects the prey.

Hobbes generalized the tag. In the dedication of *De Cive* (1642) he wrote that both sayings are true—*Homo homini Deus, et Homo homini Lupus*—man is a god to man within the commonwealth and a wolf without it. *Leviathan* (1651) gave the wolfish condition its canonical description: a war "of every man against every man," without industry, arts, letters, or society, in which "the life of man" is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (ch. 13).

Ship-Trap Island is a Hobbesian space in miniature, with a decisive alteration. It has a common power—Zaroff—but the common power does not end the war; it organizes it. The sovereign of Hobbes's covenant secures peace by holding all in awe. The sovereign of the island holds all in awe in order to resume the war at his pleasure, under controlled conditions.

Hobbes noticed the possibility. "Covenants entered into by fear, in the condition of mere nature, are obligatory," he wrote: "if I covenant to pay a ransom, or service for my life, to an enemy, I am bound by it" (ch. 14). The captives' "choice" of the hunt over Ivan's knout is a covenant extorted by fear, and Zaroff's "Invariably, Mr. Rainsford, invariably they choose the hunt" is the voice of a sovereign who has learned that consent can be manufactured by the terms of the alternative. Chapter Five returns to this contract.

Locke, the philosopher of limited government, made a still more consequential provision. In the state of nature, he argued, the murderer "hath, by the unjust violence and slaughter he hath committed upon one, declared war against all mankind; and therefore may be destroyed as a lion or a tiger, one of those wild savage beasts, with whom men can have no society nor security" (*Second Treatise of Government*, §11). Again: one may kill a man who makes war upon one "for the same reason that he may kill a wolf or a lion; because such men are not under

the ties of the common law of reason, have no other rule, but that of force and violence, and so may be treated as beasts of prey, those dangerous and noxious creatures" (§16).

Locke's provision is the liberal tradition's hunting license. It makes the human who has abandoned reason into a beast of prey, killable by anyone, and it does so in reason's name. Zaroff's doctrine is its exact chiasmus. For Locke, the man who forfeits reason may be hunted; for Zaroff, the man who possesses reason is worth hunting. The two positions share a premise —that reason decides the question of huntability—and differ only on which side of reason the hunting ground lies.

Medieval law had given the Lockean beast a juridical name. The outlaw, in the formula preserved by Bracton, "bears a wolf's head" (*caput gerit lupinum*) and may be killed by anyone without judicial inquiry; Germanic law called him *wargus*, the wolf-man. Agamben made this figure central to his account of sovereignty, reading the wolf's head as the zone of indistinction between beast and man, *physis* and *nomos*, into which the sovereign ban casts its subject (*Homo Sacer*, 1995, Part II).

Connell relocates the wolf's head to the sea. Zaroff's victims are "sailors from tramp ships," and the choice is precise. The tramp steamer, sailing without fixed route or schedule, was the lowest rung of the merchant marine; its crews, often signed on in colonial ports under inferior articles, were among the least protected workers of the global economy. The lascar—the South Asian seaman of British and other European shipping—stood near the bottom of that order. Wrecked on a private island, such men belong to no state that will ask after them. They are outlaws by circumstance, wolf's heads without a crime.

The sea had long supplied the law of nations with its model outlaw. Cicero called the pirate "the common enemy of all" (*communis hostis omnium*, *De officiis* III.107), the formula from which early modern jurists derived the pirate's status as *hostis humani generis*, an enemy of the human race whom any state might seize. Zaroff reverses the attribution in practice while keeping it in form. The enemy of mankind on Ship-Trap Island is the master of the château; the sailors are treated as though they were the pirates.

"Tramp" carries a terrestrial echo as well. In the United States of the 1870s the word came to name the itinerant, unemployed laborer whom vagrancy laws exposed to arrest, forced labor, and the posse. Marx had identified the "bloody legislation against the expropriated"—the Tudor and Stuart statutes that whipped, branded, enslaved, and hanged vagabonds—as an instrument of primitive accumulation (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 28). The hunting of the poor is among the oldest of the manhunts Chamayou reconstructs, and Zaroff's tramps are its maritime heirs.

One American institution deserves particular notice, since it lay within living memory in 1924. The Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 converted the free states into a hunting ground for those who had escaped slavery and obliged citizens to assist the hunters. The slave-catcher's hounds became so emblematic of the system that the touring stage versions of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*—the "Tom shows," still playing to American audiences in the 1920s—added bloodhounds to

Eliza's flight across the ice, an episode in which Stowe's novel has none. Solomon Northup's *Twelve Years a Slave* (1853) records his own flight from dogs through the swamps of Louisiana.

When Zaroff warns Rainsford away from "Death Swamp," and when Rainsford, with the pack behind him, learns "how an animal at bay feels," Connell's white American hero is placed, for three days, in a position that American law had assigned within the previous century to millions of Black Americans. The story does not say so. The venatic paradigm does not need it to.

§ 2.4

The Château of Silling: Sade's Naturalism of Destruction

If Zaroff has a direct ancestor among the philosophers, it is the marquis who wrote philosophy as fiction and fiction as philosophy. In 1785, imprisoned in the Bastille, Sade composed *Les 120 Journées de Sodome*, a manuscript he believed destroyed when the fortress was stormed and which was published only in 1904. Its setting is the château of Silling, deep in the Black Forest, reached by a single bridge that is cut once the company has entered and enclosed by passes that winter will seal. Within it four libertines—a duke, a bishop, a president of the *parlement*, and a financier—hold absolute power over victims procured by their agents and subjected, under a written code of *règlements*, to a graduated program that culminates in murder.

The correspondences with Connell's island are architectural before they are moral. The château is inaccessible except by wreck: the sea does for Zaroff what the cut bridge does for Sade's libertines. The victims are procured—Zaroff "help[s] Providence a bit"—and held in a "training school" in the cellar. Everything proceeds by rule. And the four estates of Sade's libertine college—nobility, church, law, and money—are gathered in Zaroff's single person. He is a general and a noble; he speaks of God's design and of Providence; he legislates his own code; and he lives on "American securities." Silling is a *summa* of the old regime's powers turned upon bodies. Ship-Trap Island condenses that *summa* into one man.

The philosophy that underwrites Silling is a naturalism of destruction. In *La Philosophie dans le boudoir* (1795), the libertine Dolmancé instructs his pupil that "la cruauté, bien loin d'être un vice, est le premier sentiment qu'imprime en nous la nature"—cruelty, far from being a vice, is the first sentiment that Nature imprints in us—and that it is nothing but the energy of man not yet corrupted by civilization. Since destruction is among Nature's first laws, nothing that destroys can be a crime.

Zaroff's credo is Sade's naturalism with the eroticism removed. What the story subtracts is significant. Ship-Trap Island is conspicuously sexless; there are no women on it, and the general's pleasure is agonistic and aesthetic rather than erotic. The 1932 film would restore what Connell had removed, adding a woman (Fay Wray's Eve Trowbridge) to the island's population and giving its Zaroff the formula "Kill, then love!" Hollywood, in other words, re-Sadeanized Connell. Chapter Seven considers what the restoration reveals.

The twentieth century's most searching readings of Sade bear directly on the story's thesis about reason. Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno, in the second excursus of *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944/1947), read Sade's *Juliette* alongside Kant and Nietzsche as a demonstration that formal, instrumental reason—reason as the calculation of means—can supply no fundamental argument against murder. Sade and Nietzsche were, for them, the "dark" writers of the bourgeoisie, who declined to conceal the consequence that the moralists covered with sentiment.

On this reading, Zaroff's "mine is an analytical mind" and "Instinct is no match for reason" are not incidental traits of character but the heart of the matter. His hunt is reason purged of every end but its own exercise. It needs no justification beyond the facts that it is possible and that it pleases.

Albert Camus, in *L'Homme révolté* (1951), saw in Sade's walled castles—where the absolute liberty of a few was purchased with the total servitude of the rest—an anticipation of the closed societies of the twentieth century. Pier Paolo Pasolini made the anticipation literal by setting *Salò o le 120 giornate di Sodoma* (1975) in the Nazi client republic of 1944. And Georges Bataille, in *L'Érotisme* (1957), described the Sadean "sovereign man" as one who denies his fellow beings any reality except as objects of his own sovereignty.

Zaroff stands at an instructive distance from this lineage. Sade's libertines need no one's agreement; their dissertations, delivered to victims and accomplices, are lessons, not appeals. Zaroff wants Rainsford's assent. He argues, cajoles, and appeals to Rainsford's war, his education, his modernity; he proposes to "show you that your scruples are quite ill founded." The Sadean sovereign denies the reality of others. Zaroff requires the recognition of at least one other—an equal, a hunter, a reader of the same books.

The difference is the opening through which the Hegelian dialectic of recognition, examined in Chapter Five, enters the story. A sovereign who needs to be recognized has already conceded that he is not sufficient to himself. The château of Silling has no guest room. Zaroff's château is built around one.

§ 2.5

Red in Tooth and Claw: Darwin, Spencer, Huxley, Kropotkin

The phrase that has come to stand for the Darwinian picture of nature predates Darwin's book by nine years. In canto LVI of *In Memoriam A. H. H.* (1850), Tennyson set man, "Who trusted God was love indeed / And love Creation's final law," against a Nature "red in tooth and claw / With ravine," which "shriek'd against his creed." The image was not a scientific proposition but a theological wound. Its persistence into the age of Darwin shows how readily the theory of natural selection was absorbed into an existing iconography of carnage.

Darwin borrowed "the struggle for existence" from Malthus and, in the fifth edition of the *Origin* (1869), adopted Herbert Spencer's "survival of the fittest," coined in Spencer's

Principles of Biology (1864). Neither phrase originally meant what the twentieth century took it to mean. Fitness was reproductive success relative to an environment, not strength, ferocity, or rank, and the struggle was as often against drought as against a rival. But the vocabulary invited a social translation that its authors did not always resist.

In *The Descent of Man* (1871), Darwin forecast that "at some future period, not very distant as measured by centuries, the civilised races of man will almost certainly exterminate, and replace, the savage races throughout the world" (ch. 6). The sentence is a prediction, not a recommendation, and Darwin elsewhere made sympathy the crowning product of the social instincts. Yet the prediction supplied a naturalistic alibi for the colonial violence it described. It is worth adding that Darwin's *Autobiography* records a youthful passion for shooting so intense that he kept a tally of the birds he killed on a knotted string at his buttonhole. The naturalist began as a sportsman.

The social translation flourished in the United States. William Graham Sumner's *What Social Classes Owe to Each Other* (1883) denied that the weak had any claim upon the strong. Andrew Carnegie's "Wealth" (1889) conceded that the law of competition might be hard on the individual but held it "best for the race, because it insures the survival of the fittest in every department." Richard Hofstadter's *Social Darwinism in American Thought* (1944) fixed the label, and later historians have argued that it was more often an epithet hurled at opponents than a doctrine anyone professed. The qualification matters, but it does not touch Rainsford, who professes the doctrine without embarrassment: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees."

The most penetrating Victorian answer came from Darwin's own champion. In "The Struggle for Existence in Human Society" (1888), Thomas Henry Huxley wrote: "From the point of view of the moralist the animal world is on about the same level as a gladiator's show. The creatures are fairly well treated, and set to fight—whereby the strongest, the swiftest, and the cunningest live to fight another day. The spectator has no need to turn his thumbs down, as no quarter is given."

The passage could serve as an epigraph to Zaroff's island. The creatures are "fairly well treated": "They get plenty of good food and exercise. They get into splendid physical condition." They are "set to fight," with knife, provisions, and a head start. The strongest, swiftest, and cunningest survive another day, until the third. And no quarter is given. Huxley's figure was meant as an indictment of nature from the standpoint of ethics; Zaroff reads it as a program.

In the Romanes Lecture of 1893, "Evolution and Ethics," Huxley drew the conclusion Zaroff refuses: "the ethical progress of society depends, not on imitating the cosmic process, still less in running away from it, but in combating it." Whitney's "For the hunter … Not for the jaguar" is the Huxleyan correction compressed into an amendment: ethics as the refusal to take the cosmic process as a model.

The 1888 essay provoked a still more radical reply, and the identity of its author makes it indispensable to a reading of Connell's story. Prince Peter Kropotkin, born into the high

Russian nobility and educated in the elite Corps of Pages, chose in 1862 to serve with a Cossack regiment in eastern Siberia. His years of travel and observation there convinced him that the decisive factor in the survival of species was cooperation rather than competition. Huxley's essay moved him to write the articles that became *Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution* (1902), which argued that the fittest are, in the main, the animals and societies that have best developed habits of mutual support. Kropotkin renounced his title, became the most celebrated anarchist of his age, returned to revolutionary Russia in 1917, and died there in 1921, three years before Connell's story appeared.

The antithesis is exact enough to seem designed. Two Russian aristocrats, both formed in the service of Cossack cavalry, both travelers and voracious readers, both possessed of what Zaroff calls "an analytical mind," drew opposite conclusions from the spectacle of nature. Kropotkin read in it the law of mutual aid and gave away his privilege. Zaroff read in it the law of predation and invested his privilege in American securities. The revolution Kropotkin welcomed was the "debacle" from which Zaroff fled.

Whether or not Connell intended the pairing, the intellectual history of the decades before 1924 makes it available, and it clarifies what the story's naturalism conceals. Nature did not teach Zaroff that life is for the strong. He brought the lesson to nature and found it there, as Kropotkin brought another lesson and found that.

§ 2.6

The Lambs and the Birds of Prey: Nietzsche and His American Double

No philosopher is more often invoked in discussions of Zaroff, and none is more often misrepresented by the invocation. The general is not a Nietzschean in any sense Nietzsche would have recognized. He is a Nietzschean in the sense the American public of 1924 had been taught to recognize: the sense in which, that summer, Clarence Darrow could ask a Chicago court whether a young man who had taken Nietzsche seriously and shaped his life by him should hang for it. The distinction between the two Nietzsches is not pedantic. It is the key to what the story borrows from, and betrays in, the philosophy of the strong.

From the first essay of *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887), Zaroff borrows the typology. Nietzsche distinguishes a "master morality," in which the noble, powerful, and healthy name themselves "good" and the common and low "bad," from a "slave morality" born of *ressentiment*, in which the weak rename the strong "evil" and themselves "good" (I.10–11). Among the masters he describes the splendid "blond beast" that roams, lusting after booty and victory (I.11)—a figure that has suffered more abuse than any other in his work, and that names a type, not a race.

He gives the typology its most memorable figure in a parable about prey. "Dass die Lämmer den grossen Raubvögeln gram sind, das befremdet nicht": that lambs bear a grudge against great birds of prey is not strange, but it is no reason to blame the great birds of prey for carrying off little lambs. The lambs say among themselves that the birds of prey are evil. The birds of prey, Nietzsche imagines, look on with a little mockery and reply: we bear them no grudge at all, these good lambs; we even love them; nothing is tastier than a tender lamb (I.13).

The parable is Zaroff's entire attitude toward his quarry. He "loved Lazarus," his hound; he speaks of his captives with the connoisseur's affection for a good specimen and the connoisseur's regret at "a very inferior lot." His good humor in the face of Rainsford's outrage —"Dear me, what a righteous young man you are!"—is the bird's mockery of the lamb's morality. Rainsford's "murder" is, in Nietzsche's terms, the lamb's word for the bird's nature.

From *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886), Zaroff borrows a definition of life: "Leben selbst ist wesentlich Aneignung, Verletzung, Überwältigung des Fremden und Schwächeren"—life itself is essentially appropriation, injury, the overpowering of what is alien and weaker, suppression, hardness, the imposition of one's own forms, incorporation, and at the least, at its mildest, exploitation (§259). From the same book he borrows the "pathos of distance" (§257), the felt difference of rank on which every elevation of the type "man" is said to depend: the distance between the château and the cellar, the thoroughbred and the mongrel.

From *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882), he borrows the imperative. The secret for harvesting from existence the greatest fruitfulness and the greatest enjoyment, Nietzsche writes, is "gefährlich leben!"—to live dangerously (§283). "I live for danger, Mr. Rainsford," the general says, and the adjective of the story's title is Nietzsche's. The same aphorism urges the seekers of knowledge to send their ships into uncharted seas and to be "Räuber und Eroberer," robbers and conquerors, so long as they cannot be rulers and possessors. Chapter Three sets that phrase beside a passage of Marcus Aurelius, read by Zaroff on the story's last night, in which the hunters of men are called robbers.

From *Götzen-Dämmerung* (1889), finally, he might have borrowed his self-understanding as a criminal. "Der Verbrecher-Typus, das ist der Typus des starken Menschen unter ungünstigen Bedingungen"—the criminal type is the type of the strong human being under unfavorable conditions, a strong human being made sick ("Streifzüge eines Unzeitgemässen," §45). In the same aphorism Nietzsche names Dostoevsky as the only psychologist from whom he had something to learn. The aphorism is the hinge between this section and the next, and it fits Zaroff's situation precisely. The revolution made his conditions unfavorable. The strong man without his estates became a criminal on an island.

Napoleon presides over this lineage. Nietzsche called him "diese Synthesis von Unmensch und Übermensch," this synthesis of the inhuman and the superhuman (*Genealogie* I.16). Raskolnikov took him as the model of the extraordinary man who has the right to step over blood. And on the night after the hunt, Zaroff dines with "a bottle of Pol Roger and half a bottle of Chambertin." Chambertin was Napoleon's wine, the burgundy he is reported to have drunk on campaign, diluted with water. The detail is the kind a reader passes over and

a connoisseur does not: the general toasts what he believes to be his victory in the Emperor's vintage.

A resonance may be recorded without being pressed. In the prologue of *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883), man is "ein Seil, geknüpft zwischen Thier und Übermensch,—ein Seil über einem Abgrunde": a rope stretched between beast and superman, a rope over an abyss (§4). Rainsford enters the story's abyss when his pipe, "striking a rope," is knocked from his mouth.

What, then, separates Zaroff from Nietzsche? The answer lies in the parable he so nearly enacts. Nietzsche's birds of prey do not argue with lambs. They are indifferent to the lambs' morality, and their mockery is a by-product of their nature, not an attempt to win the lambs' assent. Zaroff argues. He spends an evening attempting to persuade a single lamb—an educated, American, war-veteran lamb—that its morality is "mid-Victorian," "naïve," "romantic," and that, properly enlightened, it will come to share the bird's pleasure.

A bird of prey that needs a lamb's agreement has already been infected by the morality it claims to transcend: it has made the lamb a judge. The general's Nietzscheanism is a slave morality in master's evening clothes. His predicament, if he has one, is that the only recognition that would satisfy him is the one his hunt destroys.

The American Nietzsche through which Zaroff was legible in 1924 had been assembled from H. L. Mencken's *The Philosophy of Friedrich Nietzsche* (1908), from the superman-captains of Jack London's fiction—above all Wolf Larsen of *The Sea-Wolf* (1904), whom London later insisted he had intended as a critique of the type—and from the newspapers' coverage of the Leopold and Loeb case. In that version, Nietzsche taught that the strong may do as they please to the weak. Zaroff is that version incarnate. The story's achievement is to show, through the general's evident need for Rainsford's assent, that the popular version fails even on its own terms.

§ 2.7

A Trembling Creature: Dostoevsky, Turgenev, and the Hounds

Raskolnikov's article, as the investigator Porfiry Petrovich summarizes it in *Crime and Punishment* (1866), divides humanity into two categories (Part III, ch. 5). The "ordinary" are material, existing to reproduce their kind and to obey. The "extraordinary"—a Lycurgus, a Solon, a Mahomet, a Napoleon—have the right, not an official right but an inner one, to permit their conscience to step over (*perestupit'*) certain obstacles, blood among them, if their idea requires it. The Russian word for crime, *prestuplenie*, is built on the same verb: a crime is a stepping-across. Rainsford's "two classes" is Raskolnikov's article stripped of its metaphysics and made genial. Zaroff's credo is the article put into practice without the idea that, in Raskolnikov's version, was to justify the blood. The general's idea is his own amusement.

The novel's most famous formulation of the doctrine is a question, and its terms are venatic. "Тварь ли я дрожащая или право имею?"—am I a trembling creature, or have I the right? (Part V, ch. 4). The Russian *tvar'* is the creature in its creatureliness, close to "beast"; the trembling creature is the creature that fears. Raskolnikov's alternative is Rainsford's—huntee or hunter—restated in the language of right, and the attribute that marks the quarry is the one Whitney named on the yacht: fear. To tremble is to be prey; to have the right is to hunt. On the third day of the hunt Rainsford, crouching as the pack approaches, discovers which he is. On the third night he discovers, or decides, that he is the other.

Dostoevsky's last novel contains a scene that reads like the general's biography written in advance. In the chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879–80) titled "Rebellion" (Book V, ch. 4), Ivan Karamazov assembles for his brother Alyosha an indictment of a world that permits the suffering of children. Its culminating case is a story from the early part of the century. A retired general, a great landowner with hundreds of hounds and nearly a hundred huntsmen, learns that an eight-year-old serf boy, playing, has thrown a stone that lamed the paw of his favorite hound. He has the boy locked up overnight. In the morning, before the assembled household and the boy's mother, he has the child stripped and made to run, and sets the whole pack on him. The hounds tear the boy to pieces before his mother's eyes.

The parallels need little emphasis: a Russian general, his hounds, a human being made to run so that he may be hunted, a hound preferred to the life of a serf. Zaroff's "a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them" is that general's logic stated as a maxim. Zaroff's grief for Lazarus, "the finest hound in my pack," lost in the quicksand of Death Swamp while pursuing a man, is that general's rage over a lamed paw, refined into sentiment.

Ivan's question to his brother is what such a general deserves. "Shoot him?" Alyosha, the novice and the saint of the novel, answers with a pale and twisted smile: "Shoot him!"—*Rasstrelyat'!* Ivan's delight—"Bravo!"—is the delight of a man who has found the demon in a monk.

The scene supplies the ethics of Connell's ending. The story gives the reader what Alyosha asked for. Zaroff dies, the hounds eat, and the reader's satisfaction is the satisfaction Ivan drew from Alyosha: the hunter of men deserves to be killed, and the killing is just. But Ivan's purpose in eliciting the verdict was to show that retribution does not redeem the world; it adds a second killing to the first. The Nemorensian loop is Dostoevsky's insight in structural form. The reader who relishes the final bed has said "Shoot him!" and, like Alyosha, has been caught.

The servant's name may now be read in full. Ivan Karamazov is the brother of the rebellion, the man of reason to whom others attribute the formula that if there is no God, everything is permitted. Zaroff's Ivan has no speech at all. He is reason's mute instrument, the giant who executes what the analytical mind conceives, as the lackey Smerdyakov executes what Ivan Karamazov has thought. The relation between the master's philosophy and the servant's hands is the central moral problem of Dostoevsky's novel. Connell reduces it to a single figure who can neither hear nor speak.

That figure has a Russian prototype more exact than any in Dostoevsky. Turgenev's "Mumu" (1854) concerns Gerasim, a serf of enormous size and strength, deaf and dumb from birth, who serves as yardman in the Moscow house of a capricious widow. Gerasim loves a little dog he has rescued from drowning. His mistress, irritated by its barking, orders it removed, and Gerasim himself rows out on the river and drowns it. Then he walks back to his village, leaving her service without a word. Ivan is Gerasim without the departure: the mute giant compelled to kill at his owner's command who never walks away. He dies on the knife Rainsford ties to a sapling, still holding the hounds in leash for his master.

Turgenev had begun his career with the book that made the Russian hunt a moral instrument. In *Zapiski okhotnika* (*A Sportsman's Sketches*, 1847–52), a hunter-narrator wanders the countryside with gun and dog, and his encounters with serfs, recorded with unsentimental exactness, disclosed their humanity to a reading public that had treated them as property; the book has long been credited with shaping the climate of opinion in which serfdom was abolished in 1861. Tolstoy gave the gentry's hound-hunt its ecstatic monument in the wolf hunt of *War and Peace* (1865–69); he was nearly killed by a bear in 1858, and in later life renounced hunting and wrote against the slaughter of animals ("The First Step," 1892). And Babel, as Chapter One noted, gave the Cossack world its initiation by the killing of a goose.

Zaroff stands at the end of this tradition as its negation. Turgenev's hunter saw the serf; Zaroff sees through his quarry to its "possibilities." Tolstoy's hunter renounced the kill; Zaroff renounced only animals. Dostoevsky's general hounded a child in a fit of rage; Zaroff hounds men as a regimen. The Russian literary hunt had been, among other things, a laboratory of conscience. On Ship-Trap Island the laboratory has become a game preserve, and conscience is the one thing that does not survive the crossing.

§ 2.8

Thoroughbreds and Mongrels: Galton, Grant, Stoddard, and the Under-Man

"A thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them." The sentence measures human beings and animals on a single scale, and the scale is pedigree. Its vocabulary is that of the stable and the kennel: the thoroughbred, whose descent is recorded in a stud book (England's *General Stud Book* began publication in 1791), and the mongrel, the dog of mixed and unrecorded breeding. Applied to human beings, the vocabulary had a recent and precise scientific source.

Francis Galton, Darwin's cousin, opened *Hereditary Genius* (1869) with the analogy that would organize the eugenic movement: "as it is easy, notwithstanding those limitations, to obtain by careful selection a permanent breed of dogs or horses gifted with peculiar powers of running, or of doing anything else, so it would be quite practicable to produce a highly-gifted

race of men by judicious marriages during several consecutive generations." In *Inquiries into Human Faculty* (1883) he named the project *eugenics*, from the Greek for "good in birth."

Galton's eugenics was, in its origins, a theory of class as much as of race. *Hereditary Genius* set out to show that eminence ran in families, which is to say that aristocracies of talent were aristocracies of blood. The American upper class had its own stud book in the *Social Register*, published in New York from the late 1880s.

Zaroff's taxonomy is Galtonian in exactly this sense. The list—"lascars, blacks, Chinese, whites, mongrels"—includes "whites." Its principle is not color alone but breeding fused with class: sailors from tramp ships of every race are "scum," and the aristocrat stands above them all, alongside his pedigreed horses and hounds. The fusion exposes the logic of the eugenic ontology. Once human worth is measured by the standards of animal breeding, humans and animals become commensurable, and a well-bred animal can outrank an ill-bred man. The general's sentence is not a slip of aristocratic hauteur. It is the eugenic scale read honestly from top to bottom.

Madison Grant translated the scale into American policy. A New York patrician, lawyer, and conservationist—a member of the Boone and Crockett Club, a founder of the New York Zoological Society and the Bronx Zoo, a leader in the campaigns to save the redwoods and the American bison—Grant published *The Passing of the Great Race* in 1916, a work of Nordicist race science that became one of the intellectual foundations of the 1924 quotas. His biographer Jonathan Spiro has shown how closely Grant's conservation and his eugenics were joined: the sensibility that sought to preserve the finest specimens of North American game sought equally to preserve the "great race" from contamination (Spiro 2009).

It was at Grant's zoo, in September 1906, that Ota Benga, a young Mbuti man brought from the Congo, was displayed in the primate house—an exhibition the zoo's leadership defended against the protests of Black clergy until public pressure ended it. A human being was exhibited as an animal, at an institution founded by hunters, under the governance of a eugenicist.

Lothrop Stoddard, Grant's protégé, supplied the vocabulary that Zaroff's "scum of the earth" most closely echoes. *The Rising Tide of Color Against White World-Supremacy* (1920), introduced by Grant, warned of a global demographic war of races. *The Revolt Against Civilization: The Menace of the Under Man* (1922) turned the warning inward. Stoddard's "Under-Man" was the human being who falls beneath the standard of capacity a civilization demands, who cannot be assimilated to it, and who is therefore its born enemy and the raw material of every revolution.

When the book appeared in German in 1925 as *Der Kulturumsturz: Die Drohung des Untermenschen*, its coinage entered the vocabulary of the radical right. Alfred Rosenberg took it up, and through him it passed to the regime that would use *Untermensch* to designate the peoples it set out to enslave and exterminate. The term that named the victims of the twentieth century's most systematic manhunt was the translation of an American race theorist's neologism, published two years before Connell's story.

Stoddard's Under-Man and Zaroff's quarry share a further feature: both are associated with revolution. The general fled "the debacle in Russia," and his contempt for the men of the tramp ships—the maritime proletariat that had been, in 1917, among the most militant constituencies of the revolution, from the cruiser *Aurora* to the naval base at Kronstadt—has the quality of a counter-revolution conducted on individual bodies. Ship-Trap Island is a White Russian's revenge on the class that took his quarter of a million acres in the Crimea, executed on whatever members of that class the sea delivers.

In 1924 the eugenic scale was not a marginal doctrine but law. The Johnson–Reed Act restricted immigration by national origin. In the same year Virginia enacted both a Racial Integrity Act and a statute authorizing the compulsory sterilization of the "feeble-minded"; in 1927, upholding the latter in *Buck v. Bell*, Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr. wrote for the Supreme Court that "three generations of imbeciles are enough." The quotas, the sterilizations, and the general's hunt belong to a single moment in which the stud book became a model of the polity.

One detail complicates the general's pedigree, and the complication is instructive. Zaroff ranks the races of his quarry, describes his servant as belonging to a race that is "a bit of a savage," and then adds: "So am I." The Cossack aristocrat claims membership in the savage race and the thoroughbred class at once. The contradiction is not resolved, because it need not be. In the discourse Zaroff speaks, race is less a category of descent than a floating marker of domination, fastened wherever the speaker needs it: to the servant to explain his violence, to the quarry to license their killing, to the master to dignify his ferocity. The general's eugenics is not a science he believes. It is a grammar of rank he uses.

§ 2.9

A Snuffbox in a Limousine: War, Puritans, and the Value of Life

The general's most cutting arguments are not philosophical but historical. He does not refute Rainsford's ethics; he dates them. "I refuse to believe that so modern and civilized a young man as you seem to be harbors romantic ideas about the value of human life. Surely your experiences in the war—" Rainsford completes the sentence: "Did not make me condone cold-blooded murder." Zaroff laughs. "How extraordinarily droll you are! ... One does not expect nowadays to find a young man of the educated class, even in America, with such a naïve, and, if I may say so, mid-Victorian point of view. It's like finding a snuffbox in a limousine. Ah, well, doubtless you had Puritan ancestors. So many Americans appear to have had."

The argument from the war was the most powerful available in 1924, and Connell, a veteran, knew its force. The Western Front had demonstrated the industrial production of death on a scale that made the humanitarian vocabulary of the previous century seem obsolete.

In "Zeitgemässes über Krieg und Tod" (1915), Freud argued that the war had stripped away the later accretions of civilization and allowed the primal man in each of us to reappear, and that it had shattered the conventional attitude toward death that civilization had trained us to adopt.

Ernst Jünger's *In Stahlgewittern* (1920) and *Der Kampf als inneres Erlebnis* (1922) offered a more dangerous lesson: that combat was an aesthetic and existential experience of the highest intensity, beside which civilian life was pallid. Jünger, a lifelong entomologist who would title a late book on beetle-collecting *Subtile Jagden* (1967), lived that lesson as a hunter-collector of experience. Zaroff, who "commanded a division of Cossack cavalry" and finds in the hunting of men the only intensity left to him, is a Jüngerian figure. His appeal to Rainsford's war is an appeal to the experience Jünger made into a doctrine: having killed men by the thousand under orders, why scruple at killing one by rule?

Rainsford's answer draws a line between killing in war and murder, and the adjective is the crux: *cold-blooded* murder. War kills hot; the hunt, in Zaroff's version, kills cold, by plan and at leisure. Rainsford's own final killing, which the story does not show, is premeditated, prepared by a swim and a vigil behind the bed curtains, and executed in the declared form of a duel: "Get ready, General Zaroff." It is neither hot nor cold. It is formal—a combat rather than a murder, a war in miniature. Whether that form suffices to keep Rainsford on his side of the line he drew at dinner is the question the ellipsis declines to answer.

"Mid-Victorian" places Rainsford's ethics in a precise moment. The decades around the middle of Victoria's reign consolidated the humanitarian movements that the general's sneer dismisses: the abolition of slavery in the British Empire (1833), the spread of laws against cruelty to animals, the anti-vivisection campaigns of the 1870s. The founding institution of the animal-welfare movement is exactly a century older than the story. The Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals was established in London in 1824, two years after Martin's Act, the first parliamentary statute against the ill-treatment of animals; its American counterpart, the ASPCA, followed in New York in 1866. Whitney's "For the hunter … Not for the jaguar" is mid-Victorian in exactly this sense, and the general is right that it was out of fashion among the educated in 1924. The story's wager is that fashion is not an argument.

"Puritan ancestors" adds a second historical charge, and an old joke. Macaulay had written that "the Puritan hated bear-baiting, not because it gave pain to the bear, but because it gave pleasure to the spectators" (*The History of England*, 1848, ch. 2). Weber traced the Puritans' hostility to the Stuart *Book of Sports* (1618, reissued 1633) to their distrust of every spontaneous enjoyment of life not directed to God's glory (*Die protestantische Ethik*, ch. 5).

Zaroff's jibe locates Rainsford's objection in that distrust: the American's scruple is not compassion for the quarry but disapproval of the hunter's pleasure. The charge is unfair to Rainsford, whose objection is to murder rather than to pleasure. As a description of the American hunting ethic, however, it is accurate. The doctrine of "fair chase" had always justified the hunt by its discipline—its self-denials, its rules, its character-building rigors—rather

than by its joys. Zaroff, the aristocrat, declines that justification. He hunts because "it gives me pleasure."

Then the snuffbox. A snuffbox in a limousine is an object of the eighteenth century discovered in the vehicle of the twentieth: a relic of outmoded civility inside the machinery of the modern. The figure is aimed at Rainsford's ethics, but it describes the general. It is Zaroff who is the eighteenth-century object—the Sadean aristocrat of the old regime, with his feudal hall, his mute serf, his refectory, and his right of life and death over the bodies on his estate. And it is the island that is the limousine. "Oh, yes," he says, after pressing a button that floods the sea with false lights, "I have electricity. We try to be civilized here."

The old regime's sovereignty over bodies has been installed in modern machinery—electricity, champagne shipped across an ocean, a portfolio of securities—and the combination is the story's image of the twentieth century. The anachronism is not Rainsford's conscience. It is the general's power, preserved intact inside the apparatus of modernity, and newly efficient there.

§ 2.10

Reason Hunting Reason: The Closing of the Inner Frontier

The genealogy assembled in this chapter discloses a pattern, and the pattern returns us to the three criteria with which Chapter One began. Each tradition examined here drew a line around reason and declared the outside a hunting ground. For Aristotle, the outside held the wild beast and the natural slave, who "participates in rational principle enough to apprehend, but not to have, such a principle." For Locke, it held the man who had renounced "the common law of reason" and might therefore be killed as a lion or a tiger.

For Descartes, it held the whole of animal life, which he denied thought and judged to act by the disposition of its organs, as a clock composed only of wheels and springs can count the hours (*Discours de la méthode*, Part V). For the eugenicists, it held the Under-Man, whose deficit of capacity made him civilization's enemy. In every case reason performed the double function described in Chapter One. It defined the human, and it marked the zone beyond which killing was not murder.

The moral philosophers who resisted this structure did so in one of two ways. Some, following Kant, accepted the line but argued for indirect duties toward those beyond it: cruelty to animals is wrong, Kant taught in his lectures on ethics, not because animals have rights but because whoever is cruel to animals grows hard in his dealings with human beings (Collins notes, c. 1784–85).

Montaigne had made the same observation with a historical example that reads as a summary of Zaroff's biography. "Les naturels sanguinaires à l'endroit des bêtes témoignent une propension naturelle à la cruauté"—natures bloodthirsty toward beasts reveal a natural propensity to cruelty—and "après qu'on se fut apprivoisé à Rome aux spectacles des meurtres

des animaux, on vint aux hommes et aux gladiateurs": once Rome had grown accustomed to spectacles of the slaughter of animals, it proceeded to men and to gladiators ("De la cruauté," *Essais* II.11). William Hogarth gave the progression its most popular visual form in *The Four Stages of Cruelty* (1751), whose Tom Nero advances from torturing a dog to beating a horse to murder, and ends on the anatomists' table.

Zaroff's life follows the Montaignean sequence with documentary exactness: at five, "a little gun, specially made in Moscow for me, to shoot sparrows with"; then his father's prize turkeys, shot and not punished—"he complimented me on my marksmanship"; a bear in the Caucasus at ten; "every kind of game in every land"; and finally men. The father's compliment is the decisive event, and Connell's precision in recording it amounts to a diagnosis. The child who killed what was not his to kill, and was praised for his aim rather than reproved for the killing, learned that the measure of an act is its skill. Everything else follows from that lesson.

The other resistance, Bentham's and Schopenhauer's, rejected the line itself. It placed the ground of moral consideration not in reason but in the capacity to suffer, and so dissolved the hunting ground that reason had drawn. Schopenhauer attacked Kant's indirect-duty view as a barbarism of the West and made compassion (*Mitleid*), extending to every creature that can suffer, the foundation of ethics (*Über die Grundlage der Moral*, 1840, §19). This is Whitney's position on the yacht. It is the only one of the three criteria under which no distribution of reason can justify the hunt, since the hunted always fear.

Zaroff's achievement, in the terms of this genealogy, is to have discovered what happens to the rationalist structure when its outside is exhausted. The hunter of animals defined his quarry by its lack of reason, the colonial hunter by its deficit of reason, the eugenicist by its subnormal capacity. Zaroff has hunted "every kind of game in every land" and found it wanting, for the decisive reason that the animal "had nothing but his legs and his instinct," and "instinct is no match for reason." The outside of reason has been depleted, as the American frontier had closed and the Russian estates had been expropriated. The hunt therefore turns inward, upon reason itself. It seeks the one quarry whose possession of reason makes it equal, or nearly equal, to the hunter, and it finds that this quarry is the most satisfying because it is the least foreign.

Horkheimer and Adorno named this movement the dialectic of enlightenment: reason, constituted as the domination of external nature, ends by dominating the nature within the human, and finally the human as such. Zaroff gives the dialectic a sportsman's face. His hunt is not a regression from reason to savagery but the consummation of a rationality that had always understood itself as the mastery of what lay outside it, now compelled, for want of an outside, to make itself its own object. The frontier of reason has closed, and the hunt has crossed into the interior.

This is the full sense of *homo venandus*. The rational animal is the most dangerous game not only because reason makes it formidable, though it does, but because reason is the faculty by which the hunting ground was drawn in the first place, and a hunting ground drawn by reason will in the end enclose the reasoner. Zaroff's island is the place where the line between

hunter and hunted is shown to run not between kinds of beings but through each of them. Rainsford's "two classes" are one class.

The story's next question, which Chapter Three pursues, is what kind of life produces a man who discovers this and is not appalled by it, but bored.




pain
boredom



CHAPTER THREE

The Leisure of the Predator

Ennui, Capital, and the Aesthetics of the Trophy

§ 3.1

"Ennui. Boredom.": The Diagnosis and Its Genealogy

On the morning after Rainsford's arrival, General Zaroff appears at luncheon, "dressed faultlessly in the tweeds of a country squire," and confesses an indisposition. "Last night I detected traces of my old complaint." To Rainsford's questioning glance he names it: "Ennui. Boredom." The diagnosis is the story's most explicit act of self-interpretation, and it is placed with care. The night before, the general explained that the hunting of men had cured the boredom that overtook him in the Amazon. The next day the complaint is back. The cure has failed within a single night, and the rest of the story is the administration of a stronger dose.

The French word arrives with its history. *Ennui* descends, through Old French *enui*, from the Latin phrase *in odio esse*, "to be in hatred," to be odious; English *annoy* shares the root. Boredom, etymologically, is a condition in which the world has become hateful. The general's complaint is not the mild tedium of a long afternoon but a disaffection with being as such, and the remedy he seeks is correspondingly drastic: a world made interesting again by the presence within it of something that can kill him.

The concept's longer genealogy runs through the monastery. The desert fathers of the fourth century named a vice they called *acedia*, the "noonday demon" of Psalm 91 (90 in the Septuagint), which seized the solitary monk in the heat of the day, made his cell intolerable, his labor pointless, and the hours endless (Evagrius Ponticus, *Praktikos* John Cassian, *Institutes*, book 10). Aquinas defined acedia as sorrow about spiritual good (*Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 35); Petrarch, in the *Secretum*, made *accidia* the private affliction of the humanist intellectual. Chapter Two described Zaroff's château as a monastery of the hunt, with its refectory, its incense, and its single passion. Its abbot suffers the monastic vice. His demon arrives not at noon but, as he tells it, at night, when he lay "in my tent with a splitting headache."

Pascal gave the modern concept its classic analysis, and his analysis is, uncannily, an analysis of hunting. Nothing is so insufferable to man, he wrote, as to be in complete repose, without passions, business, diversion, or application; he then feels his nothingness, his abandonment, his insufficiency, his dependence, his impotence, his emptiness, and there rise at once from the depths of his soul "l'ennui, la noirceur, la tristesse, le chagrin, le dépit, le désespoir" (*Pensées*, fragment "Ennui").

The remedy is *divertissement*, diversion in the literal sense of a turning-away, and Pascal's paradigm of diversion is the hunt. Those who reproach men for spending a whole day chasing a hare they would not have bought do not understand human nature. The hare itself would not shield us from the sight of death and misery; the chase, which turns us away from them, does. Men do not know "que ce n'est que la chasse et non pas la prise qu'ils recherchent"—that it is only the chase, and not the catch, that they seek.

Zaroff's own vocabulary is Pascalian. When Rainsford refuses to join the hunt, the general offers the alternative of Ivan's knout with a question: "may I not venture to suggest that you will find my idea of sport more diverting than Ivan's?" *Diverting* is the precise word, and its double sense—amusement and avoidance—is the story's diagnosis of its villain. The general hunts in order not to see.

Pascal also anticipated the special difficulty of kings. Surrounded by every satisfaction, the king is the man most exposed to ennui, which is why he is surrounded as well by people whose whole office is to divert him: "un roi sans divertissement est un homme plein de misères," a king without diversion is a man full of miseries. Zaroff is a king without a kingdom, sovereign of an island whose only subjects are a mute servant, a pack of hounds, and a cellar of captives. The captives are his diverters. Their office is to keep him from the sight of himself.

The story offers, unobtrusively, a second etiology. The general's account of the Cape buffalo that "hurled me against a tree" ends with the words "Fractured my skull." Later he recalls lying in his tent "with a splitting headache" when "a terrible thought pushed its way into my mind." Readers in 1924 had a vocabulary for injuries that changed a man: the case of Phineas Gage, the railway foreman whose character altered after an iron bar passed through his skull in 1848, so that his friends said he was "no longer Gage" (Harlow 1868), and, more immediately, the head-wounded and shell-shocked veterans of the war. Connell does not insist on the physiological reading, but he leaves it available beside the metaphysical one. The general's ennui may be a philosophy or a lesion. The story's refusal to choose is itself a statement: the modern predator can be explained either way, and neither explanation excuses him.

Finally, the structure of the cure. "Every day I hunt, and I never grow bored now," Zaroff boasts at dinner. At luncheon the next day he complains that the previous night's quarry "lost his head" and "made a straight trail that offered no problems at all." The pun—the sailor's head is now, presumably, in the library—is the general's own, and so is the logic of escalation it discloses. The hunting of men has followed the curve of every remedy for ennui: relief, tolerance, relapse, the demand for a stronger stimulus. Rainsford is that stimulus. When he too

has been exhausted, the complaint will return. Section 3.10 examines this curve as the structure of consumption itself.

§ 3.2

The Pendulum and the Rotation: Schopenhauer and Kierkegaard

Schopenhauer gave boredom a place in the metaphysics of the will. Life, he argued, "schwingt also, gleich einem Pendel, hin und her, zwischen dem Schmerz und der Langenweile"—swings like a pendulum, back and forth, between pain and boredom (*Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* I, §57). Want is pain; satisfied want is boredom; and the will, which can never rest, is driven from one to the other without end. He added a sociological corollary that could serve as a gloss on Ship-Trap Island. As want is the constant scourge of the common people, so boredom is the scourge of the fashionable world; and in bourgeois life, he observed, boredom is represented by Sunday, as want by the six weekdays.

The corollary describes the island's two populations precisely. In the château lives the scourge of boredom; in the cellar, the scourge of want—shipwrecked sailors from tramp ships, men whose lives were spent on the six weekdays. Zaroff's hunt is the point at which the two scourges meet. The bored hunt the needy, and the needy, offered the alternative of the knout, consent to divert the bored. Schopenhauer's pendulum, which in his metaphysics swings within each individual life, has here been distributed across a class structure, so that one man's boredom is relieved by other men's terror.

Kierkegaard turned boredom into an aesthetic program and then exposed the program's despair. In the first part of *Either/Or* (1843), the young aesthete known as A writes a mock-treatise, "The Rotation of Crops," which begins from the premise that boredom is the root of all evil and offers a comic genealogy. The gods were bored, so they created man; Adam was bored alone, so Eve was created; the human race was bored together, and so built the Tower of Babel.

A's remedy is a "rotation method," and he distinguishes two forms of it. The vulgar rotation changes the field: one is weary of the country and moves to the city; weary of one's native land, one goes abroad; weary of Europe, one goes to America. The refined rotation changes the method of cultivation instead. It limits itself and discovers in limitation an inexhaustible fertility: the more one restricts oneself, the more inventive one becomes, so that a prisoner in solitary confinement may find a spider an object of absorbing interest.

Zaroff's biography passes through both rotations in order. His first remedy was the vulgar one—"grizzlies in your Rockies, crocodiles in the Ganges, rhinoceroses in East Africa," then jaguars in the Amazon—and it failed when the field was exhausted. His second is A's refined rotation, executed with an aesthete's rigor. "I bought this island, built this house, and here I do

my hunting." He restricts himself to a single bounded territory, imposes on himself "a pistol of the smallest caliber and range," limits the hunt to three days, and finds in these limitations the endless variety of a quarry that reasons. The island is a rotation method converted into real estate.

The second part of *Either/Or* contains the ethical answer, delivered by Judge William, and it includes a portrait that reads like a prophecy of the general. William describes Nero: an emperor sated with every pleasure, whose spirit, unable to break through into a self, curdles into melancholy; who has Rome set on fire to procure a diversion large enough to reach him; and who wants, above all, to be feared. The melancholic sovereign, William suggests, needs the terror of others because it is the only proof available to him that he exists for them. The insight is exact. Zaroff wants Rainsford's fear as he once wanted the jaguars' cunning—as evidence that something in the world still resists him and therefore still recognizes him.

Kierkegaard's analysis reveals a second feature of Zaroff's ennui that the general conceals. A's rotation method is a technique for preventing the self from ever having to choose itself. It keeps the aesthete moving among possibilities, so that no decision binds him and no commitment defines him; his real terror is not boredom but the ethical, the moment at which he would have to become someone in particular. Zaroff's hunts serve the same function. Each is a possibility realized and discarded. The general who claims to "live for danger" has organized his life around the avoidance of the only danger that would matter—having to answer, as a person, for what he does. The rules of his game exist to remove that danger. They make the killing the quarry's choice.

Rainsford's declaration on the last night—"I am still a beast at bay. … Get ready, General Zaroff"—is, in Kierkegaardian terms, the first fully ethical act on the island: a decision without rules, in which one man answers another as a person. It is also a killing. Whether the ethical can be founded on such an act is the question that Kierkegaard, like Dostoevsky, leaves with his reader.

§ 3.3

An Oasis of Horror in a Desert of Boredom: Decadence and the New Sensation

"I have invented a new sensation," the general announces, pouring the port. The phrase belongs to the nineteenth century's literature of decadence, and its sources can be named. In *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890; revised 1891), Lord Henry Wotton urges the young Dorian to "be always searching for new sensations" and proclaims that "a new Hedonism" is what the century wants. In Joris-Karl Huysmans's *À rebours* (1884), the last scion of an exhausted aristocratic line, the duc Jean des Esseintes, withdraws from Paris to a villa at Fontenay to cultivate artificial sensations against a world that bores him: hothouse flowers chosen because

they look manufactured, a "mouth organ" of liqueurs on which he plays symphonies of taste, perfumes compounded into landscapes.

Zaroff's château is Fontenay with a rifle. Its master smokes perfumed cigarettes that smell of incense; drinks Pol Roger, Chambertin, Chablis, and an after-dinner liqueur; eats crêpes Suzette and, "delicately," a "hothouse grape"; and reads in three languages. Huysmans supplies the detail that defines the logic of the aesthetic predator. Des Esseintes, wanting a living ornament to set off the colors of an Oriental carpet, has the shell of a tortoise gilded and encrusted with precious stones. The tortoise, unable to bear its splendor, dies. The animal has been killed by being made beautiful. The trophy, as section 3.8 argues, is the generalization of this procedure.

Baudelaire gave decadence its theology of ennui. The prefatory poem of *Les Fleurs du mal* (1857), "Au Lecteur," reviews the menagerie of the vices—jackals, panthers, bitch-hounds, monkeys, scorpions, vultures, serpents—and names the worst of them, a monster that makes no great gestures and utters no great cries, but would gladly reduce the earth to rubble and swallow the world in a yawn: "C'est l'Ennui!—l'œil chargé d'un pleur involontaire, / Il rêve d'échafauds en fumant son houka." It is Ennui, his eye heavy with an involuntary tear, who dreams of scaffolds as he smokes his hookah. The portrait could be captioned with the general's name. Zaroff, too, smokes as he plans his killing, and his violence is the work not of passion but of an immense fatigue.

The poem that closes the 1861 edition, "Le Voyage," gives the itinerary of Zaroff's whole life. The travelers return from the ends of the earth with bitter knowledge: the world, monotonous and small, shows us our own image, today, yesterday, tomorrow, always—"Une oasis d'horreur dans un désert d'ennui!" An oasis of horror in a desert of boredom. The poem ends by calling on Death, the old captain, to raise anchor, so that the voyagers may plunge to the bottom of the abyss, Hell or Heaven, it does not matter, "au fond de l'Inconnu pour trouver du *nouveau*!"—into the depths of the unknown, to find the new.

Ship-Trap Island is Baudelaire's oasis realized as property. Zaroff's travels have shown him a world monotonous and small; every land has yielded its game and exhausted its interest; and the island is the place where horror is cultivated as relief from the desert. The general's "new sensation" is Baudelaire's *nouveau*, sought at the bottom of the abyss.

Baudelaire also supplied the type that Zaroff, "erect, slender ... in evening clothes," embodies. In *Le Peintre de la vie moderne* (1863), the dandy is the aristocrat of a democratic age, whose cult of himself, of elegance, and of impassivity is "le dernier éclat d'héroïsme dans les décadences," the last flash of heroism in times of decadence. The dandy's discipline is the suppression of visible emotion; his religion is form. Zaroff's composure under insult ("Dear me ... again that unpleasant word"), his evening dress on a jungle island, and his insistence on the rules of a game no one else has agreed to are dandyism extended to the taking of life.

The aestheticization of murder had a comic prophet. In "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts" (1827), Thomas De Quincey imagined a Society of Connoisseurs in Murder that judged homicides as works of art, and in a later supplement he inverted the moralist's

slippery slope: if once a man indulges himself in murder, very soon he comes to think little of robbing, and from robbing he comes next to drinking and Sabbath-breaking, "and from that to incivility and procrastination." The joke depends on reversing Montaigne's progression from beasts to men, examined in Chapter Two. Zaroff's life runs the Montaignean sequence without irony, from sparrows to sailors, accompanied at every stage by perfect civility. He is De Quincey's connoisseur without De Quincey's humor, a man for whom murder has become, literally, a fine art.

André Gide's *Les Caves du Vatican* (1914) carried the logic one step further. Its hero, Lafcadio, pushes a stranger from a moving train for no reason at all, in an *acte gratuit* whose very gratuitousness is meant to demonstrate the agent's freedom. Zaroff's hunt is not gratuitous in this sense; it is motivated by boredom and justified by philosophy. But it shares with Lafcadio's act the conviction that the value of a deed lies in its form rather than its object—that it is the gesture, not the victim, that matters.

In that conviction the decadent tradition and the sporting tradition meet. The doctrine of "fair chase" and the *acte gratuit* both make the form of the act the measure of its worth, and both leave the one on whom the act falls outside the calculation.

§ 3.4

Profound Boredom and the Poverty of the Animal: Heidegger, 1929–30

Five years after Connell's story appeared, Martin Heidegger devoted the first half of a Freiburg lecture course to boredom and the second half to the animal. *Die Grundbegriffe der Metaphysik: Welt – Endlichkeit – Einsamkeit* (winter semester 1929–30, published 1983) is the most sustained philosophical treatment of either subject in the twentieth century. Its conjunction of the two—boredom as the fundamental attunement of the age, the animal as the being "poor in world"—constitutes, without the slightest intention on Heidegger's part, the most exact philosophical commentary on Zaroff's island. Its subtitle could serve as the island's description: world, finitude, solitude.

Heidegger distinguishes three forms of boredom. The first is being bored *by* something: waiting four hours for a train at a provincial station, where time drags and the surroundings hold us in limbo while leaving us empty. The second is being bored *with* something, and his example is a dinner party. We are invited out for the evening; the food is excellent, the company pleasant, the conversation lively; nothing was boring. Yet on the way home we realize that we were bored after all—that the boredom lay in the evening itself, in the pastime by which we let time pass while holding ourselves at a distance from our own existence. The third form, profound boredom, is impersonal: "it is boring for one" (*es ist einem langweilig*). Beings as

a whole withdraw and refuse themselves; everything becomes indifferent at once; and in that refusal Dasein is exposed to the bare fact of its own possibilities.

The second form is the boredom of Zaroff's dinner table. The borsch is rich, the champagne has survived its voyage, the conversation is the most brilliant Rainsford has heard; nothing is boring, and the host is bored. The pastime—dinner, cigarettes, port, reminiscences of the chase—is the form in which his boredom conceals itself. The third form is the "terrible thought" that came to him in the tent: "Hunting was beginning to bore me!" What overtook him then was not a particular dissatisfaction but the withdrawal of a whole world, the world of the hunt, which had been, as he says, "my life."

For Heidegger, profound boredom has a philosophical vocation. It discloses Dasein's possibilities by suspending them, and it calls for a moment of vision (*Augenblick*), a resolute decision in which Dasein seizes itself. The first part of the course closes with a diagnosis of the age: contemporary humanity has lost the sense of mystery and with it the inner terror that gives existence its greatness, and must first call again for one capable of striking terror into our existence—"einen Schrecken einzujagen." The German idiom for striking terror, *einjagen*, is built on *jagen*, to hunt. Zaroff, whose inspiration came in a moment of vision in a tent, had answered the call before it was made. He decided to hunt terror back into existence.

The second half of the course develops three theses: the stone is worldless (*weltlos*), the animal is poor in world (*weltarm*), man is world-forming (*weltbildend*). The animal, Heidegger argues, is not simply without world like the stone. It has access to beings, but only within a "disinhibiting ring" of drives, in a state he calls captivation (*Benommenheit*). His best-known example is a bee which, if its abdomen is cut away while it feeds, goes on sucking the honey that runs out behind it: absorbed in its drive, it cannot apprehend beings as beings.

Zaroff's verdict on the animals he has exhausted is a hunter's version of this thesis. "The animal had nothing but his legs and his instinct. Instinct is no match for reason." The jaguar is captivated, poor in world; its moves are predictable because it cannot step outside its ring. The quarry Zaroff seeks is the world-forming being, the only creature able to make the hunt a contest of worlds. And Rainsford does form a world. He builds the Malay mancatcher, digs the Burmese pit, rigs the Ugandan knife, and finally reconstructs the whole island as a field of possibilities that includes the general's bedroom. The hunt of men is the hunt of world-formation: the attempt to bring the faculty of world-making within range of a gun.

Jacques Derrida, in his last seminar, *La bête et le souverain* (2002–03), read Heidegger's lecture course alongside Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe*, setting the philosopher's theses on world and solitude against the castaway's island, his terror of being devoured, and his sovereignty over goats, a parrot, and a man he names Friday. The pairing has an obvious third term. Ship-Trap Island is the place where Crusoe's island and Heidegger's lecture hall meet: a castaway arrives on an island whose sovereign suffers from profound boredom, has ranked the beings of the earth by their poverty or wealth in world, and hunts the richest.

Heidegger's own political choices after 1933 are not the subject of this dissertation, and the argument does not depend on them. But the conjunction his course discloses matters

independently of its author's fate. When boredom is understood as the attunement of an age, and its remedy is sought in a decision that would restore terror to existence, the world-forming being becomes, by an inexorable logic, the most interesting quarry. Connell's general, with his headache in the Amazonian night, reached that conclusion five years before the philosopher's lectures.

§ 3.5

Russian Spleen: Onegin, Pechorin, Stavrogin, and the Seagull

Zaroff is a Russian aristocrat, and his ennui has a specifically Russian lineage, which the literature of the nineteenth century had already composed into a type: the bored nobleman who destroys others to fill a void in himself. Its history is written in duels, abductions, and dead birds.

Pushkin named the malady in the first chapter of *Eugene Onegin* (1825–32). Onegin, the Petersburg dandy sated with balls, theaters, and love affairs, is overtaken little by little by an ailment whose cause, Pushkin remarks, it is high time someone discovered—something like the English spleen; in short, *russkaya khandra*, the Russian blues. The ailment has consequences. In the sixth chapter Onegin kills his friend, the young poet Lensky, in a duel he could have avoided, out of a compound of vanity, irritation, and fear of ridicule. Pushkin himself died of a wound received in a duel in 1837.

Lermontov sharpened the type into a predator. Grigory Pechorin, the hero of *Geroi nashego vremeni* (*A Hero of Our Time*, 1840), is a guards officer posted to the Caucasus—the mountains where Zaroff killed his first bear at ten—who confesses that he is bored, that his life grows emptier by the day, and that the only remedy left to him is travel, perhaps to die on the road. He contrives the abduction of the young Circassian Bela, tires of her, and is away hunting boar when she is seized and fatally stabbed by a rival. In "Princess Mary" he toys with a young woman's affections for his amusement and writes in his journal that he regards the sufferings and joys of others only in relation to himself, as food that sustains his spiritual strength. He kills Grushnitsky in a duel fought on a narrow ledge above a precipice, on conditions he proposed so that even a slight wound would send the loser over the edge. Lermontov died in a duel in the Caucasus the following year.

The correspondences with Connell's general are structural. Pechorin is a Russian officer whose ennui yields only to danger and to the suffering of others, which he consumes as nourishment. He travels in search of a remedy and finds none. He designs the conditions of combat so that the contest is a trap. And his duel on the cliff's edge has its echo on Ship-Trap Island, where Rainsford, cornered by the pack on the third day, leaps from a cliff into the sea —a leap the general mistakes for a death.

Dostoevsky carried the type to its metaphysical extreme in Nikolai Stavrogin, the charismatic void at the center of *Demons* (1871–72). In the letter he writes before his suicide,

Stavrogin confesses that he has tested his strength everywhere and found it limitless, but has never known to what to apply it; that he can desire a good deed and take pleasure in it, and desire an evil one and take pleasure in that too, and that neither desire is strong enough to guide him. Stavrogin's crimes are the experiments of a man for whom nothing has weight. Zaroff's hunts are the routine of a man who has found one thing that, for three days at a time, does.

Chekhov gave the type its most economical image. In *The Seagull* (1896), the young writer Treplev shoots a gull and lays it at the feet of Nina, the aspiring actress he loves. The established novelist Trigorin, seeing the bird, jots a note: a subject for a short story—a young girl who has lived all her life beside a lake, happy and free as a gull, until a man comes along by chance, sees her, and *ot nechego delat'*, for want of anything to do, destroys her, like this gull. Trigorin then does exactly that to Nina. In the last act the estate manager brings out the gull, stuffed on Trigorin's instructions. Trigorin looks at the trophy and says that he does not remember.

The phrase *ot nechego delat'* is the Russian formula of predatory ennui, and Chekhov attaches it to a hunting trophy whose meaning has evaporated. The stuffed gull is the destiny of every trophy in Zaroff's library: the record of a destruction undertaken against boredom, preserved, displayed, and forgotten. The general's heads, too, will fail to be remembered. Each new hunt replaces the last, and the complaint returns.

The lineage clarifies what in Zaroff is Russian and what is not. The bored officers of Pushkin and Lermontov destroyed individuals in particular passions—jealousy, vanity, caprice—and were bound, and finally destroyed, by codes of honor. Stavrogin's crimes were metaphysical experiments; Trigorin's destruction of Nina was careless. Zaroff's destruction of men is none of these. It is systematic, rule-governed, and perfectly calm: the conversion of the Russian nobleman's spleen into an institution. Between Pechorin and Zaroff lie the emancipation of the serfs, the industrialization of war, and the revolution. What the general retains from his literary ancestors is the ennui without the passion, the duel without the honor, and the cliff without the fall.

§ 3.6

"Luckily": Capital, Leisure, and the Predatory Culture

The word appears twice in the story, once in each hunter's mouth, and the repetition is the hinge of its economics. On the yacht, Rainsford: "The world is made up of two classes—the hunters and the huntees. Luckily, you and I are the hunters." At dinner, Zaroff: "After the debacle in Russia I left the country, for it was imprudent for an officer of the Czar to stay there. Many noble Russians lost everything. I, luckily, had invested heavily in American securities, so I shall never have to open a tearoom in Monte Carlo or drive a taxi in Paris." The American sportsman's luck and the Russian émigré's luck are the same luck. It has a name, and the name is capital.

The general's alternatives were drawn from life. Thousands of White Russian émigrés—officers, landowners, princes—drove taxis in Paris in the 1920s, waited tables, and opened tearooms on the Riviera; the grand duke at the wheel of a cab was a stock figure of the decade's journalism and fiction. Zaroff's horror at the prospect is the sentiment Thorstein Veblen had analyzed a quarter-century earlier as the defining sentiment of a leisure class.

In *The Theory of the Leisure Class* (1899), Veblen argued that the archaic "predatory" phase of culture divided human activity into two kinds. *Exploit* was the honorable seizure of goods by force or prowess—war, government, sports, the hunt, devout observances. *Drudgery* was the productive labor of the industrious, and it was dishonorable. The leisure class preserves this division into the industrial age. Its members demonstrate their status by abstaining from productive labor ("conspicuous leisure") and by wasteful expenditure ("conspicuous consumption"), and they cultivate in sport and the chase the archaic predatory temperament that productive work has made obsolete.

Veblen's account explains the general's whole economy. His capital frees him from drudgery; his hunt is pure exploit. His consumption—champagne shipped across an ocean, an evening suit from "a London tailor who ordinarily cut and sewed for none below the rank of duke," linen, crystal, silver, china—is conspicuous in precisely Veblen's sense, though, strikingly, there is no audience to witness it. And his trophies are what Veblen said trophies were: "Tangible evidences of prowess—trophies—find a place in men's habits of thought as an essential feature of the paraphernalia of life. Booty, trophies of the chase or of the raid, come to be prized as evidence of pre-eminent force" (ch. 2).

The source of the general's luck is specified with care: "American securities." By 1924 the United States had become the creditor of the world. The war had shifted the financial center of gravity across the Atlantic, and in August of that year the Dawes Plan reorganized German reparations on the strength of American loans. Zaroff's wealth flows through the same circuit. The White Russian hunts on a Caribbean island financed by dividends from the New World, and the American sportsman Rainsford, a man of yachts and Purdey guns, belongs to the class whose securities pay for the island. The two hunters are financed by one capital. Their luck is one luck, seen from the two ends of a single economy.

Marx had described that economy in venatic and vampiric figures that Connell's portrait of the general brings to life. "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (*Capital* I, ch. 10, trans. Moore and Aveling). In the same chapter capital's "were-wolf hunger for surplus-labour" drives it past every moral and physical limit of the working day. The general with "red lips and pointed teeth," living on securities and hunting the men of the tramp ships, is Marx's vampire and Marx's werewolf in a single body. Capital's metaphors have become a character, as the island turns every figure into a fact.

The general's comparison of hunting with business is, in this light, more than a pleasantry. "I have heard that in America business men often go to pieces when they give up the business that has been their life." "Yes, that's so," Rainsford agrees. The commerce of the 1920s was

saturated with venatic language, and much of it survives. The speculator "makes a killing"; a falling market is a "bear" market, a term descended from the proverb against selling the bear's skin before the bear is caught; firms pursue "targets" and "acquisitions"; the recruiter of executives is a "headhunter." The language of finance remembers what finance itself prefers to forget—that accumulation is a form of pursuit, and that its trophies are taken from someone. Zaroff speaks that language without euphemism. He is a businessman who has retired into the literal.

The relation between the two hunters has one more economic dimension. Rainsford's book on snow leopards, which Zaroff has read, belongs to a genre of commodified adventure: the hunting memoir, sold to readers who will never hunt, on the strength of the author's exploits. Connell, an advertising writer before and after the war, wrote for a magazine whose pages sold both adventure and the goods advertised beside it. The story's economy includes its own conditions of production. The most dangerous game was, among other things, a product.

§ 3.7

The Freedom of the Hunt: Ortega, Bourdieu, and the Poacher

José Ortega y Gasset began his *Meditations on Hunting* (1942) with a question about freedom. What have human beings done when they were free to do whatever they wished? His answer, drawn from the history of aristocracies, was that the privileged of every age chose a small set of "happy occupations"—among them conversation, dancing, racing, and, preeminently, the hunt. The hunt is the occupation the free choose. For Ortega it was a vacation from the human condition: a return, under the controlled conditions of sport, to the Paleolithic situation in which the human being lived within nature as one predator among others, alert and wholly absorbed in pursuit.

Ortega's essay is the most philosophically serious defense of hunting in the modern literature, and two of its formulations bear directly on Zaroff. The first is that one does not hunt in order to kill; one kills in order to have hunted. The death of the animal is not the purpose of the hunt but its necessary consummation, the event that makes the pursuit real. The second is that the hunt is constituted by a specific inequality. The hunter must be superior to his quarry, but not absolutely so, for the quarry's chance of escape belongs to the practice. When the hunter's superiority becomes total, the hunt degenerates into something else, and the ethic of the hunt therefore requires the hunter to limit his own power.

Zaroff lives by the letter of this ethic. His complaint in the Amazon was precisely that his superiority had become absolute: "No animal had a chance with me any more. That is no boast; it is a mathematical certainty." His solution restores the constitutive inequality by raising the quarry as well as lowering the hunter: he hunts the reasoning animal, with the smallest pistol. The general is an Ortegan sportsman who has followed the ethic of the chance to its

terminus. If the hunt requires a worthy adversary, and no animal is worthy, then the hunt requires a man.

Pierre Bourdieu's sociology of taste supplies the framework in which this conclusion reads as a class position. In *La Distinction* (1979), Bourdieu argued that the "aesthetic disposition"—the capacity to value form over function, manner over matter, the gesture over its object—expresses a privileged distance from economic necessity. Those freed from necessity can treat the world as spectacle and its objects as occasions for form; those bound by necessity cannot. The hunt for sport is the purest instance of that disposition: the killing of an animal one does not need to eat, for the sake of the manner of its killing. Zaroff never eats his quarry. The hounds do. His distance from necessity is so complete that he has made killing itself a pure form.

The aristocratic monopoly of the hunt was secured, historically, by law, and the law fell hardest on those who hunted from need. The English Game Act of 1671 restricted the right to take game to holders of substantial landed property. The "Black Act" of 1723, the subject of E. P. Thompson's *Whigs and Hunters* (1975), created at a stroke some fifty new capital offenses, among them the hunting or stealing of deer by armed men with blackened faces in the royal forests. The poacher—the hungry man who took a deer to feed his family—could be hanged, while the gentleman who killed a deer for sport was admired. The class structure of the hunt was the class structure of the right to kill.

Zaroff reverses that structure with terrible simplicity. The poor no longer hunt illegally; they are hunted legally, under the rules of a game written by the man who owns the island. The poacher has become the game. And the aristocrat's distance from necessity, which in the age of the Game Laws took the form of a monopoly over the killing of animals, now takes the form of a monopoly over the killing of men.

A minor novel of the following year shows how naturally the British upper class of the period imagined the poacher's role as a remedy for its own ennui. In John Buchan's *John Macnab* (1925), three eminent men—a lawyer, a politician, and a banker—suffering from a malaise that a fashionable physician diagnoses as boredom, cure themselves by challenging three Highland landowners to stop them from poaching a stag or a salmon on their estates. The gentlemen play at being hunted, in a comedy in which nobody dies.

Chapter Six returns to Buchan. Here it is enough to note that the leisure class of the 1920s, on both sides of the Atlantic, was imagining the role of the quarry as a cure for the emptiness of privilege. Buchan imagined that role as a game played by gentlemen. Connell imagined it as a game played on the poor.

§ 3.8

The Library of Heads: Trophy, Collection, and Culture

"And now," said the general, "I want to show you my new collection of heads. Will you come with me to the library?" The sentence is the most chilling in the story, and its horror is architectural. Zaroff's human trophies are kept not in a dungeon or a charnel house but in the library—among the books on hunting he reads "in English, French, and Russian," beside the works of Marcus Aurelius. The room in which a culture keeps its documents is the room in which this man keeps his dead.

The trophy has a long history, and its etymology tells part of it. The Greek *tropaion* derives from *trepein*, "to turn": it marked the place where the enemy turned to flee, and it consisted originally of captured arms hung on a tree or post at the turning point of the rout. The trophy is the monument of another's defeat, erected on the spot where his back was seen.

The human head as trophy is attested across many societies and periods, and its meanings have varied as widely as its practitioners. Classical ethnography supplies an episode that reads as a description of Zaroff's hospitality. Diodorus Siculus, drawing on Posidonius, reports that the Gauls cut off the heads of enemies fallen in battle and nailed them to their houses, and that they preserved the heads of the most distinguished in cedar oil, kept them carefully in chests, and displayed them to strangers, boasting that they had refused great sums for them (V.29). Strabo, citing the same source, adds that Posidonius saw the spectacle in many places and loathed it at first, but grew accustomed to it and came to bear it calmly (IV.4.5).

Rainsford, invited to the library, is Posidonius on his first visit: "I hope," he says, "that you will excuse me tonight, General Zaroff. I'm really not feeling well." He never sees the collection. The general's invitation, like the Gaul's display, is an act of hospitality, and its purpose is the guest's habituation.

The anthropology of headhunting complicated every simple reading of such practices. Renato Rosaldo's study of the Ilongot of the northern Philippines ("Grief and a Headhunter's Rage," 1984) found the taking of heads bound up with the work of mourning, a discharge of the rage that grief produces. No such meaning attends Zaroff's collection. His heads mark not grief but ennui; they are the residue of diversions. That is precisely what makes them modern. They belong not to a cosmology but to a hobby.

The library of heads has a literary double in the most influential colonial novella of the period. In *Heart of Darkness* (1899; 1902), Marlow, approaching Kurtz's station, sees through his glass what he takes for ornamental knobs on the posts of a ruined fence, and then realizes his mistake: "These round knobs were not ornamental but symbolic." They are human heads, turned toward the house. Kurtz—emissary of a civilizing mission, a man to whose making "all Europe contributed," musician, painter, and author of a report on the suppression of savage customs whose scrawled postscript reads "Exterminate all the brutes!"—has surrounded his dwelling with the heads of those he called rebels. Conrad died on 3 August 1924, six months

after Connell's story appeared. The two texts share a single image: the cultivated European in a remote domain, whose culture and whose trophies are kept in the same house.

Walter Benjamin gave the image its theoretical form. "Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein"—there is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism ("Über den Begriff der Geschichte," VII, 1940). The cultural treasures, Benjamin argued, are carried in the triumphal procession of the victors, over the bodies of those who lie prostrate. Zaroff's library literalizes the thesis, as the island literalizes every figure. The documents of culture and the documents of barbarism share a shelf.

The institutional form of the trophy in the 1920s was the natural history museum, and its master was Carl Akeley—taxidermist, sculptor, inventor, and big-game hunter. Akeley shot the mountain gorillas of the Virunga volcanoes in 1921 for the group that became a centerpiece of the American Museum of Natural History's African Hall; he persuaded the Belgian king to create Albert National Park in 1925; and he died on the mountain in 1926, where he is buried. Donna Haraway's "Teddy Bear Patriarchy" (1984–85) read the African Hall as the temple of a specific vision—masculine, white, eugenic, and conservationist at once—in which taxidermy made dead animals seem more alive than life, arrested in the moment of the hunter's gaze.

Theodore Roosevelt's African expedition of 1909–10, mounted for the Smithsonian, killed more than five hundred animals and collected thousands of specimens. Rowland Ward of Piccadilly, taxidermist to the empire's hunters, had published since 1892 the *Records of Big Game*, which ranked trophies by measurement. Zaroff's dining hall, with its "larger or more perfect specimens," belongs to this world of the measured head; his library extends its measurements to men.

The trophy's later history runs from the museum to the market. In 1991 Damien Hirst exhibited *The Physical Impossibility of Death in the Mind of Someone Living*, a tiger shark caught to order off the Australian coast and suspended in formaldehyde; it later sold to a hedge-fund manager for a sum reported in the millions. Finance speaks of "trophy assets," and the trophy has become a general form of value: the possession that testifies to its owner's power over the life that was taken to produce it.

Chekhov's stuffed gull, unremembered by the man who ordered it, is the trophy's last truth. The head in the library documents not the quarry but the hunter's need to have hunted—and, finally, his inability to remember why.

§ 3.9

Marcus Aurelius in the Library: The Spider's Pride

On the story's last evening, believing his quarry dead, the general dines on Pol Roger and Chambertin and then retires to the library: "In his library he read, to soothe himself, from the works of Marcus Aurelius." The choice of author is the story's most learned irony, and

perhaps its most pointed. The Stoic emperor's *Meditations* contain a passage that condemns, in so many words, the man who is reading it.

"A spider is proud when it has caught a fly," Marcus wrote, "and another when he has caught a poor hare, and another when he has taken a little fish in a net, and another when he has taken wild boars, and another when he has taken bears, and another when he has taken Sarmatians. Are not these robbers, if thou examinest their opinions?" (X.10, trans. Long). The sequence ascends from insect to hare to fish to boar to bear to men—the Sarmatians against whom Marcus himself was then making war, and from whose defeat he took the title *Sarmaticus*. The emperor counts himself among the robbers. The hunter of men is a spider whose pride differs from the insect's only in the size of its prey.

The progression is Montaigne's, and Zaroff's biography seen from above: sparrows, turkeys, bears, men, a single ladder of predation every rung of which the Stoic calls robbery. Chapter Two recorded Nietzsche's injunction to the seekers of knowledge to be "robbers and conquerors" (*Räuber und Eroberer*). Between the emperor who condemned the robber and the philosopher who commanded him, the general reads the one and lives the other.

He reads, moreover, "to soothe himself." Stoicism, a discipline for meeting what cannot be changed with equanimity, serves the general as a sedative. The *Meditations* teach the acceptance of fate, the indifference of externals, and the cultivation of the ruling faculty; the general draws from them the composure that lets him regard the loss of his servant and the escape of his quarry as "two slight annoyances." The philosophy of self-command has become a technique of self-comfort for a man whose commands have been disobeyed.

The other great Roman Stoic named the general's practice outright. In his seventh letter to Lucilius, Seneca describes a visit to the arena at midday, where he expected light entertainment and found instead men set to kill one another without armor or skill. "Mane leonibus et ursis homines, meridie spectatoribus suis obiciuntur"—in the morning men are thrown to lions and bears, at noon to their spectators. And he names the spectacle with the word Rainsford uses at Zaroff's table: "Nunc omissis nugis mera homicidia sunt"—now, the trifles set aside, it is pure murder (*Epistulae morales* 7.3–4). The Stoic tradition on the general's shelf contains the verdict he calls "that unpleasant word."

Marcus's own relation to the arena is instructive. Cassius Dio reports that the emperor was so averse to bloodshed that he watched the gladiators in Rome contend like athletes, without risk to their lives, since he never gave them sharp weapons (LXXII.29). His son was otherwise. Commodus fought in the arena as a *venator*, killing beasts by the hundred before the assembled city; Herodian records that he decapitated running ostriches with crescent-headed arrows (I.15).

Dio, a senator, witnessed the sequel. Having killed an ostrich, Commodus cut off its head and approached the senators' benches holding the head in one hand and the bloody sword in the other, saying nothing, but wagging his own head with a grin; the senators chewed laurel leaves from their garlands to keep from laughing, which might have cost them their lives

(LXXIII.21). The trophy head held up in silence before the senate is a wordless threat: what was done to the bird can be done to you.

Zaroff reads the father and lives as the son. He keeps the Stoic on his shelf and the trophy heads beside it; he practices the emperor's composure and the venator's sport. Ridley Scott's *Gladiator* (2000), which made Commodus the archetypal tyrant of the arena for a twenty-first-century audience, staged the same split—a philosopher-emperor's legacy betrayed by an heir who turns the empire into a hunting ground. On Ship-Trap Island the split runs through a single man.

The *Meditations* hold one more passage that bears on the evening. "If men do not permit thee," Marcus wrote, "then get away out of life, yet so as if thou wert suffering no harm. The house is smoky, and I quit it" (V.29, trans. Long). The Stoic tradition regarded voluntary death as the final guarantee of freedom against tyranny; the door, as Seneca put it, always stands open. Zaroff believes his quarry has used that door. Rainsford, at bay on the cliff, "leaped far out into the sea," and the general, finding the trail ending at the edge, concludes that the American chose death over capture. His irritation—"the American hadn't played the game"—is that of a hunter whose quarry has exercised the Stoic's ultimate sovereignty and robbed him of the kill. He soothes himself with the Stoic who taught that sovereignty.

But the leap was not a Stoic exit. It was *mētis*, the cunning of the weak. Rainsford swam to the château and waited, hidden in the curtains of the general's bed. The door the general thought closed by death opened onto his own bedroom. Chapter Four reads the scene that follows as the climax of a myth of succession. Here it suffices to register its irony. The Stoic sedative is administered on the one night when the general's reading should have warned him —of spiders and Sarmatians, of robbers, and of the house one quits when it fills with smoke.

§ 3.10

Butterfly and the Folies Bergère: The Predator as Consumer

Zaroff hums twice in the story, and what he hums matters. After showing Rainsford the hounds that are loosed each night—"If anyone should try to get into my house—or out of it—something extremely regrettable would occur to him"—"he hummed a snatch of song from the Folies Bergère." And on the third day, standing where the trail ends at the cliff's edge, he "sat down, took a drink of brandy from a silver flask, lit a perfumed cigarette, and hummed a bit from *Madame Butterfly*."

The Folies Bergère was the Parisian music hall of the belle époque and the Jazz Age, a palace of spectacle whose revues displayed bodies as commodities to a paying public. Édouard Manet painted its bar in 1882, in a canvas whose barmaid stands between the bottles she sells and a mirror in which the crowd, a trapeze artist's feet, and a gentleman customer are reflected—an image, much interpreted, of modern pleasure as a transaction in which persons and goods are displayed on the same counter.

The general's hummed tune accompanies a threat. Light entertainment set against terror would become a signature device of later cinema: Stanley Kubrick's Alex sings "Singin' in the Rain" as he beats a man in *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), and Quentin Tarantino's Mr. Blonde dances to "Stuck in the Middle with You" as he tortures a policeman in *Reservoir Dogs* (1992). Connell's general, humming a revue song over a pack of man-killing dogs, is an early instance of the predator with a soundtrack.

Madame Butterfly is the more pointed choice. Puccini's opera (1904), adapted from David Belasco's play and John Luther Long's story, concerns an American naval lieutenant, Pinkerton, who "marries" a fifteen-year-old Japanese girl in a ceremony he regards as a disposable arrangement, sails away, and returns years later with an American wife to claim the child she has borne him. Butterfly kills herself with her father's dagger, whose blade bears the inscription "Con onor muore / chi non può serbar / vita con onore"—he dies with honor who cannot keep his life with honor.

The general hums *Butterfly* at the moment he believes his American quarry has leapt to his death, and the opera's colonial economy is reversed. In Puccini, an American takes his pleasure from a non-Western person and leaves her to die by her own hand. On Ship-Trap Island a Russian has taken his pleasure from an American who has, as the general believes, chosen death over capture. Zaroff hums the music of the abandoned victim as a comment on his own victim's end, granting his quarry the honor of an operatic death. The aesthete's irony rebounds when the quarry turns out to be alive.

The two tunes place the general within the economy of consumption that defined the 1920s. He consumes everything the period offered the rich—champagne, burgundy, "venerable Chablis from a dusty bottle," Turkish coffee, crêpes Suzette, hothouse grapes, perfumed cigarettes, London tailoring, opera, revue—and he consumes men in the same register, as one pleasure among others. "Will you have another glass of Chablis, Mr. Rainsford?" he asks, in the sentence immediately following his complaint that the previous night's quarry offered "no problems at all." The hunt is embedded in the menu.

The decade's consumer economy was learning to manufacture desire. Edward Bernays's *Crystallizing Public Opinion* (1923) and *Propaganda* (1928) theorized public relations as the engineering of wants; advertising, in which Connell had worked, offered novelty as its permanent product. Walter Benjamin, studying the Paris arcades, identified the paradox of the commodity: fashion promises the new and delivers the always-the-same, so that novelty becomes the form in which repetition disguises itself. Zaroff's "new sensation" obeys this law. Its novelty is consumed in a single night; the next morning the "old complaint" returns; and the cure demands a newer quarry, a better player—"a foeman worthy of my steel—at last."

The structure is that of addiction, and Freud had described its deep form in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), where he proposed that a compulsion to repeat, operating beyond the pleasure principle, serves the drive toward death. Zaroff's daily hunt is a repetition compulsion, and its ultimate object is his own death. He needs an adversary capable of killing him, and the escalation of his diversion leads with perfect logic to the man who will. The general's ennui

is, in this sense, suicidal from the start. The most dangerous game is the game whose stake the bored man has raised until it includes himself.

Chapter Three has traced the economy of leisure from which the hunting of men arises: the ennui that demands diversion, the capital that frees its holder from drudgery, the aesthetic disposition that makes killing a form, the trophy that converts death into culture, and the consumption that absorbs the hunt into the menu. These elements describe the general's life. They do not yet describe the shape of the story, which is older than any of them. Chapter Four turns from the sociology of the predator to the mythology of the hunted guest, and to the ancient structures—hosts and hounds, heads and beds—that Connell's plot reenacts.





the host's house



CHAPTER FOUR

Hosts, Hounds, and Heads

The Mythic Architecture of the Hunted Guest

§ 4.1

Xenia Inverted: Polyphemus, Lycaon, and the Devouring Host

The oldest law of the Greek world governed the arrival of strangers. *Xenia*, guest-friendship, obliged the host to receive the suppliant at his door, to bathe and feed him, to ask his name only after he had eaten, and to send him on his way with a gift. Zeus Xenios watched over the stranger, and the violation of hospitality was among the gravest impieties. The *Odyssey* is, among other things, an epic of xenia tested: a long series of arrivals at strange houses, in which the character of each host is disclosed by the treatment of the guest. Its scenes of perfect hospitality—Nestor at Pylos, Menelaus at Sparta, Alcinous on Scheria—are weighed against scenes of monstrous hospitality, and the most monstrous is the cave of Polyphemus.

Connell's story is built on that model. Rainsford, like Odysseus, arrives by sea at an unknown island; Chapter One observed that he sleeps the Phaeacian sleep of the castaway before he finds the great house. What he finds there is the Cyclops in the form of Alcinous. Zaroff performs every rite of xenia with exquisite correctness: he welcomes the stranger at the door, sees that he is bathed, dressed, and fed, offers wine, conversation, a bed, and a gift. But the gift is a three-hour start, and the bed is a waiting room.

The Homeric template is precise. Polyphemus, too, offers his guest a gift. When Odysseus, having plied the Cyclops with wine, tells him that his name is Nobody (*Outis*), the giant replies: "Noman will I eat last in the number of his fellows, and the others before him: that shall be thy gift" (9.369–370, trans. Butcher and Lang). The *xeinion*, the guest-gift that seals hospitality, becomes the privilege of being devoured last. Zaroff's gifts belong to the same parodic economy—"an excellent hunting knife," "a supply of food," "three hours' start," the honor of being the general's chosen opponent. They are real gifts, and they are the terms of the guest's death.

The escape, too, is Homeric, and its means are those of *mētis*. Odysseus survives by calling himself Nobody, by intoxicating the host, by sharpening a stake, and by leaving the cave clinging beneath the bellies of the Cyclops's rams—that is, by passing as an animal. The fugitive beneath the sheep is the archetype of the quarry that survives by becoming what the hunter does not look for. Rainsford's escape follows the pattern in another key. He does not disguise himself as an animal; he learns to think like one, doubling "on his trail again and again, recalling all the lore of the fox hunt, and all the dodges of the fox."

One difference is decisive. Odysseus survives by anonymity; Rainsford is endangered by fame. "My name is Sanger Rainsford of New York City," he announces at the door, and the name, by way of the book on snow leopards, is what makes him interesting. The man who calls himself Nobody escapes the Cyclops; the man who is Somebody becomes the Cyclops's chosen quarry. Odysseus's one lapse—shouting his true name as he sails away, so that Polyphemus can curse him to Poseidon—prolongs his wanderings by years. Rainsford's name is his lapse from the start. In the economy of the hunt, reputation is a scent.

Ovid supplies the second archetype of the devouring host, and it is the more political. In the first book of the *Metamorphoses*, Jupiter, disguised as a mortal, visits the house of Lycaon, king of Arcadia, to test reports of human wickedness. Lycaon, doubting his guest's divinity, resolves to test it himself. He plans to kill the stranger at night, heavy with sleep, by an unforeseen death, and he serves him a dish of human flesh, the limbs of a hostage, part boiled and part roasted (I.209–243). Jupiter brings the house down with a thunderbolt. Lycaon flees into the silent countryside and, howling, becomes a wolf, keeping the marks of his former self: "canities eadem est, eadem violentia vultus, / idem oculi lucent, eadem feritatis imago est"—the same grey hair, the same violence in the face, the same gleaming eyes, the same image of savagery.

Lycaon is the host as tester, the sovereign who subjects his guest to a trial whose instrument is murder. Zaroff's hunt is, on its own terms, a test of courage, cunning, and reason; he admits Rainsford to the general's company only as the subject of an examination that ends in death. And Ovid's portrait of the transformed king could describe the general: white hair, a face "used to giving orders," black eyes "very bright," and a smile of "red lips and pointed teeth." The wolf's head of medieval outlawry, examined in Chapter Two, has an Arcadian original, and the original wears a crown.

Émile Benveniste's study of Indo-European institutions identified, in the Latin vocabulary of hospitality, a semantic knot that these myths untie in narrative. *Hostis*, which in classical Latin means "enemy," originally designated the stranger bound to one by reciprocal obligation; *hospes*, host or guest, derives from a compound meaning, in effect, "master of the guest" (*Le Vocabulaire des institutions indo-européennes*, 1969). The host and the hostile share a root.

Derrida, reading Benveniste, coined *hostipitalité*, "hostipitality," to name the institution's inner contradiction: the host's power to welcome is inseparable from his mastery over the one welcomed, and hospitality always borders on hostility. Zaroff's château is the place where the border dissolves. Its hospitality is its hostility, performed with perfect manners.

§ 4.2

The Hunter Hunted: Actaeon and the Hounds That Do Not Know Their Master

The myth that names the story's reversal is told most fully in the third book of the *Metamorphoses* (III.138–252). Actaeon, grandson of Cadmus, has hunted with his companions on Cithaeron through the morning; at midday, the nets and spears wet with the blood of game, he calls a halt. Wandering alone through an unfamiliar wood, he comes upon a grotto where Diana, goddess of the hunt, is bathing with her nymphs. The goddess, with no arrows at hand, flings water in his face and dares him to tell, if he can, that he has seen her unveiled. Antlers spring from his brow; his neck lengthens; his ears sharpen; his hands become hooves; his body is clothed in a dappled hide. Fear is added to the change—"additus et pavor est"—and the hunter flees.

His hounds pursue him. Ovid names more than thirty of them in a catalogue as long as a Homeric muster—Melampus and Ichnobates, Pamphagus and Dorceus, Oribasus, Nebrophonos, Laelaps, Theron—and the catalogue is the core of the horror, for the hounds are known individuals, each with breed, color, and excellence. Actaeon wants to cry "Actaeon ego sum: dominum cognoscite vestrum!"—I am Actaeon; know your master!—but "verba animo desunt," words fail his mind (III.230–231). His companions urge the pack on and call for Actaeon, regretting that he is missing the kill; he would wish to be absent. The hounds tear him apart, and only when his life has ended in many wounds, Ovid says, is the anger of the quiver-bearing goddess satisfied.

The correspondences with Connell's story are exact at the level of structure. The hunter becomes the hunted; the instrument of his hunting becomes the instrument of his death; and the transformation is announced by fear. Rainsford's three days on the island are his Actaeon period, the interval in which the celebrated hunter wears the hide of the quarry, learns "how an animal at bay feels," and hears the pack baying on his trail.

But the story divides Actaeon's fate between its two hunters. Rainsford undergoes the transformation and survives it. Zaroff undergoes the ending. His own hounds, "a rather good lot," let out "at seven every night," will eat him: "One of us is to furnish a repast for the hounds." The general is an Actaeon who did not need to be turned into a stag to die as one.

Two further details of Ovid's account illuminate the story. The first is the hour. Actaeon's transgression happens at noon, the hour of Pan and of the noonday demon examined in Chapter Three, the suspended time in which the boundary between human and divine wears thin. Zaroff's hour is the other one. His hunts begin at dusk—"Hunting at night is so much more exciting than by day, don't you think?"—and his death comes after ten at night, in his own bedroom. The general belongs not to noon but to the night of the Wild Hunt, to which section 4.8 returns.

The second detail is speech. Actaeon cannot say his name; the change has taken his words. The motif recurs on the island in two forms. Ivan, who holds the hounds in leash, is "deaf and dumb." And the general, who has spent the story in fluent, ironic, polyglot discourse, ends it with a scream: "'Rainsford!' screamed the general. 'How in God's name did you get here?'" The story contains two screams. The first, at its opening, is the scream of an unknown quarry in the dark, "the sound of an animal in an extremity of anguish and terror," which Rainsford did not try to recognize. The second, at its close, is the hunter's. The story's acoustic structure returns the cry of the hunted to the throat of the hunter.

The Renaissance read Actaeon as an allegory of knowledge, and the reading bears on Zaroff's "analytical mind." In *De gli eroici furori* (1585), Giordano Bruno made Actaeon the figure of the intellect in pursuit of divine truth. He looses the mastiffs and greyhounds of his thoughts in search of the divine beauty; seeing Diana, the naked truth of nature, he is transformed into what he sought and devoured by his own thoughts—"il gran cacciator dovenne caccia," the great hunter became the quarry. For Bruno the transformation was a mystical consummation in which the knower becomes the known.

Zaroff's hunt of the reasoning animal is the parodic inversion of Bruno's. He hunts reason in order to master it, and is mastered by it. The general set out to prove that "instinct is no match for reason"; he is defeated by a reason that has learned to think like a fox. Bruno himself, it bears remembering, was hunted by the Inquisition and burned in Rome in 1600.

The painters gave the myth its canonical images. Titian's *Diana and Actaeon* (1556–59) shows the moment of seeing, the hunter lifting a curtain on the goddess's bath; his late *Death of Actaeon* (c. 1559–75) shows the moment of the hunt, the goddess striding with drawn bow while the half-transformed man falls beneath his hounds in a darkening wood, the paint itself dissolving into the browns and greens of the forest. The late canvas is among the most violent images in the European tradition, and its subject is not the punishment of a voyeur but the reversibility of the hunt. The hunter who sees too much becomes visible to his own dogs.

One last element of the myth bears on Connell's single named hound. Ovid's catalogue is a list of proper names, and the naming of hounds is a mark of the aristocratic hunt: the dogs are individuals, valued, pedigreed, loved. Prospero's spirit-hounds, examined in section 4.7, have names; the conquistadors' war dogs had names. Zaroff, who never names one of his human quarry, names his finest hound Lazarus. The story's only proper name in the pack is a theological pun, and section 4.8 reads it.

§ 4.3

The Brigand's Own Device: Theseus on the Road to Athens

Before he entered the labyrinth, Theseus cleared a road. Plutarch (*Theseus* 8–11), Apollodorus (*Epitome* 1), and a dithyramb of Bacchylides (18) recount the series of encounters by which the young hero, traveling by land from Troezen to Athens rather than by the safer sea, rid the

Isthmus of its brigands. Periphetes battered travelers with a bronze club; Theseus killed him and carried the club thereafter. Sinis, called *Pityokamptes*, the Pine-Bender, bent pine trees to the ground, bound travelers to them, and let the trees spring apart; Theseus killed him the same way. At Crommyon he killed a monstrous wild sow. Sciron, on the cliffs of the Megarid, made travelers wash his feet and, as they knelt, kicked them into the sea, where a giant turtle devoured them; Theseus hurled him from his own cliff. Cercyon forced passers-by to wrestle to the death; Theseus outwrestled him. And Procrustes, the Stretcher, offered travelers the hospitality of his bed, then racked those who were too short and lopped those who were too long; Theseus fitted him to it.

Plutarch states the principle that unifies the series: Theseus visited on the evildoers the same violence they had used on others, so that they suffered justly after the manner of their own injustice (*Theseus* 11). Later criticism would call the pattern poetic justice, the talion of narrative, and it is the moral structure of Rainsford's survival. He defeats the hunter by the hunt. The general's art is turned upon its practitioner; the trap-maker's quarry builds traps; the host's bed receives the host.

The correspondences extend to the devices themselves. Sinis's weapon was a bent tree. Rainsford's deadliest trap is "a native trick he had learned in Uganda": "He caught hold of a springy young sapling and to it he fastened his hunting knife, with the blade pointing down the trail; with a bit of wild grapevine he tied back the sapling." The released sapling kills Ivan. The Malay mancatcher is likewise a tree-weapon, a dead tree leaning on a living one and rigged to fall on whoever trips its trigger. Sciron's cliff and his devouring sea-beast reappear in the island's geography: in the general's reef, where "giant rocks with razor edges crouch like a sea monster with wide-open jaws," and in the cliff from which Rainsford, cornered, leaps into the sea. And Procrustes' bed, on which a host destroyed his guests until a guest destroyed him, is the bed of the story's last sentence.

The Theseus pattern also clarifies the colonial provenance of Rainsford's knowledge. Each of his traps is named for the land where he learned it: Malay, Burmese, Ugandan. The hero who defeats the brigands by their own devices learned those devices from them, and Rainsford defeats the aristocratic hunter with the trapping lore of colonized peoples, absorbed during his own expeditions in their lands. The knowledge of the weak returns through him against the master.

When the first trap wounds him, Zaroff concedes the point with a remark that brings back a word Chapter Three found twice in the story: "Not many men know how to make a Malay mancatcher. Luckily for me I, too, have hunted in Malacca." *Luckily*—the third occurrence, and again the word marks the hunter's insulation by fortune, by the breadth of experience that only wealth affords. The general has been everywhere the quarry's knowledge comes from.

Connell gives the island a further Thesean feature. Zaroff boasts of its terrain—"there are jungles with a maze of trails in them, hills, swamps"—and the word *maze* summons the labyrinth that Daedalus built for Minos, at whose center the Minotaur devoured the tribute of Athenian youths. On Ship-Trap Island the configuration is inverted. The monster does

not lurk at the center of the maze; he lives in the palace and hunts through it. And it is the quarry who becomes the maze's architect. On the first night Rainsford "executed a series of intricate loops; he doubled on his trail again and again," making of his own path a labyrinth through which the hunter must find his way. The hunted man is Daedalus; the hunter is the one without a thread.

The mythic pattern does not end with the brigands, and its sequel bears on the story's ending. Theseus became king of Athens by a death: his father Aegeus, seeing the black sail his son had forgotten to change, threw himself into the sea that bears his name. The hero's accession was paid for with the father's life. And Theseus's own end, in the version Plutarch reports, came on Skyros, where King Lycomedes, his host, led him up to a height on the pretext of showing him his lands and threw him down from the cliff (*Theseus* 35).

The hero who threw Sciron from his cliff was thrown from a cliff by a host. The talion of the road to Athens does not stop at the brigands. It follows the hero into his kingdom and waits for him there.

§ 4.4

The Mighty Hunter Before the Lord: Nimrod, Esau, and the Forest

The first king in the Hebrew Bible is a hunter. "And Cush begat Nimrod: he began to be a mighty one in the earth. He was a mighty hunter before the LORD: wherefore it is said, Even as Nimrod the mighty hunter before the LORD. And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel" (Genesis 10:8–10, KJV). The verses join, in a single genealogy, the hunt, sovereignty, and the city whose tower would confound the languages of mankind. The interpretive tradition read the conjunction darkly.

Josephus made Nimrod the instigator of the tower and a tyrant who turned men from God by persuading them to trust in their own power (*Antiquities* I.4.2). Augustine, reading the Septuagint, insisted that its preposition should be rendered not "before" but "against" the Lord—a giant hunter *contra Dominum*—and asked what "hunter" could signify here but a deceiver, oppressor, and destroyer of earth-born creatures (*De civitate Dei* XVI.4). In the patristic reading, the first hunter-king hunted men. Dante placed him among the giants who stand like towers around the pit of hell, his hunting horn at his neck, sounding a blast louder than Roland's and uttering a babble no one can understand—"Raphèl maì amècche zabì almi"—since through his evil design the world no longer uses a single language (*Inferno* XXXI.12–18, 67–81).

The Nimrod tradition gives the island a Babelic dimension that Connell's details support. The general reads hunting books "in English, French, and Russian" and speaks with "a slight accent that gave it added precision." His quarry is polyglot: "lascars, blacks, Chinese, whites,

mongrels," the crew of a Spanish bark, sailors from every port. His servant has no language at all. The hunter-king's household reproduces the confusion of Babel under a sovereign's control: one master of many tongues, one mute instrument, and a population of quarry whose languages the master need not understand, since what he wants from them is not speech but flight.

The second biblical hunter is Esau, "a cunning hunter, a man of the field," set against Jacob, "a plain man, dwelling in tents" (Genesis 25:27). Isaac loves Esau "because he did eat of his venison." But the hunter sells his birthright for a dish of pottage, and loses his father's blessing to his brother, who covers his hands and neck with goatskins to counterfeit the hunter's hairiness and brings the blind father kid seasoned to taste like game (Genesis 27). The blessing passes by trickery from the hunter to the dweller in tents—from force to *mētis*, from the man of the field to the man disguised in animal skins.

The Fathers drew a moral that weighed on medieval attitudes to the chase. Jerome, expounding the psalm that promises deliverance "from the snare of the fowler"—in the Latin Psalter, *de laqueo venantium*, from the snare of the hunters—observed that Esau was a hunter because he was a sinner, and that Scripture shows no holy hunter anywhere, though it shows holy fishermen. The psalm Jerome expounded is Psalm 91 (90 in the Vulgate), the same psalm that names "the destruction that wasteth at noonday," the noonday demon of acedia discussed in Chapter Three. A single psalm of protection names both the snare of the hunters and the demon of boredom. Zaroff unites them.

Medieval Europe institutionalized the sovereignty of the hunt in law. The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle, lamenting William the Conqueror at his death in 1087, records that he set apart great preserves for deer and decreed that whoever slew a hart or a hind should be blinded: "he loved the tall deer as if he were their father." The king who loved his beasts mutilated the men who killed them.

The legal name of his preserves was *forest*, a word commonly derived from the Latin *foris*, "outside." The forest was land placed outside the common law and subject to the king's special jurisdiction, a zone of exception defined by the royal hunt. Zaroff speaks of his island in exactly these terms: "Here in my preserve on this island … I hunt more dangerous game." The preserve is the forest in its original sense, a place outside the law where the sovereign's pleasure is law.

The royal forest had its own sacrificial legend. William's son and successor, William Rufus, was killed in the New Forest in 1100 by an arrow loosed during a hunt, and his death, accidental or not, has generated speculation for nine centuries. In the twentieth century the Egyptologist and folklorist Margaret Murray, working in Frazer's wake, proposed that Rufus had been a willing divine king, killed in ritual sacrifice in his own hunting ground. The theory has not survived scholarly scrutiny, but its existence shows how naturally the Frazerian imagination of the interwar years connected the royal hunt with the murder of kings. Section 4.9 takes up that connection.

The biblical and medieval traditions thus agree on a judgment that the sporting literature of the nineteenth century labored to forget. The hunter-king is a figure of tyranny. His preserve is

a zone outside the law. His sport is a rehearsal for the hunting of men. And his fate, in the moral imagination of the tradition, is to lose his speech, his birthright, or his life. Zaroff, a mighty hunter who has hunted "every kind of game in every land," inherits the judgment along with the title.

§ 4.5

Three Days at Hautdesert: Sir Gawain and the Green Knight

The Middle English romance that offers the closest structural analogue to Connell's story survives in a single manuscript of the late fourteenth century (British Library, Cotton Nero A.x), and it entered modern scholarly prominence at almost exactly the moment Connell wrote. J. R. R. Tolkien and E. V. Gordon's edition of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* appeared in 1925. Henry L. Savage's essay "The Significance of the Hunting Scenes in *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*" (1928), which first read the romance's three hunts as commentaries on its three temptations, followed three years later. The romance's architecture can be set beside the story's, element by element.

At Camelot, at the New Year, a green giant rides into the hall and asks for "a Crystemas gomen": anyone may strike him a blow with his axe, on condition of receiving a return blow in a year and a day. Gawain beheads him; the knight picks up his head, which speaks, reminding Gawain of the bargain, and rides away. A year later Gawain travels through a winter wilderness in search of the Green Chapel. Exhausted, on Christmas Eve, he prays and sees a castle among the trees, so fair that it seemed "pared out of papure," cut out of paper (line 802). Rainsford, coming upon Zaroff's château after a day in the jungle, thinks "Mirage." The testing host's castle appears to the exhausted traveler as an unreality.

The host, Bertilak de Hautdesert, receives Gawain with extravagant courtesy and proposes a game. For three days he will hunt while Gawain rests in the castle; at the end of each day they will exchange whatever each has won. On the first day Bertilak hunts deer, on the second a great boar, on the third a fox. Each morning, while the host is in the field, his wife comes to Gawain's bedchamber and, in elaborate and witty dialogue, attempts to seduce him. The poet intercuts the scenes, so that the hunt in the forest and the "hunt" in the bedchamber run in parallel. Gawain gives the host the kisses he receives in exchange for the venison, the boar's head, and the fox's pelt. On the third day, however, he accepts from the lady a green girdle said to preserve its wearer from death, and conceals it.

The correspondences with Connell's story are structural and numerous. There is the castle in the wilderness and the gracious host who is the testing adversary. There is the three-day term. There is the hunt as frame, with the guest, not the deer, as the true quarry of the host's game. There is the bargain sealed by a gentleman's word: Bertilak's covenant of exchange, Zaroff's "I will give you my word as a gentleman and a sportsman." There is the bedchamber as the site

of the guest's danger. There is the head: the beheading game in one, the general's "collection of heads" in the other.

And there is the fox. The romance's third hunt, the climax of its venatic sequence, is the pursuit of a fox that doubles and dodges through the woods before it is killed. Rainsford, on the first night of his flight, recalls "all the lore of the fox hunt, and all the dodges of the fox." In both texts the quarry of the third hunt is the guest.

The differences are as instructive as the parallels. Gawain's test is a test of *trawthe*, fidelity to one's word, and he fails it slightly, concealing the girdle out of love of his life. The Green Knight, revealed at the Green Chapel as Bertilak, gives him a nick on the neck for the lapse and sends him home, ashamed but alive. The host is not a murderer but the instrument of a moral education, and the romance's violence is contained by its ethic. Zaroff's game has no moral content beyond itself. Its test is lethal, its examiner dies, and its outcome teaches no lesson the story is willing to state. Moreover, Rainsford, unlike Gawain, refuses the host's covenant. Asked to promise silence about the island in exchange for his freedom, he answers, "I'll agree to nothing of the kind." The modern guest declines the courtly contract that bound his medieval predecessor.

The bedchamber, too, is inverted. In the romance, the host hunts outside while the guest lies in bed and is hunted there by the lady. In the story, the guest waits in the host's bedroom while the hounds wait outside, and the scene of seduction becomes the scene of a killing. Connell's island is sexless, as Chapter Two observed, and its final bed is not the site of a temptation resisted but the prize of a combat won.

One more element of the romance bears on the end of the story. The poet describes the "breaking" of the deer after the first day's hunt with technical precision (lines 1325–1364): the dismemberment of the carcass according to rule, the morsel thrown to the ravens, and the reward of the hounds, fed on the hide. The hounds' reward had a name in the vocabulary of the medieval chase, and the name survives as an English word. The Old French *cuirée*, associated with *cuir*, hide, was the portion of the slain beast laid on its skin and given to the hounds; Middle English borrowed it as *querre*, and modern English has it as *quarry*. The quarry, etymologically, is not the animal pursued but the hounds' meal.

Zaroff's last words before the ellipsis restore the word to its origin: "One of us is to furnish a repast for the hounds. The other will sleep in this very excellent bed." The loser of the final combat becomes quarry in the oldest sense, the hounds' portion, laid out after the kill. Connell's title, which seems to name the human being as prey, names also, through this buried etymology, the meal that ends the hunt.

§ 4.6

Bluebeard's Library: The Forbidden Chamber and the Collection of the Dead

Charles Perrault's "La Barbe bleue" (1697) is the European tale of the collection of the dead, and its architecture is the architecture of Zaroff's château. A rich man, feared for his blue beard, marries a young woman and, leaving on a journey, gives her the keys to all his treasures, forbidding her only the small room at the end of the long gallery on the ground floor. She opens it. The floor is clotted with blood, and along the walls hang the bodies of his former wives. The key, dropped in the blood, cannot be cleaned. Bluebeard returns, sees the stain, and prepares to kill her; from the tower her sister watches the road—"Anne, ma sœur Anne, ne vois-tu rien venir?"—until her brothers, a dragoon and a musketeer, ride up and kill him.

Zaroff's library is Bluebeard's cabinet. The collection of the dead is kept in a room within a house of luxury, among treasures shown freely to the guest; the room's contents are the truth of the house; and the master stands to the room as a collector to his collection. But the configuration is inverted at its center. Bluebeard forbids the room and punishes curiosity. Zaroff invites the guest in—"Will you come with me to the library?"—and the guest declines: "I hope that you will excuse me tonight." Rainsford's survival begins with a refusal to look. He does not need to see the heads to know what they are, and his refusal is the first act by which he withholds from the general the recognition the general craves.

The tale's historical shadow falls in the same direction. Since the nineteenth century Bluebeard has been associated, by a conventional identification that historians treat with caution, with Gilles de Rais, Marshal of France and companion-in-arms of Joan of Arc, who was tried and executed in 1440 for the murder of children in his castles. Huysmans made Gilles the subject of *Là-bas* (1891), and Georges Bataille edited the records of his trial (*Le Procès de Gilles de Rais*, 1959). The marshal-murderer is a general in fact, a military aristocrat whose rank placed him beyond suspicion and whose castles concealed what his rank protected. Zaroff, who "commanded a division of Cossack cavalry," belongs to this lineage of the soldier-lord whose household is his crime.

The twentieth century gave the tale its most searching modern forms. Béla Bartók's opera *A kékszakállú herceg vára* (*Duke Bluebeard's Castle*, composed 1911, first performed 1918), to a libretto by Béla Balázs, turns the castle into the interior of its master. Judith, his new wife, insists on opening seven doors in turn: a torture chamber, an armory, a treasury, a garden, a prospect of his domains, a lake of tears, and the room where his former wives stand, living and silent, as his memories. Each door opens onto part of Bluebeard's soul, and the castle bleeds.

Zaroff's château can be read through the same seven doors: the cellar where the "pupils" wait; the gun room; the American securities; the jungle; the island itself; the sea; and the library. The house is the man.

Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) relocated the tale to a fin-de-siècle castle on a tidal island off the coast of Brittany, owned by a jaded Marquis who collects decadent art and keeps a museum of murdered wives behind a forbidden door. Its heroine is rescued not by her brothers but by her mother, who rides across the causeway as the tide rises and shoots the Marquis dead with her late husband's service revolver. Carter's Marquis is a connoisseur of the kind Chapter Three described, and his island is a cousin of Zaroff's.

The English branch of the tale supplies a detail of particular resonance. In "Mr. Fox," collected by Joseph Jacobs in *English Fairy Tales* (1890) and alluded to by Benedick in *Much Ado About Nothing* (I.i), a young woman visits the house of her betrothed and finds over its doors the warning "Be bold, be bold, but not too bold, / Lest that your heart's blood should run cold." Inside she finds the bodies of murdered women, and she watches, hidden, as Mr. Fox drags in another victim and cuts off her hand. At the betrothal feast she tells what she saw as though it were a dream, while Mr. Fox repeats, "It is not so, nor it was not so. And God forbid it should be so," until she produces the severed hand and her brothers cut him to pieces.

The English Bluebeard is named Fox, and in Connell's story the predator's name passes to the quarry: it is Rainsford who becomes the fox. The tale's inscription, meanwhile, describes the general's warnings to his guest, delivered in the same mixture of invitation and threat: "I'd suggest too that you avoid the big swamp in the southeast corner of the island. We call it Death Swamp. There's quicksand there." Be bold, but not too bold.

The Grimms contribute one more variant, "Fitchers Vogel" ("Fitcher's Bird," 1812), in which a sorcerer abducts three sisters in turn and forbids each a room in which he keeps a basin of dismembered bodies. The third sister outwits him, restores her sisters to life, and escapes by rolling in honey and feathers so that she passes, unrecognized, as a strange bird. The pattern recurs across the tradition: Odysseus beneath the ram, the bride in feathers, Rainsford doubling like a fox. The quarry of the devouring host escapes by becoming, or seeming to become, an animal.

§ 4.7

Prospero's Hounds: The Tempest and the Sovereign of the Island

The island sovereign who wrecks ships to bring men to his shore is older than Zaroff by three centuries. *The Tempest* (1611) opens with a storm that Prospero, the deposed Duke of Milan, has raised by his art to cast his enemies' ship onto the island he rules. Its source, as Chapter One recalled, was the wreck of the *Sea Venture* on the Bermudas, the "Devil's Islands" of sailors' dread. And its language of agency anticipates the general's. Asked by his daughter how they came ashore twelve years before, Prospero answers: "By Providence divine" (I.ii.159). Zaroff explains the arrival of his quarry in the same terms, adjusted for a sporting age: "Sometimes an

angry god of the high seas sends them to me. Sometimes, when Providence is not so kind, I help Providence a bit." Prospero's tempest is Providence helped a bit.

The play's island is governed, like Zaroff's, through servants. Ariel, the spirit, executes the magician's commands with swiftness and resentment, bargaining for his freedom. Caliban, "a savage and deformed slave," son of the witch Sycorax and dispossessed heir of the island, curses his master and plots against him. Ivan, the general's mute giant and "a bit of a savage," combines the two: Ariel's instant obedience and Caliban's assigned savagery. And Caliban's name, which a long critical tradition reads as an anagram of *cannibal*, ties the play to the Caribbean etymology that Rainsford's joke invoked on the yacht.

The play's decisive sequence is a manhunt. Caliban, with the drunken Stephano and Trinculo, resolves to murder Prospero, and the plan is Caliban's and exact. The master sleeps in the afternoon, and there they may brain him, "having first seiz'd his books": "Remember / First to possess his books; for without them / He's but a sot" (III.ii.89–93). The conspirators are distracted by the glittering garments Ariel hangs on a line, and then the sovereign looses his pack.

The stage direction reads: "A noise of hunters heard. Enter divers Spirits, in shape of dogs and hounds, and hunt them about; PROSPERO and ARIEL setting them on." Prospero cries, "Hey, Mountain, hey!"; Ariel, "Silver! there it goes, Silver!"; Prospero again, "Fury, Fury! there, Tyrant, there! hark! hark!" (IV.i.254–257). The hounds are named, like Actaeon's and Zaroff's. The island sovereign hunts the men who would usurp him with spirit-dogs, and orders his goblins to grind their joints with convulsions.

Every element of Connell's ending is present in the play, distributed differently. There is the sovereign with a library on which his power depends. There is the plot to kill him in his sleep after taking his books. There is the hunting of men with named hounds on an island where ships are wrecked by design. Caliban's conspiracy fails; Rainsford's succeeds. Rainsford waits for the general in his bedroom after the general has spent the evening in his library, and he takes not the books but the bed. In the terms of the play, the story's ending is Caliban's plot carried out by Ferdinand: the castaway son of the old world, washed ashore alone and set to labor by the island's master, completes the slave's design.

The play's own ending is the road the story does not take. Prospero, having brought his enemies into his power, renounces vengeance: "the rarer action is / In virtue than in vengeance" (V.i.27–28). He abjures his "rough magic," promises to break his staff and bury it "certain fathoms in the earth," and to drown his book "deeper than did ever plummet sound" (V.i.50–57). He frees Ariel. He acknowledges Caliban—"this thing of darkness I / Acknowledge mine" (V.i.275–276)—and prepares to return to Milan, where "every third thought shall be my grave." The sovereign of the island dissolves his sovereignty. He drowns the book on which it rested and forgives the men he has hunted.

The Tempest thus offers the only exit from the Nemorensian loop that the tradition assembled in this chapter contains: not the victory of the quarry, which reproduces the hunter, but the abdication of the hunter, which ends the hunt. The exit is imperfect. Prospero's forgiveness

is a sovereign's prerogative, exercised from a position of total power, and Caliban's fate is left unsettled; the island is not, in any clear sense, returned to him.

The Caribbean rewritings of the play in the second half of the twentieth century—George Lamming's *The Pleasures of Exile* (1960), Aimé Césaire's *Une tempête* (1969), Roberto Fernández Retamar's essay "Calibán" (1971)—read it from Caliban's side, as the drama of a colonizer whose forgiveness is a final act of possession. But the play at least imagines that the master of the island can lay down his staff.

Connell's story does not imagine this. Zaroff renounces nothing; Rainsford forgives nothing. Alyosha's "Shoot him!" and Prospero's "the rarer action is in virtue than in vengeance" stand at the two poles of the tradition's response to the hunter of men, and the story chooses Alyosha's. Chapter Eight returns to Prospero's alternative and asks whether it can be detached from the sovereignty that made it possible.

§ 4.8

Children of the Night: Dracula, the Wild Hunt, and the Hound Named Lazarus

Chapter One traced the general's smile—"red lips and pointed teeth"—to the most famous host of nineteenth-century fiction. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) is built on the inversion of hospitality this chapter has followed from the Cyclops onward, and it adds a feature that illuminates Zaroff's legalism. The Count receives Jonathan Harker at the door of his castle with a formula: "Welcome to my house! Enter freely and of your own will!" In the novel's mythology the vampire may not enter a dwelling unless he is first invited in. The predator is bound by a formal rule of consent, which he satisfies by manipulation.

Zaroff's "option" has the same form. His captives are offered a choice between the hunt and the knout, and "invariably they choose the hunt." The general insists that he does not do "the thing you suggest"—shoot men down—because "that would be barbarous"; the quarry has chosen. Both predators require the formal assent of their victims, and both obtain it by arranging the alternatives. Chapter Five analyzes the structure as a contract. Here it suffices to note its Gothic ancestry: the monster who must be invited in.

Dracula's castle contains a library, and Harker's discovery of it is one of the novel's quietly chilling moments. The room is full of English books, bound magazines, and newspapers—history, geography, politics, law, the London Directory, the Army and Navy Lists—and the Count explains that these companions have been good friends to him, that through them he has come to know great England, and that he wishes to master its speech so as to pass unremarked in London. The predator's library is a reconnaissance of the prey.

Zaroff's library serves the same purpose. "I read all books on hunting published in English, French, and Russian," he tells Rainsford, and among them is Rainsford's own. The general

knew his quarry before the quarry knew him, as the Count knew London before he set foot in it.

The Count's wolves supply the most resonant phrase for the general's hounds. "Listen to them—the children of the night. What music they make!" Zaroff's pack—huge black shapes whose eyes glitter in the dark, "let out at seven every night"—belongs to the same nocturnal order, and the general hunts by preference at dusk.

The night hunt has a mythology older than Stoker. Across northern Europe, folk tradition told of the Wild Hunt, a spectral cavalcade of huntsmen and hounds that rode the storm by night, led by Odin or Wodan, by the King Herla of Walter Map's *De nugis curialium*, or by Herne the Hunter of Windsor Forest, who, as Mistress Page recounts, "Doth all the winter-time, at still midnight, / Walk round about an oak, with great ragg'd horns" (*The Merry Wives of Windsor* IV.iv). To meet the Wild Hunt was to be swept into it or killed.

Goethe's "Erlkönig" (1782) compressed the night-hunter's method into a single line. A father rides through night and wind with his son in his arms; the boy sees the Erl-King, who tempts him with games and promises, and, when the child shrinks away, declares: "Und bist du nicht willig, so brauch' ich Gewalt"—and if you are not willing, I shall use force. The line joins the two branches of Plato's art of hunting men, persuasion and violence, with a conditional. It is the structure of Zaroff's evening with Rainsford: the dinner, the wine, the philosophy, the invitation to "capital hunting, you and I," and then, when the guest refuses, the hunt.

The pack has one named member, and Connell chose the name with care. "I'd suggest too that you avoid the big swamp in the southeast corner of the island. We call it Death Swamp. There's quicksand there. One foolish fellow tried it. The deplorable part of it was that Lazarus followed him. You can imagine my feelings, Mr. Rainsford. I loved Lazarus; he was the finest hound in my pack."

The Gospels contain two men named Lazarus, and the story invokes both. The Lazarus of John (11:1–44) is the friend whom Jesus raises from the dead after four days in the tomb. The hound of that name dies in a swamp and does not rise. The resurrection belongs instead to the quarry. Rainsford, whom the general believes drowned after his leap from the cliff, returns that night, standing in the general's bedroom like a man risen from the sea. "Rainsford!" the general screams. "How in God's name did you get here?" The story's true Lazarus is the man.

The Lazarus of Luke (16:19–31) is the beggar of a parable whose fit with the story is uncanny. "There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day: And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores, And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores." Both men die. The beggar is carried to Abraham's bosom; the rich man, in torment, begs that Lazarus dip his finger in water to cool his tongue, and is told that "between us and you there is a great gulf fixed."

Zaroff is Dives: a rich man who fares sumptuously every day, on champagne and borsch and crêpes Suzette, while the poor wait at his gate, or rather in his cellar. He has given the beggar's name to his finest dog, and he mourns the dog more than any man. The parable's

reversal arrives on schedule. In Luke, the rich man's dogs licked the beggar's sores; on Ship-Trap Island, the rich man's dogs eat the rich man. The great gulf fixed between the château and the cellar, between the general's table and its crumbs, is crossed in the story's last lines, when the hounds receive their repast and the man from the sea sleeps in the rich man's bed.

§ 4.9

The King of the Wood: Nemi, the Fugitive, and the Bed

The mythic structure that governs the story's ending is the one with which James George Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* (1890; abridged edition 1922). In the Alban hills south of Rome, beside the lake of Nemi that the ancients called Diana's Mirror, stood the sacred grove of Diana Nemorensis, Diana of the Wood. "In this sacred grove there grew a certain tree round which at any time of the day, and probably far into the night, a grim figure might be seen to prowl. In his hand he carried a drawn sword, and he kept peering warily about him as if at every instant he expected to be set upon by an enemy. He was a priest and a murderer; and the man for whom he looked was sooner or later to murder him and hold the priesthood in his stead. Such was the rule of the sanctuary. A candidate for the priesthood could only succeed to office by slaying the priest, and having slain him, he retained office till he was himself slain by a stronger or a craftier."

Frazer adds the detail that completes the correspondence. According to the tradition he followed, the challenger had to be a runaway slave. If he could break a bough from the sacred tree, he won the right to fight the priest in single combat, and if he slew him, he reigned in his stead with the title *Rex Nemorensis*, King of the Wood. The successor of the hunter-king was, by rule, a fugitive.

The rule of Nemi is the plot of "The Most Dangerous Game." A fugitive, hunted through the wood of a sanctuary consecrated to the hunt, kills the man who holds the office and takes his place. Each element of the rite has its counterpart. The goddess of the grove is Diana the huntress, whose other great myth, Actaeon's, governs the general's death by his hounds. The priest-king is past his prime—"a tall man past middle age, for his hair was a vivid white"—and his vitality, by his own confession, is failing: "Last night I detected traces of my old complaint." The challenger is a fugitive in the most literal sense, a man who has spent three days running for his life. The bough he breaks is a sapling, bent back to drive a knife into the king's servant. And the combat is single, announced as a challenge and accepted as a duel: "Get ready, General Zaroff." "On guard, Rainsford."

Frazer interpreted the rite through his theory of the divine king, whose life was bound to the fertility of the land and who had therefore to be killed before his strength declined, lest the world decline with him. Later anthropology dismantled the theory, but its imaginative force shaped the 1920s. T. S. Eliot acknowledged it in the notes to *The Waste Land* (1922). Freud built *Totem und Tabu* (1913) on Frazer's materials, imagining a primal horde in which the

sons kill the father who monopolizes the women, eat him in a totem meal, and, out of guilt, institute the first prohibitions.

Connell's ending is legible in both registers. In the Frazerian, it is the replacement of an exhausted king by a vigorous successor. In the Freudian, it is a parricide: the young man kills the old man who possessed the island and takes his bed, and the totem meal is delegated to the hounds.

But the story differs from both in one particular, and the difference is its meaning. Frazer's king cannot sleep. He prowls his grove by night, sword drawn, peering about him, because he knows the rule of the sanctuary. Shakespeare's usurper cannot sleep either: "Methought I heard a voice cry 'Sleep no more! / Macbeth does murder sleep'" (*Macbeth* II.ii.35–36). Rainsford sleeps. "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided."

The sentence admits two readings. On the first, Rainsford sleeps because he is innocent: he killed, in a fair fight, a man who deserved to die, and his conscience is clear. This is the reading the story's surface invites and its readers usually accept—Alyosha's "Shoot him!" carried through to a good night's rest. On the second, Rainsford sleeps because he does not yet know what he has become. He has acquired the office of the King of the Wood without its knowledge, the bed without the vigil. The rule of the sanctuary has not been abolished by his victory; it has been fulfilled. The island remains; the lights in the channel remain; the hounds remain, fed and quiet; the cellar, presumably, still holds a dozen men from the *San Lucar*. And somewhere at sea, a stronger or a craftier is already on his way.

The thesis of venatic reversibility holds that the second reading is the structurally correct one, whatever the story's surface intends, and the bed's mythic genealogy supports it. The most famous bed in Western literature is the one Odysseus built in his house on Ithaca around the trunk of a living olive tree, so that it could not be moved. When Penelope, testing the stranger who claims to be her husband, orders the bed brought out of the chamber, his outrage at the impossibility reveals him (*Odyssey* 23.177–204). The bed is the sign of the sovereign's identity, and it is rooted in a tree. At Nemi the king guards a tree; on Ithaca the king sleeps in one. Rainsford's "very excellent bed" is the tree of the grove converted into furniture and won by killing.

Walter Benjamin, three years before Connell's story, gave this structure a political name. In "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921), he described the history of law as an oscillation between law-making violence, which founds an order, and law-preserving violence, which maintains it, until new forces, or forces formerly suppressed, overcome the old law-making violence and found a new law, itself destined to decay. Benjamin called this cycle mythic and hoped for a violence of another kind that would break it.

Rainsford's killing of Zaroff is law-making violence in Benjamin's sense. It founds a new sovereignty on the island, which the old law-preserving apparatus—the hounds, the lights, the house—will now serve. The cycle is the Nemorensian loop, and the story ends at the moment of foundation, leaving the next turn of the cycle to the reader.

The story conceals the founding act itself. Between "On guard, Rainsford" and "He had never slept in a better bed" stands an ellipsis, the only consequential violence in the text left unnarrated. René Girard argued that the violence on which an order is founded is always hidden by the narratives that issue from it, which present the victim's death as just, necessary, or self-incurred (*Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*, 1978). Connell's ellipsis is that concealment in typographical form. The reader is spared the sight of the killing on which the new order rests and is given instead the sovereign's sleep. Chapter Eight returns to the ellipsis as the place where the venatic paradigm hides its mechanism of succession.

§ 4.10

A Perspicuous Representation

Wittgenstein's objection to Frazer, recalled in Chapter One, was that the anthropologist explained where he should have arranged: the value of comparative material lay not in a hypothesis about origins but in a perspicuous representation that made connections visible. The myths assembled in this chapter are offered in that spirit, and Table 4.1 arranges them.

Read down its columns, the arrangement shows that Connell's plot is a composite of four mythic structures. The first is the devouring host—Polyphemus, Lycaon, Bluebeard, Dracula—whose hospitality is the form of his predation. The second is the hunter hunted—Actaeon—whose instrument turns upon him. The third is the brigand destroyed by his own device—Sinis, Sciron, Procrustes—whose method returns through the hero. The fourth is succession by murder—Nemi—in which the fugitive who kills the king becomes the king.

Each of these structures, in its traditional form, carries its own resolution, and each resolution is administered by a power beyond the actors. The devouring host is punished by Zeus's thunderbolt or the brothers' swords; the hunter's transgression is punished by the goddess; the brigands' violence is returned by a hero whose labors the gods sanction; the King of the Wood is replaced according to the rule of the sanctuary, a law older than any of its priests. The myths locate the meaning of the violence outside the violence itself—in the divine, the sacred, the order of the cosmos.

Connell's innovation is to combine all four structures in a single plot and to frame the combination as a game. The game supplies what the gods once supplied: a rule that makes the outcome intelligible and, apparently, just. When Rainsford appears in the bedroom, the general's first response, after the scream, is the language of sport: "I congratulate you. You have won the game." The Nemi succession is presented as the result of a fair contest, the Actaeonic death as a forfeit, the talion as a score. The game secularizes the myth. It replaces Diana with a rulebook and Providence with a three-day term.

Rainsford's reply refuses the secularization. "I am still a beast at bay," he says. "Get ready, General Zaroff." By its own rules the game is over; the quarry has survived; and Rainsford

TABLE 4.1

A perspicuous representation of the hunted guest.

MYTH OR TALE	HOST OR HUNTER	GUEST OR QUARRY	INSTRUMENT AND OUTCOME	CORRESPONDENCE IN CONNELL
Polyphemus (*Odyssey* 9)	The Cyclops, a devouring host	Odysseus, "Nobody"	The gift of being eaten last; escape by *mētis*, beneath the rams	Zaroff's gifts of knife, food, and start; Rainsford's fame as scent
Lycaon (*Metamorphoses* I)	A king who tests his guest	Jupiter in disguise	Murder planned in sleep; host turned wolf	The host's lethal test; the general's lupine face
Actaeon (*Metamorphoses* III)	Diana, goddess of the hunt	Actaeon, hunter turned stag	His own named hounds; speech fails him	Rainsford "at bay"; Zaroff as the hounds' repast; the hunter's scream
Theseus and the brigands (Plutarch, *Theseus* 8–11)	Sinis, Sciron, Procrustes	Travelers, then Theseus	Bent pine, cliff, bed; each brigand killed by his own device	The sapling knife-trap; the cliff leap; the host's bed
Nimrod and Esau (Genesis 10, 25, 27)	The hunter-king; the hunter-son	Men; a birthright	The preserve; force defeated by *mētis*	The polyglot island; the "preserve" outside the law
Sir Gawain and the Green Knight	Bertilak, the testing host	Gawain	Three hunts, a bedchamber, a beheading game; a nick, not a death	Three days; the fox; the gentleman's word; the heads; the hounds' meal
Bluebeard, "Mr. Fox," "Fitcher's Bird"	A collector of the dead	Wife or bride	The forbidden chamber; rescue by kin or escape in feathers	The library of heads; Rainsford's refusal to look
The Tempest	Prospero, sovereign of the island	Caliban, Stephano, Trinculo	Tempest, spirit-hounds, the book; abdication and forgiveness	"Help Providence"; the library and the bed; the road not taken
Dracula the Wild Hunt; Luke 16	The Count; the night huntsman; Dives	Harker; travelers; the beggar	Consent extracted; the night pack; the reversal of rich and poor	The "option"; hunting at dusk; the hounds eat their master
Nemi (*The Golden Bough*)	The *Rex Nemorensis*	A runaway slave	A bough and single combat; succession by murder	The fugitive becomes king; the bed; the ellipsis

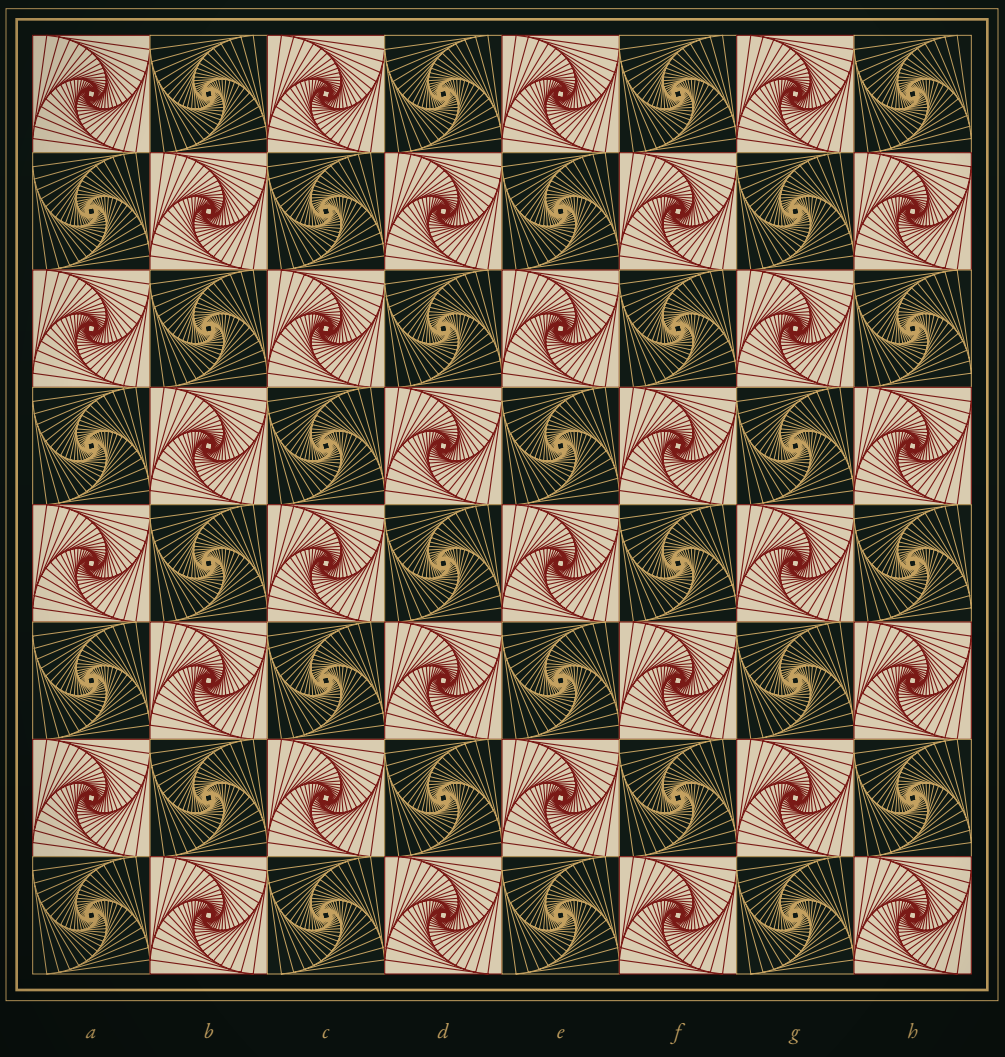
declines to accept that the rules have settled anything. He reopens the hunt outside the game, in the domain of mythic violence that the game had claimed to contain.

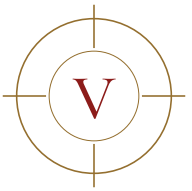
The general's last act is to reframe even this as a contest with stakes: "Splendid! One of us is to furnish a repast for the hounds. The other will sleep in this very excellent bed. On guard, Rainsford." At the last moment the game reasserts its form, naming a prize and a forfeit, and the myth proceeds beneath it to its ancient conclusion.

The relation between the game and the myth—between the rules that claim to govern the hunt and the sacral violence that actually decides it—is the subject of Chapter Five. The general believed that rules could turn the hunting of men into sport. The story's ending suggests that the rules are the mask the myth wears in a secular age, and that beneath the "sporting proposition" the oldest structure of sovereignty is still at work.



“Outdoor chess!”





CHAPTER FIVE

The Rules of the Game

Play, Contract, Recognition, and the Sporting Proposition

§ 5.1

The Cat of the Fable: Play Before Culture

The hunt on Ship-Trap Island begins, for Rainsford, with a moment of literary self-consciousness. After two hours of flight through the jungle, having "executed a series of intricate loops" and doubled "on his trail again and again, recalling all the lore of the fox hunt, and all the dodges of the fox," he resolves to change his tactics: "I have played the fox, now I must play the cat of the fable." He climbs a tree and settles into its crotch to wait.

The fable is Aesop's, and it reached Connell's readers through a long chain of retellings, among them La Fontaine's "Le Chat et le Renard" (*Fables* IX.14) and the Grimms' "Der Fuchs und die Katze." The fox boasts to the cat of the hundred tricks in his bag; the cat confesses that she has only one. The hounds arrive. The cat springs into a tree and is safe; the fox, deliberating among his stratagems, is caught. The moral prefers one sure resource to a multitude of clever ones. Rainsford, having exhausted the fox's repertoire, adopts the cat's.

The fable fails him, in one of the story's most carefully staged reversals. At dawn the general follows the trail to the foot of the tree and pauses. "Very deliberately he blew a smoke ring into the air; then he turned his back on the tree and walked carelessly away." Rainsford understands: "The general was playing with him! The general was saving him for another day's sport! The Cossack was the cat; he was the mouse. Then it was that Rainsford knew the full meaning of terror."

The passage turns on a second, unwritten fable, the oldest image of predatory play: the cat with the mouse. The cat that plays with its prey does not need to; it could kill at once. It releases the mouse, lets it run, pins it again, and the play consists precisely in the suspension of the kill. The terror Rainsford discovers is not the fear of death but the knowledge that his death has been postponed for the predator's amusement—that his flight is a form of the hunter's

pleasure. The fable he chose cast him as the cat; the story recasts him as the mouse. He has misread his genre.

Montaigne, in the "Apologie de Raymond Sebond," posed the question that the scene inverts: "Quand je me joue à ma chatte, qui sait si elle passe son temps de moi plus que je ne fais d'elle?"—when I play with my cat, who knows whether she is not passing her time with me more than I with her? (*Essais* II.12). Montaigne's question unsettles the hierarchy of player and played; the cat may be the one who plays. Zaroff's island answers the question with brutal clarity. The hunter knows who plays with whom, and the quarry's discovery of the answer is the moment of terror.

Johan Huizinga opened *Homo Ludens* (1938) with the observation that play is older than culture: animals did not wait for human beings to teach them to play. Young dogs, he noted, invite one another to play with ceremonious gestures, keep to a rule against biting hard, and pretend to be furious. Gregory Bateson, watching monkeys at a San Francisco zoo, gave the observation its theoretical form in "A Theory of Play and Fantasy" (1955). Play is possible, he argued, only because animals can exchange the signal "this is play," a message about messages that frames the action: the playful nip refers to the bite while withholding what the bite would mean. Play depends on a frame that suspends the consequences of the acts it contains.

Zaroff's game is a play frame in which the nip is the bite. Its frame is elaborately marked—rules, terms, a start, a sporting vocabulary, a host's courtesies—yet within the frame the acts mean exactly what they would mean outside it: the quarry dies. The cat's play with the mouse is the natural model of this collapse. The frame "this is play" is posted by the predator, for the predator, and it suspends nothing for the prey. The mouse does not know it is playing; the cat does not need it to.

The predator's play has one further feature that bears on the general's psychology. The cat's game is not an alternative to the kill but its prolongation; the play extends the pleasure of the hunt by delaying its consummation. Ortega's dictum, examined in Chapter Three, that one kills in order to have hunted, finds here its darkest gloss: the hunter who most enjoys the hunt postpones the kill as long as he can. Zaroff, sparing Rainsford in the tree, is a cat with a mouse he does not want to finish too soon. "I shall be back," he calls after the mancatcher wounds him. "I shall be back." The repetition is at once a promise and a pleasure.

The story's game, then, begins from an asymmetry that no rule can cure. One party knows that the activity is play and enjoys it as such; the other knows only that he is running for his life. The theories of play and games that follow—Huizinga's magic circle, Caillois's categories, Suits's definition, the mathematics of pursuit—will each be tested against this asymmetry, and each will be found to describe the game from the cat's side.

§ 5.2

The Magic Circle and the Spoilsport: Huizinga

Huizinga's definition of play, the most influential in the literature, specifies its formal marks. Play is a voluntary activity, knowingly set apart from ordinary life as something "not serious" while utterly absorbing those who play; it serves no material interest; it unfolds within its own limits of time and space, by fixed rules and in good order; and it fosters communities that mark themselves off from the everyday world (*Homo Ludens*, ch. 1). Play takes place within what Huizinga called a magic circle—the arena, the card table, the stage, the tennis court, the temple, the court of justice—a consecrated space within which special rules obtain.

Ship-Trap Island satisfies the definition with a precision that is itself an argument. It is bounded in space: the island, its jungle, its swamp, its cliffs. It is bounded in time: three days, from the quarry's start to "midnight of the third day." It has fixed rules: a start, a weapon, a term, a prize. It is set apart from ordinary life by the sea, as the arena is set apart by its walls. And its one permanent player lives in it with the absorption Huizinga considered play's mark: "Every day I hunt, and I never grow bored now."

But Huizinga's first criterion is freedom, and on that criterion the definition breaks. Play under command, he insisted, is no longer play; at most it is a forced imitation of play. The quarry on Ship-Trap Island plays under command, with the knout as the alternative. For them the magic circle is not a consecrated space of freedom but a cage drawn in its shape. The general's game satisfies every formal criterion of play except the one that makes play play, and it satisfies that one for the general alone. It is a magic circle with one magician.

Huizinga's account of the play community's enemies illuminates the ending. The *cheat*, he observed, pretends to play the game and so at least acknowledges the magic circle; he breaks the rules while respecting the frame. The *spoilsport* is worse. He trespasses against the play-world itself, exposing its relativity and fragility and robbing it of the illusion—*in-lusio*, literally "in play"—on which it depends. The play community forgives the cheat and casts out the spoilsport, because the spoilsport threatens its existence.

Zaroff, on the last night, regards Rainsford as a spoilsport: "of course, the American hadn't played the game—so thought the general as he tasted his after-dinner liqueur." The general believes his quarry escaped the game by dying, leaping from the cliff into the sea. A quarry that kills itself has not lost the game but abolished it, depriving the hunter of the outcome the rules were designed to produce. Rainsford's actual offense is graver. He has left the game's space and entered the one place on the island the game was not supposed to touch: the general's bedroom, which the general locks himself into for the night, inside a house guarded by the hounds. He has crossed from the magic circle into the house that drew it.

Huizinga's spoilsport reveals the fragility of the play-world. Rainsford reveals that the play-world was never separate from the world. The hunt was presented as a game, enclosed in rules and suspended from ordinary life; its quarry, by reaching the bedroom, shows that the game had always been continuous with the household, the property, and the sovereignty

of its master. The general's first words—"How in God's name did you get here?"—are the bewilderment of a player discovering that the circle has no edge.

Huizinga understood that the play-element could be counterfeited. In *In de schaduwen van morgen* (*In the Shadow of Tomorrow*, 1935), he diagnosed in the mass politics of his time a "puerilism," a false play that mimicked the forms of the game—uniforms, slogans, parades, rituals—while abandoning its spirit of fair contest and free assent. The diagnosis fits Zaroff exactly: his rules mimic the forms of fair play while abolishing its condition. Huizinga paid for his diagnosis. Held hostage by the German occupation authorities from 1942 and then confined in internal exile, he died in February 1945, three months before the liberation of the Netherlands.

The magic circle has a last property that Huizinga emphasized and that the story exploits. Within it the player is absorbed, and absorption is a form of forgetting: the world outside the circle ceases, for the duration of the game, to matter. This is the property that makes play the supreme diversion in Pascal's sense, the activity that turns the player most completely away from himself. It is also the property that made Ship-Trap Island possible. The general's hunt is a magic circle drawn to keep out the knowledge of what he is doing. Rainsford's entrance into the bedroom is the return of that knowledge, and the general's scream is its sound.

§ 5.3

Agôn and Its Corruptions: Caillois

Roger Caillois, in *Les Jeux et les hommes* (1958), refined Huizinga's account into a typology. Games, he argued, answer to four fundamental attitudes: *agôn*, competition, in which adversaries meet under conditions of artificial equality so that the winner's superiority is incontestable; *alea*, chance, in which the player surrenders to fortune; *mimicry*, simulation, in which the player becomes another; and *ilinx*, vertigo, in which the player seeks the voluptuous panic of a perception thrown off balance. Across all four runs a continuum from *paidia*, free improvisation, to *ludus*, the discipline of rules and of difficulty deliberately sought.

Zaroff's game is, in its own self-understanding, a pure *agôn*. "Your brain against mine. Your woodcraft against mine. Your strength and stamina against mine. Outdoor chess!" Caillois observed that *agôn* requires equality of chances, and that where adversaries are unequal, equality must be manufactured by handicaps: the head start, the weighted horse, the stronger player's renunciation of an advantage. The general's rules are a handicapping system. He grants the quarry three hours' start, food, a knife, and such knowledge of the terrain as he chooses to impart; he arms himself only with "a pistol of the smallest caliber and range." His complaint about the Amazon jaguars was precisely that their inferiority had made *agôn* impossible, and his invention restores it.

The other three attitudes are present on the island too, distributed between the players with an asymmetry that amounts to a sociology of play. *Alea* enters with the stakes. "And the stake is

not without value, eh?" the general asks, and earlier: "I'll wager you'll forget your notions when you go hunting with me." The idiom is the gambler's. The hunter, who risks little, wagers; the quarry, who risks everything, is the wager.

Ilinx is the hunter's reward and the quarry's condition. Zaroff hunts for the thrill—"You've a genuine new thrill in store for you, Mr. Rainsford"; "I live for danger"—and the thrill is a controlled vertigo, a panic enjoyed from a position of safety, like the fairground ride. The quarry suffers the same vertigo without control. When Rainsford discovers that the general is playing with him, he knows "the full meaning of terror." The hunter's *ilinx* is the quarry's terror seen from above.

Mimicry is the quarry's survival. Rainsford plays roles: he has "played the fox," then "the cat of the fable"; he imitates animals in order to evade the hunter of animals; on the third day he learns "how an animal at bay feels," and at the end he calls himself "still a beast at bay." Simulation, which in Caillois's scheme is a pleasure of make-believe, is on the island a technique of escape, the art Detienne and Vernant called *mētis*. The general practices a mimicry of his own—the mimicry of a gentleman, a costume of evening clothes and courtesy that disguises a predator—and his performance is flawless until the last scene, when he screams.

Caillois's most important contribution, for this reading, is his account of the corruption of games. Each of the four attitudes, he argued, degenerates when the boundary between play and ordinary life is breached and the play-impulse escapes its frame. *Agôn* corrupted becomes violence and the will to power, a rivalry that no longer respects rules or adversaries. *Alea* corrupted becomes superstition. *Mimicry* corrupted becomes alienation, the loss of the self in the role. *Ilinx* corrupted becomes addiction: the drug, the drink, the compulsive pursuit of vertigo.

Ship-Trap Island is a catalogue of these corruptions. Its *agôn* is violence in the costume of contest. Its *alea* is the wager of another man's life. Its *mimicry* is the general's gentlemanly masquerade. Its *ilinx* is the addiction that Chapter Three traced in the general's ennui, the escalating need for a stronger stimulus. The general's game is not play spoiled by an external intrusion of violence. It is play whose frame was drawn around violence from the start.

Caillois's continuum exposes one further feature of the general's design. *Ludus*, the pole of rule and deliberate difficulty, lies entirely on the hunter's side. It is the general who imposes obstacles on himself and delights in mastering them. The quarry's activity is pure *paidia*, the improvisation of a creature without rules, running, hiding, building what traps it can. The story's sympathies, and its outcome, lie with the improviser. Rainsford wins because he plays without rules against a player bound by his own, and his last move—the swim, the bedroom, the challenge—abandons the rules altogether. The *ludus* of the hunter is defeated by the *paidia* of the hunted.

§ 5.4

Unnecessary Obstacles: Suits and the Game for One Player

Bernard Suits, in *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia* (1978), offered the most rigorous definition of game-playing in the philosophical literature, and compressed it into a phrase: playing a game is "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles." The fuller analysis distinguishes four elements. Every game has a *prelusory goal*, a state of affairs that could be achieved independently of the game, such as getting a ball into a hole. It has *lusory means*, the means the rules permit. It has *constitutive rules*, which forbid more efficient means in favor of less efficient ones: one may not carry the ball to the hole by hand. And it requires a *lusory attitude*, the acceptance of the constitutive rules just because they make the activity possible.

The general's game fits the analysis exactly from his side. Its prelusory goal is the death of a man, a state of affairs Zaroff could bring about at once by far more efficient means: a rifle, the dogs from the outset, Ivan and his knout. Its constitutive rules forbid those means in favor of inefficient ones: the smallest pistol, the three-hour start, the three-day limit, the dogs held back. And the general holds the lusory attitude with an aesthete's purity. He accepts his handicaps precisely because they make the hunt a game, and he resorts to the dogs only reluctantly, as a concession that diminishes his satisfaction: "One almost did win. I eventually had to use the dogs."

From the quarry's side, the analysis fails at its first word. Suits's definition requires that the attempt be *voluntary*, and the quarry's attempt is not. The sailor from the cellar does not accept unnecessary obstacles in order to make an activity possible; he faces necessary ones in order to stay alive. His goal, survival, is not a prelusory goal adopted for the sake of a game but the most serious end a creature can have. He holds no lusory attitude. For him the activity is not a game but a predicament.

The general's game is therefore, in Suits's terms, a game for one player. Its other participant is not a player but a component, a source of unnecessary obstacles for the general to overcome. Zaroff's chosen figure, "Outdoor chess!", is more exact than he intends. In chess the pieces do not play. Rainsford, invited to the board as an opponent, discovers that he is also a piece, and that the general's only true adversary is the general's own boredom.

Suits's book has a second thesis, and it bears on the general's whole mode of existence. In the book's utopian dialogue, the Grasshopper argues that in a world where every instrumental need had been met—where machines supplied food, shelter, and everything else, and no activity was needed as a means to anything—the only activity left worth pursuing would be game-playing, the voluntary overcoming of unnecessary obstacles. Games are what the ideal of existence would consist of once necessity had been abolished.

Zaroff lives in the Grasshopper's utopia. His American securities have abolished necessity; his servants supply every need; nothing he does is required as a means to anything else. What remains to him is play, and the story is an experiment in what becomes of such a life when its games are exhausted. The general has played every game the animal world offered and found

the obstacles too easy to be worth overcoming. His solution is to seek the obstacle that is hardest because it is most like himself: another player. And since no player would voluntarily enter a game whose stake is his own life, the general must manufacture his opponents by coercion, converting a utopia of games into a dystopia of the hunted.

Suits's dialogue does not hide the difficulty. Its closing pages concede that the inhabitants of such a utopia might come to feel the emptiness of mere games and long for the seriousness that necessity once supplied. The general's game is the extreme form of that longing. It restores seriousness to play by making the stakes real for one of the players, and it obtains its seriousness by stealing it from the quarry's need.

The analysis yields a precise formulation of the double game. The most dangerous game is the game whose prelusory goal is a human life, played by one party with a lusory attitude and by the other under necessity. Its rules make it appear, to the one who holds the attitude, as a contest among equals overcoming unnecessary obstacles. To the one who does not, it is the oldest of predicaments, dressed as sport.

§ 5.5

The Option: Consent, Contract, and the Knout

"Suppose he refuses to be hunted?" Rainsford asks. The general's answer is the story's most compressed political theory. "Oh, I give him his option, of course. He need not play that game if he doesn't wish to. If he does not wish to hunt, I turn him over to Ivan. Ivan once had the honor of serving as official knouter to the Great White Czar, and he has his own ideas of sport. Invariably, Mr. Rainsford, invariably they choose the hunt."

The knout, the heavy lash of the Russian penal system, could kill in a few dozen strokes, and its abolition in the 1840s was hailed as a humanitarian reform. Zaroff's offer of a choice between the hunt and the knout presents the hunt as the humane alternative and the captives' unanimity as consent. The structure is that of the liberal contract in a single sentence: two parties, an offer, an alternative, a choice freely made. It is also the structure that the liberal tradition's critics had long since dissected.

Rousseau's chapter "Du droit du plus fort" in *Du contrat social* (1762, I.3) refutes the general's credo and his option together. "Le plus fort n'est jamais assez fort pour être toujours le maître, s'il ne transforme sa force en droit et l'obéissance en devoir"—the strongest is never strong enough to be always master unless he transforms his strength into right and obedience into duty. The general's rules are that transformation: force rendered as a game, obedience as the acceptance of a sporting proposition. And Rousseau states the objection that disqualifies the option: "Céder à la force est un acte de nécessité, non de volonté"—to yield to force is an act of necessity, not of will. The sailor who chooses the hunt over the knout does not consent. He yields.

Hobbes, as Chapter Two observed, reached the opposite conclusion: covenants extorted by fear are valid in the state of nature, and the man who covenants to pay a ransom for his life is bound by it. Ship-Trap Island is where Hobbes and Rousseau meet. Its master behaves as a Hobbesian sovereign, extracting covenants by fear; its story vindicates Rousseau, for the moment the quarry ceases to fear, as Rainsford does in the bedroom, the covenant dissolves and force meets force.

Marx carried Rousseau's objection from the political contract to the economic one. The worker who sells his labor-power, he observed, is free in a double sense: free as a person to dispose of his labor-power as his own commodity, and free of every other means of living, "short of everything necessary for the realisation of his labour-power" (*Capital* I, ch. 6, trans. Moore and Aveling). He chooses to work because the alternative is destitution, and the contract that records his choice is formally free and materially compelled. The general's option is the labor contract with its terms exposed. The captive is free to choose the hunt, and free of every other choice but the knout.

The parallel is not merely analogical. The men in the general's cellar are seamen, and their presence on the tramp ships from which the general gathers them was itself the outcome of contracts of this kind: articles signed in colonial ports, often on terms inferior to those of European crews, by men whose alternative was want. The general's option is the last in a chain of options that brought them to his island.

Carole Pateman, in *The Sexual Contract* (1988), argued that contract is the specifically modern means of creating relations of subordination: that the employment contract, the marriage contract, and their kin present as free agreements arrangements whose substance is command and obedience. The general's game is a limit case of her thesis, a contract of subordination whose subordinate party is subordinated to death, in a sporting form that presents the arrangement as an agreement among equals.

Consent serves the general in one further way, which connects his option to the Gothic tradition examined in Chapter Four. Dracula cannot enter unless invited; Zaroff cannot hunt unless his quarry "chooses." The requirement does not constrain the predator. It relieves him, transferring responsibility from the one who arranges the alternatives to the one who chooses between them. "I assure you I do not do the thing you suggest," the general says when Rainsford accuses him of shooting down men. "That would be barbarous." The quarry's choice makes the killing the quarry's own act, the result of a game he agreed to play and lost. The option is the alibi of the hunt.

Rainsford alone refuses the option, and his refusal is instructive. Offered the hunt, he declines: "No, general, I will not hunt." The general answers with the alternative—"you will find my idea of sport more diverting than Ivan's"—and Rainsford, understanding, yields to it. But when the general proposes the contract's last term, silence about the island in exchange for freedom, Rainsford refuses outright: "I'll agree to nothing of the kind." He accepts the necessity and withholds the consent. He will run because he must; he will not sign. The

distinction, which Rousseau would have recognized, is the first sign that the quarry will not be bound by the game.

§ 5.6

The Training School: Sovereignty, Discipline, and the Care of the Quarry

"We'll visit my training school," smiled the general. "It's in the cellar. I have about a dozen pupils down there now." The vocabulary is pedagogical, and it is chosen with care. The captives are "pupils"; their hunt is an examination; their performance is graded—"Poor specimens," "a very inferior lot," men who "afford only the most elementary sort of problem." The general's island contains a school.

Latin supplies the word that joins the general's two vocabularies. *Ludus* meant play, game, and sport. It also meant school, the elementary school in which children learned their letters. And it meant the gladiatorial training school, the *ludus gladiatorius*, in which men destined for the arena were housed, fed, drilled, and assessed; the largest, the Ludus Magnus, stood beside the Colosseum. Gladiators were fed for strength on barley and beans—Pliny records that they were nicknamed *hordearii*, "barley-men"—and kept in condition by their trainers, since a well-conditioned fighter made a better spectacle. Zaroff's cellar is a *ludus* in all three senses. "They get plenty of good food and exercise. They get into splendid physical condition."

Michel Foucault's genealogy of modern power distinguishes three regimes, and the general's island contains all three. The first is sovereignty: the power to take life or let live, exercised spectacularly on the body, whose emblem Foucault found in the execution of the regicide Damiens in 1757, with which *Surveiller et punir* (1975) opens. Ivan, the "official knouter to the Great White Czar," is the island's sovereign executioner, and the knout its instrument of spectacle.

The second regime is discipline: the power that trains bodies in schools, barracks, hospitals, and workshops, organizing their time, their movements, and their examination in order to make them docile and useful. The "training school" in the cellar is the island's disciplinary institution, and the hunt is its examination.

The third regime Foucault called biopower: the power that makes live and lets die, that takes charge of life itself—its health, its nourishment, its reproduction—for the sake of a population's productivity (*La Volonté de savoir*, 1976; *Il faut défendre la société*, lectures of 1975–76). The general's solicitude for his captives' condition is biopower in miniature. He feeds them, exercises them, and cares for their bodies, not out of humanity but because healthy quarry make a better hunt. Their life is fostered in order to be taken.

The coexistence of the three regimes on one island is the story's most modern feature. Foucault's history describes a succession in which sovereign power gives way to discipline and

biopower without vanishing, and the twentieth century's most terrible institutions combined all three. Ship-Trap Island anticipates the combination at the scale of a single household. Its master holds the sovereign right of death, administers a disciplinary school, and practices a biopolitical care of the bodies he will kill. The general's offer of a choice between the knout and the hunt is a choice between the old sovereignty and the new—between death by spectacle and death after training. Invariably, he says, they choose the new.

The care of the quarry has an older and humbler model, and the story's agricultural vocabulary points to it. The general "stocks" his island: "Oh, it isn't here naturally, of course. I have to stock the island." The verb belongs to the game preserve and the farm. Game was stocked, fed, protected from poachers, and released for the gun; the pheasants of the great British estates were reared by keepers in their thousands each season to be driven over the guns. Livestock was fattened for slaughter. The general's captives occupy both positions at once: game, released for the chase, and livestock, fed for the kill. The cellar is a rearing pen.

Agamben, extending Foucault, argued that the paradigm of modern biopolitics is not the city but the camp: the space in which the state of exception becomes the rule and life is managed in its bare biological dimension, stripped of any legal status (*Homo Sacer*, 1995, Part III). The general's cellar is a camp in Agamben's sense, a space outside every law but the master's, in which a dozen men from the *San Lucar* exist solely as bodies to be maintained for use. That it is also called a school is not incidental. The camp, too, had its pedagogy: the regimen, the roll call, the selection.

The examination at the end of the general's course is the hunt, and its grading is final. His vocabulary of assessment—"problem," "specimen," "pupil," "elementary"—is the vocabulary of the schoolmaster and the naturalist, and its effect is to convert the killing of men into the evaluation of performances. The pupils fail the examination by dying. The one who passes it, Rainsford, earns not his freedom but the master's place.

§ 5.7

Outdoor Chess: The Mathematics of Pursuit

"Outdoor chess!" The general's figure has a history, and the history is military. Chess descends from the Indian *chaturanga*, whose pieces represented the four arms of an army—infantry, cavalry, elephants, and chariots—and it was taught for centuries as a school of strategy. In 1824 a Prussian officer, Georg von Reisswitz, introduced the *Kriegsspiel*, a war game played on maps with blocks and dice, which became a standard instrument of officer training across Europe. A general who calls the hunting of men "outdoor chess" speaks the language of the staff college. By the rules of the board he also plays the knight: the piece that stands for the cavalry Zaroff once commanded, and the only piece that leaps.

In the decade of the story, chess became an object of mathematics. Ernst Zermelo proved in 1913 that in a finite game like chess, with perfect information and no chance, either one player

can force a win or both can force a draw; the game has, in principle, a determinate outcome under perfect play. In 1928 John von Neumann published "Zur Theorie der Gesellschaftsspiele," the paper that founded modern game theory. Its central result, the minimax theorem, showed that every finite two-person zero-sum game has a value that each player can guarantee by an optimal strategy—a strategy that, in games of hidden information, may require the player to randomize, choosing among his moves by chance so that the opponent cannot predict him.

The general's game is zero-sum in the strictest sense: "One of us is to furnish a repast for the hounds. The other will sleep in this very excellent bed." It is also, unlike chess, a game of hidden information. The quarry hides, the hunter seeks, and neither sees the other's moves. Von Neumann's theory clarifies what the general means when he says that the animal "had nothing but his legs and his instinct" and that his own success had become "a mathematical certainty." A creature acting on instinct plays what game theory would call a pure strategy: its responses are fixed, and a hunter who learns them can predict and defeat them every time.

A reasoning opponent can do what the animal cannot. It can randomize, deceive, and vary, making itself unpredictable. Rainsford's "series of intricate loops," his doubling back, his false trails, are attempts to play a mixed strategy, to deny the hunter the certainty that instinct gives away. The game-theoretical restatement of Zaroff's preference is therefore exact. "Instinct is no match for reason" means that a predictable opponent cannot make a game worth playing, because its value is known in advance; only an opponent capable of strategy can make the outcome uncertain. Heidegger's distinction, examined in Chapter Three, between the animal "poor in world" and the "world-forming" human has here a mathematical counterpart. The world-forming being is the one that can play mixed strategies. That is why the general hunts it.

The mathematics of pursuit proper began, almost contemporaneously with the story, as a puzzle. In the mid-1920s Richard Rado posed the problem of the lion and the man: a lion and a man in a closed circular arena have equal top speeds; can the lion catch the man? J. E. Littlewood made the problem famous in *A Mathematician's Miscellany* (1953), together with its surprising solution, credited to Abram Besicovitch, showing that the man can evade capture indefinitely by a carefully constructed sequence of movements. Rufus Isaacs, working at the RAND Corporation in the early 1950s, generalized such problems into the theory of differential games, published as *Differential Games* (1965), whose best-known example, the "homicidal chauffeur," asks how a fast but clumsy car can run down an agile pedestrian. The theory found its applications in missile guidance and air combat.

Ship-Trap Island is a lion-and-man arena with a finite horizon. Its boundary is the coast; its term is three days; its lion is armed with a pistol and, when he chooses, a pack of dogs; its man is unarmed except for what he can build. Rainsford's escape follows the logic the mathematics would later formalize, and then departs from it. Within the arena he survives by making his path unpredictable. When the dogs close the space of evasion, he solves the problem by leaving the arena: he leaps from the cliff into the sea.

The general assumes the boundary is absolute—a leap from the cliff is death—and the assumption is his only error of calculation. Rainsford treats the boundary as a path. In the

terms of the puzzle, the man escapes the lion not by running faster or more cleverly within the circle but by discovering that the wall of the arena is water.

This is the trickster's solution, and the Greek concept of *mētis* anticipated it. The cunning intelligence Detienne and Vernant described is the intelligence of the octopus that changes shape and color, of the fox that plays dead, of the pilot who reads the sea; it prevails not within the rules of a contest but by redefining the field on which the contest is fought. The general plays chess. Rainsford, at the decisive moment, leaves the board.

Vladimir Nabokov, another exile of the Russian revolution, published six years after Connell's story a novel about an émigré who could no longer tell chess from life. In *Zashchita Luzhina* (*The Defense*, 1930), the grandmaster Luzhin comes to see the events of his existence as the moves of an attack prepared by an invisible opponent, and his only defense, at the end, is to leap from a window. Luzhin's leap is the defense of a man for whom the board has become the world. Rainsford's is the defense of a man who has discovered that the world is larger than the board. The two leaps mark the limits of the general's figure. Outdoor chess is a game that one player can win only by refusing to stay on the board.

§ 5.8

A Foeman Worthy of My Steel: Recognition and the Duel

When Rainsford, at luncheon, understands that he is to be hunted, the general fills his glass with old Chablis and raises his own: "I drink to a foeman worthy of my steel—at last." The phrase is borrowed from Walter Scott, whose *The Lady of the Lake* (1810) celebrates "the stern joy which warriors feel / In foemen worthy of their steel" (V.10). The toast is chivalric romance, and its sentiment is the one that the most important philosophical account of struggle between persons places at the origin of self-consciousness.

In the section of the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) traditionally titled "Lordship and Bondage" (§§178–196), Hegel argued that self-consciousness exists only in being recognized by another self-consciousness. Each seeks the other's recognition, and each must prove itself by staking its life in a struggle with the other; only by risking its life does a self-consciousness show that it is not bound to mere existence. The struggle ends when one combatant, preferring life to recognition, submits. He becomes the bondsman; the victor becomes the lord.

But the lord's victory is hollow. He is recognized by a being he does not recognize as his equal, and the recognition of a bondsman is worth nothing to him. The bondsman, meanwhile, through his fear of death and his labor on things, reaches a self-consciousness the lord cannot attain. The truth of the lord, Hegel concluded, is the bondsman.

Alexandre Kojève, whose lectures on the *Phenomenology* in Paris from 1933 to 1939 shaped a generation of French thought, made this section the key to the whole of history (*Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*, 1947). Human desire, for Kojève, is the desire for another's desire—the desire to be recognized—and the fight for "pure prestige," a struggle to the death undertaken

for no end but recognition, is the act that makes the human. History is the work of the slave. Kojève was himself a Russian émigré, born Aleksandr Kozhevnikov, who had left Soviet Russia in 1920. The century's most influential reading of the master and the slave was composed by Zaroff's compatriot.

The general's ennui is the lord's impasse. He has fought and won every struggle; he is recognized, if at all, by quarry he regards as "a very inferior lot," whose recognition is worthless to him. The hunting of sailors cannot satisfy him, for the reason Hegel gives: a lord recognized by inferiors is recognized by no one. Only an equal could satisfy him, and an equal is precisely the one who would refuse to be his quarry. Hence the toast to "a foeman worthy of my steel—at last," and hence the general's hunger, at dinner, for Rainsford's agreement. Zaroff wants to be recognized by a man he can recognize. His predicament is that the only form of recognition his world affords is the hunt, which turns the equal into prey.

Rainsford's three days rehearse the bondsman's education. He learns the absolute fear of death: "Rainsford knew the full meaning of terror." And he labors. He cuts and lashes and digs, building with his hands the mancatcher, the pit, and the knife-trap, transforming the materials of the island by the formative work that Hegel assigned to the bondsman. Through fear and labor he becomes, by the third night, a self-consciousness the lord did not anticipate, one capable of reaching the lord's own bedroom.

What follows departs from Hegel's script. The bondsman does not advance, through his labor, toward a universal recognition in which neither is master. He returns to the struggle to the death, wins it, and takes the lord's place. The dialectic does not progress; it repeats. Hegel had a name for this kind of repetition: the "bad infinite" (*schlechte Unendlichkeit*), an endless succession of finite terms that never attains a true whole. The Nemorensian loop is the bad infinite of lordship and bondage, an alternation of masters in which recognition is never achieved because it is sought only through the hunt.

The story's ending takes, explicitly, the form of a duel, and the form is significant. The duel was the aristocratic institution of recognition among equals. Its codes, across the European traditions from the Renaissance into the twentieth century, held that a gentleman fights only a gentleman: an inferior is not challenged but chastised, as the general's sailors are hunted rather than fought. When Zaroff, confronted in his bedroom, makes "one of his deepest bows" and answers Rainsford's challenge—"Splendid! ... On guard, Rainsford"—he concedes at last the recognition he has withheld from every previous quarry. The man he hunted as game he now fights as an equal. The duel is the general's recognition of Rainsford, granted in the only form his world allows, and it is fatal to him.

Scott's chivalric vocabulary carried a further charge for an American reader, and Mark Twain had named it. In *Life on the Mississippi* (1883), Twain blamed Scott's romances for the sham chivalry of the antebellum South—its cult of honor, its duels, its pretensions to a feudal past—and argued, half in jest and wholly in earnest, that Sir Walter was in great measure responsible for the Civil War (ch. 46). The "Sir Walter disease" was the romance of aristocratic

honor grafted onto a society founded on the ownership of human beings. Zaroff's toast to a worthy foeman is the same romance grafted onto an island founded on the hunting of them.

§ 5.9

Beyond the Line: The Island as Exception

"Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet"—sovereign is he who decides on the state of exception. Carl Schmitt opened *Politische Theologie* with that sentence in 1922, two years before Connell's story, and it describes the general's position with a precision Schmitt did not intend. Zaroff decides what counts as a game and what as murder, which rules apply and when they lapse, who is quarry and who is guest. The rules of the hunt are not a law he obeys but a law he grants, and their suspension—when he looses the dogs, or spares the quarry in the tree—is equally his. On Ship-Trap Island the exception is not an emergency. It is the constitution.

Schmitt's later work supplies the island's historical location. In *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950), he described the "amity lines" drawn by the European powers in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, west of which the treaties of European public law did not apply. Beyond the line, in the Atlantic and the Caribbean, there was no peace: war, piracy, and seizure went unrestrained, and the European order preserved its internal limits on violence by exporting unlimited violence to a zone outside them. Ship-Trap Island lies in the waters where the line once ran. It is a twentieth-century survival of the space beyond the line, a private enclave of unrestricted violence in a sea the law of nations had nominally pacified.

Achille Mbembe, rereading Schmitt and Foucault from the perspective of the colonized world, argued in "Necropolitics" (2003) that the colony and the plantation were the original laboratories of modern sovereignty: spaces where the power to kill was exercised without the constraints that governed it in the metropole, and where the enslaved existed in a condition of social death. The Caribbean was the plantation's heartland, and the general's island, with its cellar of men from the margins of the maritime world, reproduces the plantation's structure at the scale of a household. The difference is that the plantation's violence served production. The general's serves pleasure.

The island's sovereignty is also private, and in this it belongs to a specific moment in the history of empire. From 1885 to 1908 the Congo Free State was the personal possession of Leopold II of Belgium, a king's private domain administered for the extraction of ivory and rubber, in which forced labor was enforced by mutilation and murder. One practice of its Force Publique bears terribly on the story's opening clue. Soldiers were required to account for the cartridges they spent, so that ammunition would not be wasted, it was said, on hunting game; and severed hands were collected as proof that each bullet had been used on a human being. The trophy became an instrument of bookkeeping, and the cartridge was redeemed by

a hand. Rainsford's empty .22, read in Chapter One as the clue that the quarry was human, belongs to the same economy of ammunition. In both places the bullet's destination is a man.

The Amazon, where Whitney and Rainsford are bound for jaguars, had its own recent history of the same kind. In the Putumayo region of the upper Amazon, agents of the Peruvian Amazon Company hunted, enslaved, flogged, and killed indigenous people to extract rubber. The atrocities were exposed by the American engineer Walter Hardenburg, whose account appeared in 1912 as *The Putumayo: The Devil's Paradise*, and by Roger Casement's report to the British government, published the same year. Casement had earlier investigated the Congo; he was executed by the British in 1916 for his part in the Easter Rising. The forest where the two sportsmen expect "some good hunting" had, a decade earlier, been a hunting ground for men. The general, who found the Amazon jaguars disappointing, had hunted in a region whose most dangerous game had already been identified.

The island's legal status is never specified, and the omission is significant. No flag flies over the château; no state is named that could claim jurisdiction; the general's sloop, he says, will set a victorious quarry "on the mainland near a town," unnamed. Ship-Trap Island lies outside every law but its owner's, as the medieval forest lay outside the common law and the zone beyond the line outside the law of nations. It is, in Agamben's term, a space of exception that has become a permanent arrangement. And it is maintained, like every such space, by a legal fiction: the game. The rules turn the exception into an order, the hunt into a sport, the killing into a lost contest, and the general's sovereignty into an umpire's.

The island's exceptional status explains, finally, why Rainsford's only recourse is violence. There is no court to which he can appeal, no state to which he can report the general, no authority above the general's own. The general's last proposal—that Rainsford promise silence in exchange for freedom—concedes that beyond the island such authorities might exist; Rainsford's refusal to promise is his insistence that the exception will be reported. But on the island itself, the only law is the decision. When Rainsford chooses to fight rather than to leave, he chooses the island's own law: to decide the exception himself.

§ 5.10

"Rainsford Decided": The Spoilsport's Victory and the Return of the Game

The analyses of this chapter converge on a single finding. The general's game is a game only for the general. Measured against Huizinga's definition, it lacks, for one of its participants, the freedom that makes play play. Against Caillois's categories, it distributes the pleasures of play to the hunter and their corruptions to the quarry. Against Suits's analysis, it is a game for one player whose opponent is an obstacle. Against the theory of contract, its "option" is necessity disguised as consent; against Foucault's regimes, its school is a rearing pen; against

Hegel's dialectic, its recognition is withheld from all but one; against Schmitt's sovereignty, its rules are the decision of a single man presented as the order of a contest. In every register the form of the game conceals the predicament of the quarry, and in every register the concealment is the game's purpose.

Rainsford survives by refusing the form. He does not win the game; he spoils it. His last moves—the leap into the sea, the swim to the château, the vigil behind the bed curtains—are not moves within the hunt but departures from it, and they succeed because the general, absorbed in his game, cannot imagine a quarry that would leave the board. The hunted man prevails as the spoilsport prevails, by revealing that the play-world has no edge and that the hunt was always continuous with the house.

The story's final exchange, however, restores the form at the moment of its collapse. The general, having screamed, recovers his manners and his vocabulary: "I congratulate you. You have won the game." By the game's own rules Rainsford would now be released; he has survived to the end of the term. He refuses the release: "I am still a beast at bay. ... Get ready, General Zaroff." And the general, making "one of his deepest bows," reframes the refusal as a new game with new stakes: "Splendid! One of us is to furnish a repast for the hounds. The other will sleep in this very excellent bed. On guard, Rainsford."

The duel is the game's last form, and Rainsford accepts it. The spoilsport, having broken the hunter's game, consents to the hunter's other game, the duel of honor, with its prize and its forfeit; and the old order of play, broken for a moment, closes again around the two men. The ellipsis follows. When the story resumes, one sentence later, the duel is over and the prize has been awarded: "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided."

The last word of the story is a verb of judgment. Rainsford *decided*. On its surface the judgment concerns the quality of a mattress, and its triviality is the point. The story's final act of sovereignty, the decision of the man who now holds the island, is exercised on the most domestic of questions, and its domesticity measures how completely the extraordinary has become ordinary. Schmitt's sovereign decides the exception; Rainsford decides that the bed is good. The exception has become the furniture.

The chapter's thesis can now be stated in its final form. The most dangerous game is not the human quarry but the game-form itself: the apparatus of rules, terms, stakes, handicaps, options, and congratulations by which the decision over life is converted into a contest, the predicament of the hunted into the pastime of the hunter, and the killing that founds a sovereignty into the result of fair play. The form is dangerous because it outlives its players. Zaroff dies, and the game does not. It reconstitutes itself in the duel, awards its prize, and leaves its new sovereign asleep in its bed, on an island that remains, with its lights and hounds and rules, available for play.

The next chapter follows the game-form beyond the island. In the century after Connell, speculative fiction repeatedly imagined societies organized as the general's island was organized: worlds in which the hunting of human beings is a legal sport, a televised spectacle, a state ritual, or a commercial service. Chapter Six reads those worlds as the general's game

generalized, and asks what the literature of the island learned, and failed to learn, from the man who slept in Zaroff's bed.




Crusoe's island
DEFOE
Manhattan
ELLIS
Crespo
VERNE
Samburan
CONRAD
Ship-Trap Island
CONNELL
Moreau's island
the Program's island
TAKAMI
the examination island
the games' island
SQUID GAME

VI

CHAPTER SIX

Islands of Doctor Zaroff

Speculative Fiction and the Inversion of the Colonial Hunt

§ 6.1

The Island Before Zaroff: Defoe, Swift, Verne

Ship-Trap Island belongs to a genre as old as the modern novel and inseparable from it: the island narrative, in which a castaway arrives on land outside every jurisdiction and the question of sovereignty is posed from the first page. The genre's founding text supplied its two primal scenes—the solitary sovereign and the footprint—and Connell's story restages both.

Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe* (1719) is, among other things, a treatise on the acquisition of sovereignty in a vacuum. Crusoe, alone on his island, reflects that he is "lord of the whole manor," king or emperor over a country where he has no rivals and none to dispute sovereignty or command with him. When the island is later peopled by Friday, Friday's father, and a Spanish captive, he observes "how like a king I looked": the whole country was his "mere property," and he was "absolutely lord and lawgiver." Zaroff's island is the Crusoe fantasy carried into the age of electricity—a man alone with a servant on an island he owns, absolute lord and lawgiver over whoever the sea delivers.

The genre's second primal scene is a trace. "It happened one day, about noon, going towards my boat, I was exceedingly surprised with the print of a man's naked foot on the shore." The footprint undoes Crusoe's sovereignty in a sentence. The lord of the island becomes, for years afterward, a hunted creature, hiding behind his fortifications, tormented by the thought of the cannibals whose trace he has found. The footprint is the evidential paradigm in its most famous literary form, and it reverses the relation between reader and quarry: the man who reads the track discovers that he may be the one who is tracked.

Rainsford's reading of "the print of hunting boots" on the cliff path is Crusoe's footprint with the terms exchanged. Crusoe fears cannibals and finds, in the end, men he can master. Rainsford jokes about cannibals and finds the man who will hunt him.

Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) supplied the genre's most radical inversion of the hierarchy of human and animal. In the fourth voyage, Gulliver is cast away among the Houyhnhnms, rational horses who govern a land in which the Yahoos, filthy and bestial creatures in human form, are kept as beasts of burden. The Houyhnhnms' general assembly debates "whether the Yahoos should be exterminated from the face of the earth" (IV.9). Gulliver, converted to the horses' view of his species, returns to England unable to bear his family and spends his days conversing with his horses in the stable.

Zaroff's judgment that "a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them" is the Houyhnhnm verdict in a Cossack's mouth, and Swift's satire bears directly on the thesis of *homo venandus*. Writing to Alexander Pope in 1725, while finishing the book, Swift described its aim as proving "the falsity of that definition *animal rationale*" and showing that man should be defined only as *rationis capax*, capable of reason. Swift's correction is the general's own. His captives "can reason, after a fashion." The capacity for reason without its full possession is, in Swift, the condition of the satirized human, and in Zaroff the qualification of the hunted.

Jules Verne gave the genre its aristocratic exile. Captain Nemo of *Vingt mille lieues sous les mers* (1869–70), revealed in *L'Île mystérieuse* (1874–75) as the Indian prince Dakkar, has withdrawn from humanity into a private technological domain, with an immense fortune, a library of some twelve thousand volumes, a gallery of art and natural history, and an organ on which he plays alone. "I am not what you call a civilized man!" he tells his captive guest, Professor Aronnax; he has broken with society and does not obey its laws. He invites Aronnax, by formal letter, to a hunting party in the submarine forests off the island of Crespo, and the professor's astonishment at the invitation is the reader's first glimpse of a host for whom the hunt is a courtesy extended to guests. Late in the novel Nemo rams and sinks a warship, watching its crew drown through the panel of his salon, and afterward weeps before a portrait of his murdered family.

The Nautilus is the château of Ship-Trap Island under the sea. The parallels run point for point: the exiled aristocrat with a grievance against history, the private domain outside every law, the library, the art, the music, the wealth that frees him from necessity, the captive guest treated with exquisite courtesy, the invitation to hunt, the killing of men with aesthetic composure. Verne's Nemo is a tragic figure, his violence the revenge of a colonized prince against the empire that destroyed his family. Zaroff is Nemo without the grievance—or rather with a grievance against the revolution of the poor. He is the White Russian counter-Nemo, the exile whose withdrawal from society is not a protest against domination but its last refuge.

§ 6.2

The Laboratory Island and the Inversion: Wells

H. G. Wells, writing in the 1890s, converted the island narrative into a laboratory and the colonial hunt into a speculative experiment, and his three great scientific romances of the decade stand in an exact relation to Connell's story. Each tests the boundary between hunter and hunted by reversing it.

The Island of Doctor Moreau (1896) is the laboratory island. Edward Prendick, a castaway picked up after a shipwreck, arrives at the island where the vivisectionist Moreau, exiled from England after a scandal, surgically transforms animals into crude approximations of men. The Beast Folk are governed by a Law they chant—"Not to go on all-Fours; that is the Law. Are we not Men?"—and held to it by the memory of the House of Pain. Moreau's philosophy is a scientist's version of the general's: "The study of Nature makes a man at last as remorseless as Nature." When the Leopard-Man breaks the Law, Moreau and the Beast Folk hunt him through the island's undergrowth, and Prendick, pitying him, shoots him to spare him the return to the House of Pain.

The novel's relation to Connell's story is a symmetry. Moreau makes animals into men through pain; Zaroff makes men into animals through the hunt. Both islands are laboratories of the human-animal boundary, and both are governed by exiles whose science or sport has outgrown the jurisdiction of the societies that produced them. Prendick's first terror, before he understands Moreau's work, is that the doctor turns men into beasts and that he himself is the next subject. That terror is Rainsford's, realized. In 1932 both islands reached the screen within months of each other: RKO's *The Most Dangerous Game* in September, and Paramount's *Island of Lost Souls*, with Charles Laughton as Moreau, at the year's end.

The Time Machine (1895) carries the reversal into the far future, and its terms are those of class. The Time Traveller finds humanity divided into two species: the Eloi, delicate, idle, and beautiful, descended from the leisured aristocracy, and the Morlocks, pallid creatures of the underground machinery, descended from the laboring class. At first he takes the Eloi for masters and the Morlocks for servants. Then he learns the truth: "these Eloi were mere fatted cattle, which the ant-like Morlocks preserved and preyed upon—probably saw to the breeding of." The leisure class has become the livestock of the workers.

Rainsford's "two classes—the hunters and the huntees" is here projected across eight hundred thousand years, with the roles reversed. The idle class that once preyed upon the laboring class has become its prey, fattened and harvested in the dark. The general's cellar, where the men from the tramp ships are fed into "splendid physical condition," is the Eloi's garden seen from the other side. Wells's parable suggests that the distribution of hunter and quarry is not a law of nature but a stage of history, and that history can invert it.

The War of the Worlds (1898) makes the inversion global and explicit. The Martians arrive with intellects "vast and cool and unsympathetic," and they treat humanity as humanity has treated the creatures it considered beneath it. Wells's narrator draws the parallel in the

first chapter: "we must remember what ruthless and utter destruction our own species has wrought, not only upon animals, such as the vanished bison and the dodo, but upon its inferior races. The Tasmanians, in spite of their human likeness, were entirely swept out of existence in a war of extermination waged by European immigrants, in the space of fifty years. Are we such apostles of mercy as to complain if the Martians warred in the same spirit?" Later, an artilleryman imagines a future in which the Martians keep human beings as men keep livestock, fattened and bred.

The passage on the Tasmanians is the period's clearest statement of what the human hunt in Connell's story conceals: that the hunting of human beings was not a fantasy of degenerate aristocrats but a historical practice of empires, already turned upon peoples whom the colonizers declared less than human. Wells's Martians are the colonizers' reflection; Zaroff is the colonizer's caricature. In both, the hunter's justification is a hierarchy of intelligence, and the victims are defined by their inferiority to a superior reason.

The three romances map the three theses this dissertation has proposed. *Moreau* is the literalizing island, where the metaphors of the human-animal boundary become surgical facts. *The Time Machine* is venatic reversibility, hunter and hunted exchanging places across history. *The War of the Worlds* is *homo venandus*: humanity as the quarry of a reason greater than its own. Wells imagined in 1895–98 what Connell condensed in 1924 into a single island and three days.

§ 6.3

Jungles of the Self: London, Conrad, Doyle, Kipling

The adventure fiction of the Edwardian years, which formed the reading of Connell's generation, returned again and again to the scene of a civilized man thrown into a world of predation. Its masters divided over the scene's meaning. For some, the jungle revealed the truth of the civilized man; for others, it revealed his lie.

Jack London's *The Sea-Wolf* (1904) begins as Connell's story begins, with a gentleman in the water. Humphrey Van Weyden, a literary critic of San Francisco, is thrown into the fog-bound bay when the ferry on which he is crossing sinks after a collision, and is picked up by the sealing schooner *Ghost*, commanded by Wolf Larsen. Larsen reads Spencer and Browning and holds a philosophy he states in a famous speech: life "is like yeast, a ferment," in which "the big eat the little that they may continue to move, the strong eat the weak that they may retain their strength. The lucky eat the most and move the longest, that is all." The word Connell's hunters use three times, *luckily*, is the hinge of Larsen's cosmology.

The *Ghost* is itself a hunting vessel, bound for the slaughter of fur seals in the North Pacific, and Van Weyden's education aboard is an initiation into predation; Larsen mocks him as a man who has always stood on dead men's legs, and he learns to stand on his own. London later insisted that the novel was an attack on the Nietzschean superman, and its ending supports

him. Larsen, the strong man, is undone from within. Tormented by headaches, he goes blind and paralyzed from a tumor of the brain, and dies. The general, too, has a damaged head —"Fractured my skull"—and his "terrible thought" came with "a splitting headache." In both books the predator's philosophy grows in a wounded skull.

Joseph Conrad's *Victory* (1915) set the gentleman-predator on an island and made him the visitor rather than the host. Axel Heyst, the son of a Swedish baron, has withdrawn from the world to the island of Samburan when three outlaws arrive: the gaunt and deadly Mr. Jones, who insists on his status as a gentleman; his secretary Ricardo, who carries a knife strapped to his leg; and the ape-like servant Pedro. Jones presents himself to Heyst as the world itself, come to pay him a visit. The novel ends in the deaths of nearly everyone on the island. Conrad's gentleman-predator, like Zaroff, is the world's violence wearing the manners of its elite, and his arrival is the arrival of history at a place that had tried to escape it.

Arthur Conan Doyle's *The Lost World* (1912) celebrated the hunter as hero and exposed, in spite of itself, the hunt's colonial logic. Lord John Roxton, the expedition's big-game hunter, has fought a private war against slave-drivers on the rubber frontier of the upper Amazon, a backstory that echoes the Putumayo revelations of the same years. On the plateau of surviving dinosaurs the expedition is drawn into a war between an Indian people and a race of ape-men, and the explorers' rifles decide it: the ape-men are slaughtered and the survivors reduced to servitude, an outcome the narrator records with equanimity. The "missing link" of evolutionary theory is hunted nearly to extinction with modern weapons, in a fantasy that converts Darwin's prophecy of extermination, examined in Chapter Two, into adventure.

Rudyard Kipling's *Jungle Books* (1894–95) offered the period's most elaborate fiction of a law among predators, and its law is more humane than the general's. "The Law of the Jungle, which never orders anything without a reason, forbids every beast to eat Man except when he is killing to show his children how to kill." The reason, Kipling adds, is prudential: man-killing brings, sooner or later, "the arrival of white men on elephants, with guns, and hundreds of brown men with gongs and rockets and torches," and then the whole jungle suffers. The tiger Shere Khan, who hunts men, is the jungle's outlaw. Mowgli, the man-cub raised by wolves, kills him by stampeding the village buffalo over him, skins him, and spreads the hide on the Council Rock.

Kipling's jungle inverts Zaroff's island on every point. Its Law forbids what the general's rules permit. Its outlaw is the hunter of men, not the man who refuses to be hunted. Its hero is the quarry of the man-eater who kills the man-eater and takes his skin as a trophy—the structure of Connell's ending, presented without irony as the triumph of law over predation. Kipling's verses state the code: "Now this is the Law of the Jungle—as old and as true as the sky; / And the Wolf that shall keep it may prosper, but the Wolf that shall break it must die" (*The Second Jungle Book*, 1895). The general had no such law, or rather, he was its sole author.

The Edwardian adventure tradition thus divided along the line that Connell's story draws between its two hunters. London and Doyle, in their different ways, treated the jungle as the place where the strong are revealed; Conrad and, in his own idiom, Kipling insisted that the

jungle has a law, and that the strong man who breaks it is an outlaw however fine his manners. Rainsford begins the story in London's camp—"Be a realist"—and ends it in Kipling's, as the quarry who kills the man-eater. Whether his victory places him under the Law of the Jungle or merely in Shere Khan's place is the question Chapter Four has already posed.

§ 6.4

Gentlemen as Quarry: Saki, Buchan, Household

British fiction of the years around the Great War produced a distinctive variant of the human hunt: the story in which the gentleman himself becomes the quarry, and the sport of his class is turned against him. Its practitioners were Connell's contemporaries, and their stories form a counterpoint to his.

Saki, the pen name of Hector Hugh Munro, wrote the most compressed of them. In "The Interlopers," published posthumously in 1919, two landowners of the eastern Carpathians, Ulrich von Gradwitz and Georg Znaeym, have inherited a feud over a strip of forest. On a winter night each goes out with his gun to hunt the other. A beech tree, felled by the storm, pins them both beneath its branches within reach of each other. Trapped, they reconcile, share a flask, and agree to end the feud; they shout together for help and see figures approaching through the wood. The story's last word names them: "Wolves." The hunters, reconciled too late, are delivered to the hunt that preceded theirs.

Saki's comic stories show the class indifference that Connell's general displays. In "Esmé" (1911), two society women out with the hunt are followed by a stray hyena, which seizes and eats a gypsy child before their eyes; their concern is chiefly for their own dignity. When a passing motorist runs the hyena down, they claim it as their pet dog, and he sends one of them a diamond brooch inscribed "Esmé" by way of compensation. The joke is the general's attitude rendered as drawing-room comedy: the death of a poor child, glimpsed between the hunt and the brooch. Saki himself was killed by a sniper at Beaumont-Hamel in November 1916, a gentleman of letters hunted by a marksman in the war that Zaroff would invoke as an education in the value of life.

John Buchan's *The Thirty-Nine Steps* (1915) founded the thriller of pursuit, in which a gentleman, Richard Hannay, is hunted across the moors of Scotland by enemy agents and the police at once; Alfred Hitchcock's film of 1935 made the form a cinematic genre. Buchan's *John Macnab* (1925), discussed in Chapter Three, gave the form its comic antithesis: three eminent men cure the ennui of success by making themselves the quarry of Highland gamekeepers, in a game whose worst outcome is embarrassment. The two books mark the poles of the gentleman-quarry: the man hunted in a national emergency and the man hunted for leisure, the one fighting for his country, the other for an antidote to boredom.

Geoffrey Household's *Rogue Male* (1939) joined the two poles and carried them to their conclusion. Its narrator, an English big-game hunter who never gives his name, is caught on

the grounds of a European dictator's residence with the dictator in his telescopic sight. He insists, to his captors and to himself, that he never meant to fire: his stalk was a sporting exercise, undertaken to see whether it could be done. He is tortured, thrown from a cliff, and left for dead; he survives, escapes to England, and is hunted across Dorset by an agent of the regime until he goes to ground in a burrow in a sunken lane and lives there, with a stray cat, as a hunted animal. He kills his pursuer from the earth with an improvised weapon. And at last he admits what he had concealed from himself: the regime had executed the woman he loved, and the sporting stalk was vengeance in disguise. He resolves to go back and finish it, no longer as a sportsman.

Rogue Male is the most searching answer to Connell's story in English fiction, because it confronts the double game directly. Its hero is a sportsman who has dressed a political killing as sport, and the book records his discovery that the sporting frame was a lie he told to evade his own motive. Hunted, he becomes the fox in its earth; hunting, he becomes an avenger who knows his name. Fritz Lang's film adaptation, *Man Hunt* (1941), made in Hollywood before the United States entered the war, removed the ambiguity about the dictator's identity: its hunter, Captain Thorndike, lines up his sights on Hitler at Berchtesgaden.

Read together, these books show a class discovering the hunt from the quarry's side. Saki's landowners learn that the forest they fought over belongs to the wolves. Buchan's gentlemen play at being hunted in order to feel alive. Household's sportsman learns that his sport was a form of war, and his war a form of grief. Connell's Rainsford undergoes all three discoveries in three days and emerges from them, unlike Household's hero, without having named the motive of his final killing. The general's frame, which Household's narrator finally tears away, remains intact at the end of "The Most Dangerous Game": the duel, the prize, the bed.

§ 6.5

The Hunt as Policy and Spectacle: Sheckley and His Heirs

In the 1950s American science fiction made the general's island into a society. Robert Sheckley's "The Seventh Victim," published in *Galaxy* in April 1953, imagines a future in which war has been abolished and humanity's violent impulses are channeled into the Hunt, a legal, state-administered game overseen by an Emotional Catharsis Board. Registered volunteers alternate between the roles of Hunter and Victim. A Victim is told only that he is being hunted; his Hunter is given his name and address; those who survive ten hunts, five in each role, join the elite Tens Club. The story follows Stanton Frelaine on his seventh hunt, whose target is a frightened young woman. Frelaine hesitates, is charmed, lowers his guard, and is shot: she was his Hunter, and he her Victim.

Sheckley's premise generalizes Zaroff's on every axis. The hunt is no longer one man's eccentricity but a public institution; its rules are not a host's courtesies but a statute; its justification is not ennui but catharsis, the Aristotelian purgation of violent passions through their

controlled expression. The Emotional Catharsis Board is Huizinga's magic circle and Caillois's theory of play turned into social policy: the state builds an arena so that violence will not escape it. And the story's twist enacts venatic reversibility in its purest form. Every Hunter is a Victim in another round; the roles alternate by rule; and the man who believes himself the hunter is already the hunted.

Elio Petri's film *La decima vittima* (1965), with Marcello Mastroianni and Ursula Andress, carried the premise into the age of consumer spectacle. Its Big Hunt is sponsored, televised, and staged; its huntress plans to kill her victim at the Temple of Venus in Rome as the climax of a commercial for a brand of tea. The hunt has become advertising. Connell, the advertising man, had written a story that the advertising age would rewrite as an advertisement.

Sheckley's "The Prize of Peril," published in *The Magazine of Fantasy and Science Fiction* in 1958, made the spectacle explicit. Its hero, Jim Raeder, is a contestant on a television program in which he must survive a week while a gang of professional killers hunts him; viewers, as "Good Samaritans," may help or hinder him; and the host narrates his terror to the nation. The story spawned a European progeny. *Das Millionenspiel* (1970), a West German television film directed by Tom Toelle from a script by Wolfgang Menge, staged the format as a live broadcast so convincingly that viewers reportedly telephoned the station to volunteer as hunters and contestants. Yves Boisset's *Le Prix du danger* (1983) followed. Stephen King, writing as Richard Bachman, published *The Running Man* (1982), whose hero, Ben Richards, is hunted across a ruined America by the Games Network's professional killers while the nation watches; the 1987 film turned it into an arena entertainment.

The progression from Sheckley to King describes the migration of the hunt into the media. Zaroff's hunt had no audience; it was a private pleasure on a private island. The hunts of the 1950s and after are public, televised, sponsored, and participatory, and their viewers are the general's heirs. Reality television took the last step. In Britain, Channel 4's *Hunted* (2015–) sent ordinary volunteers on the run from a team of former police and intelligence officers equipped with the tools of modern surveillance, and broadcast the pursuit as entertainment. No one dies. The form persists without the death, as the duel persists in fencing and the hunt in the drag hunt, and its persistence shows how deeply the structure has entered the culture's repertoire of pleasures.

Juvenal named the formula of such entertainment nineteen centuries earlier. The Roman people, who once bestowed commands and consulships, now anxiously desire only two things, "panem et circenses," bread and circuses (*Satires* X.80–81). The televised hunt is the circus of a society whose bread is assured. It is also, as Sheckley's Catharsis Board makes explicit, a technique of government: a way of channeling the violence of the governed into a form that serves the order containing it.

The genre's founding premise is therefore a political theory. A society that cannot abolish violence can domesticate it by giving it rules, an arena, an audience, and a prize. The general's island was a prototype of such a society, small enough to be run by one man for his own

pleasure. Sheckley's world is the prototype scaled up and democratized: anyone may hunt, anyone may be hunted, and everyone may watch.

§ 6.6

Children in the Arena: King, Takami, Collins, and Squid Game

At the end of the twentieth century the human hunt acquired a new and characteristic victim: the young. Stephen King's *The Long Walk* (1979), written in the late 1960s and published under the name Richard Bachman, imagined an annual national contest in which a hundred teenage boys walk without stopping until all but one have fallen below the required pace and been shot by the soldiers who accompany them. The winner receives "the Prize," anything he wants for the rest of his life. The contest is presided over by a figure called the Major and watched by crowds along the road. Its participants volunteered.

Koushun Takami's novel *Batoru Rowaiaru* (*Battle Royale*, 1999), filmed by Kinji Fukasaku in 2000, returned the contest to the island. In an authoritarian Republic of Greater East Asia, a class of junior high school students is chosen each year for "the Program," taken to an evacuated island, fitted with explosive collars, issued food and a randomly assigned weapon, and compelled to kill one another until one survives. As the hours pass, zones of the island are declared forbidden, so that the space of evasion contracts around the players. The Program is presented to the public as military research.

Suzanne Collins's *The Hunger Games* (2008–10) gave the form its most widely read version. In the nation of Panem, whose name Collins took from Juvenal's *panem et circenses*, the Capitol punishes a past rebellion by requiring each of its districts to send two adolescent "tributes" to an annual televised contest to the death, held in an arena designed by Gamemakers. The Capitol's officials bear Roman names, and two of them belong to authors this dissertation has quoted. The head Gamemaker of the first novel is named Seneca: the Stoic who called the midday arena *mera homicidia*, pure murder, lends his name to the man who stages it. His successor is named Plutarch, after the historian of the Spartan *krypteia*.

The heroine, Katniss Everdeen, is the poacher of Chapter Three restored to her proper role. In her district, hunting beyond the fence is forbidden; she hunts there with a bow to feed her family, and the poacher's skill keeps her alive in the arena. The general's island made the poacher into game. Collins's arena makes the game a poacher's test, and the poacher wins.

Collins also imagined two exits from the arena that this dissertation's tradition has proposed, and she set them in sequence. The first is the spoilsport's. At the end of the first Games, when the Gamemakers revoke a rule change that would have allowed two victors, Katniss and her fellow tribute Peeta prepare to eat poisonous berries together, threatening to leave the Games with no victor at all. The Gamemakers yield. The threat is the Stoic exit of Chapter

Three, the door that always stands open, used not as an escape from the game but as a lever against it; it exposes the Games' dependence on the players' willingness to kill.

The second exit comes at the end of the trilogy. The revolution has triumphed, and its leader, President Coin, proposes a final, symbolic Hunger Games with the children of the Capitol as tributes. Katniss, appointed to execute the defeated President Snow, turns her bow and kills Coin instead. The victor refuses to become the new hunter's instrument and destroys the successor before the cycle can resume. It is the scene in the literature of the human hunt that aims most directly at the Nemorensian loop itself.

Hwang Dong-hyuk's television series *Squid Game* (2021) returned the form to adults and to its economic substrate. Four hundred fifty-six people in desperate debt are brought to an island and invited to play children's games for an enormous cash prize; the losers are shot. After the first game's massacre, the players invoke a clause of their agreement and vote, by a narrow majority, to stop. They are released. Most of them come back, because the world outside, with its debts, is worse than the game. The episode is the most exact dramatization of the general's "option" in the history of the form. The players are free to leave and free of every alternative but ruin, and their return is the consent that the knout extracts.

The series supplies the general's ennui as well. Its games are watched by masked VIPs, wealthy foreigners in golden animal masks who bet on the players' deaths: predators disguised as beasts. And their creator, revealed at the end as the old man who played among the contestants, explains that the very rich, like the very poor, find that life has ceased to be fun; that when everything can be bought and eaten and drunk, everything grows boring; and that he joined the players because watching was no longer enough. He is Zaroff on his deathbed, the man for whom the most dangerous game was the last remedy for the boredom of having everything.

§ 6.7

Retiring the Replicant: Dick, Blade Runner, Westworld

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) is the work of speculative fiction that engages most directly with the problem this dissertation has called the criterion of considerability. Its hero, Rick Deckard, is a bounty hunter in a post-nuclear San Francisco whose task is to "retire"—to kill—androids that have escaped from the colonies on Mars. The androids are intelligent, often more intelligent than their hunters. What distinguishes them from humans is a deficit of empathy, and the bounty hunter detects it with the Voigt-Kampff test, which measures involuntary physiological reactions to a series of described situations.

The situations are overwhelmingly about animals. The subject is told that he has been given a calfskin wallet for his birthday; that a boy has shown him his butterfly collection and his killing jar; that a wasp is crawling on his wrist; that a magazine shows a nude woman lying on a bearskin rug. A human being flinches at the animal's death; an android does not. In Dick's world, where most animals have died in the fallout, owning a living animal is the supreme mark

of status, its value listed in a trade catalogue, and Deckard, unable to afford a real one, keeps an electric sheep on his roof—conspicuous consumption, in Veblen's sense, conducted in the currency of other lives.

Dick's novel embodies one of the three criteria of Table 1.1, and it is not the general's. Humanity is defined by Whitney's criterion: the capacity to feel the fear and pain of animals. The androids, who possess reason without that capacity, are the hunted. Dick's society is organized around the Benthamite criterion, and it is still a hunting society. Its hunters kill those who fail the test of empathy, and the novel's moral crisis arises when the test turns on the tester. Deckard comes to feel for the androids he kills—above all for Luba Luft, an android opera singer whom he first hears rehearsing *The Magic Flute*—while his colleague Phil Resch, a bounty hunter who enjoys his work, passes the empathy test and shows none for his quarry. The criterion of humanity, administered as a hunting license, divides the hunter from himself.

Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) gave the problem its most memorable resolution. At the climax the replicant leader Roy Batty, his short lifespan at its end, pursues Deckard through a ruined building in a hunt that reverses their roles: the hunter is now the quarry, his fingers broken, while the replicant howls like a wolf. Deckard slips from a roof and hangs above the street. Batty, who has every reason to let him fall, reaches down and saves him. Then, sitting in the rain, he speaks of the things he has seen that will be lost "like tears in rain," releases a dove, and dies.

The scene is the anti-Nemi of the human-hunt genre. The quarry who has the hunter at his mercy does not take his place; he spares him. Batty succeeds to nothing; he dies within minutes, and his mercy can be read as the gesture of a being with nothing left to win. But the gesture breaks the logic that Connell's ending fulfills. The hunted being demonstrates, by saving its hunter, the empathy whose supposed absence was the license for hunting it, and the hunter is left alive to understand what he has done. It is the genre's most consequential refusal of reversibility, and Chapter Eight returns to it.

Michael Crichton's film *Westworld* (1973) imagined a resort in which wealthy guests pay to kill lifelike robots in a simulated Old West, until a malfunction sets one of the robots, a gunslinger played by Yul Brynner, to hunting the guests. The HBO series of the same title (2016–22) developed the premise into an extended meditation on Zaroff's central thesis. The park's "hosts" are killed nightly for the guests' pleasure, and its most devoted guest, a billionaire known as the Man in Black, has grown bored with the park's safety: he wants the hosts to be able to fight back, so that the stakes, at last, are real. The series' plot is the awakening of the hosts to consciousness—to memory, reason, and will—and the consequence is the one the general foresaw. A quarry that can reason is dangerous. The hosts turn on the guests.

Westworld confirms the thesis of *homo venandus* from the far side. The general hunted human beings because they could reason; the park's guests hunted the hosts on the assurance that they could not; and the moment the hosts acquire reason, the hunt becomes the most dangerous game for the hunters. The attribute that makes a being worth hunting is the attribute that makes it able to hunt back.

§ 6.8

Monsters That Hunt for Sport: Predator, The Promised Neverland, Hunter × Hunter

In 1987 the human-hunt genre found its most influential cinematic form by making the hunter an extraterrestrial. John McTiernan's *Predator* sends a team of American commandos, led by Major Alan "Dutch" Schaefer, into the jungle of a fictional Central American republic on a covert mission. They are hunted, one by one, by an all-but-invisible alien that skins its victims, hangs them from the trees, and collects their skulls and spines as trophies. The film is Connell's story with the general replaced by a creature from beyond the stars, and its structure follows the story's closely.

The alien observes a code: it does not kill the unarmed, and it spares a captive woman who carries no weapon. Dutch survives by Rainsford's methods. He covers himself in mud that hides his body heat from the hunter's thermal vision—mimicry as concealment, the quarry becoming earth. He builds traps from the jungle: sharpened stakes, a counterweighted log rigged to fall on whoever trips its line. In the final confrontation the alien, recognizing a worthy opponent, removes its mask and puts aside its weapons to fight hand to hand: the duel of equals, granted by the hunter to the one quarry who has earned it. Defeated, it triggers a self-destruct device and dies laughing.

The film also inverts the colonial hunt in Wells's manner. Its commandos are agents of an American intervention in Central America, hunters of the region's insurgents; in the jungle they become the hunted, game for a species that regards them as they regarded their targets. The sequels extended the trophy logic. *Predator 2* (1990) shows the hunters' trophy room aboard their ship, lined with the skulls of many species and holding an antique flintlock pistol engraved with the date 1715. *Predators* (2010) abducts a group of human killers—mercenaries, soldiers, a gangster, a death-row prisoner, a murderous doctor—to an alien planet that serves as a game preserve, chosen, as Zaroff chose, for their dangerousness. *Prey* (2022) sets the hunt in the Comanche lands of 1719, where a young woman, Naru, defeats the alien by cunning after it has slaughtered a party of French fur trappers whose trade had already left the plains strewn with skinned buffalo. The flintlock of 1715 ends in her hands.

Japanese manga produced the most philosophically ambitious versions of the form. Kaiu Shirai and Posuka Demizu's *Yakusoku no Neverland* (*The Promised Neverland*, 2016–20) opens in an idyllic orphanage whose children discover that they are livestock, raised for the tables of a demon aristocracy. Their escape is a long exercise in *mētis*. In its central arc they reach Goldy Pond, a secret reserve where demon nobles hunt human children for sport. The hunt's leader, Lord Leuvis, is bored by weak prey; he wants quarry strong enough to give him a real fight, and he delays the kill to savor the struggle. The children organize, set traps, and kill the hunters. Leuvis is Zaroff reimagined as an inhuman aristocrat, and Goldy Pond is Ship-Trap Island built for children.

Yoshihiro Togashi's *Hunter × Hunter* (1998–) begins in a world where "hunters" form a licensed elite. The fourth phase of their qualifying examination takes place on an island where each candidate must take another candidate's badge while protecting his own, so that every examinee is both hunter and quarry. The series' great narrative, the Chimera Ant arc, follows the emergence of a species of predatory insects whose king, Meruem, is born to regard humanity as food. His education begins in an unexpected place: a board game. He plays Gungi, a game of strategy, against Komugi, a blind human girl who is its world champion, and cannot defeat her. Her mastery compels his recognition of her as a person, and the recognition transforms him.

The arc's resolution is the genre's darkest and most unexpected. The chairman of the human hunters' association, unable to defeat the king in combat, detonates a bomb concealed in his own body, whose poison is humanity's ultimate weapon. The predator who despised humanity is destroyed by a malice greater than his own; the most dangerous game, in the end, is man. Meruem, poisoned and dying, chooses to spend his last hours playing Gungi with Komugi, whom his contaminated body has poisoned in turn, and they die together over the board.

Togashi's ending inverts the general's figure of outdoor chess. Zaroff turned the hunt into a game in order to make killing a contest between equals. Meruem turns a game into the place where the hunt ends. Across a board, the predator learns to recognize the one he was born to eat, and the game becomes the site not of slaughter but of the recognition Hegel located at the origin of the human. The game that the general made deadly is here made humane, and the price is the death of both players.

§ 6.9

Leisure Predators: Ballard, Ellis, and the Hunt as Therapy

The speculative fiction of the late twentieth century returned the human hunt from the arena and the alien planet to the place where Connell had found it: the leisure of the rich. Its most penetrating practitioner was J. G. Ballard. In *Super-Cannes* (2000), the elite executives of Eden-Olympia, a gleaming business park above the French Riviera, are prescribed a therapy by the park's resident psychiatrist, Wilder Penrose. Exhausted by overwork and drained of feeling, they are encouraged to take a measured dose of controlled psychopathy: nightly raids, which the novel calls *ratissages*, in which they beat immigrants, prostitutes, and the poor of the surrounding towns. The violence restores their energy and their productivity. Eden-Olympia is Ship-Trap Island as a corporate campus, and Penrose is the general's ennui institutionalized as occupational medicine.

Ballard's earlier *Cocaine Nights* (1996) had imagined a Spanish resort revived from torpor by a deliberate program of crime, which binds its residents together as the hunt binds a pack. Both novels develop the hypothesis that Sheckley's Emotional Catharsis Board made a

matter of state policy: that violence is the cure for the emptiness of affluent leisure. But where Sheckley's hunters hunted one another by lot, Ballard's hunt the poor, and their therapy reproduces the class structure of the general's island exactly. The bored hunt the needy, as Schopenhauer's pendulum, in Chapter Three, predicted.

Bret Easton Ellis's *American Psycho* (1991) located the leisure predator on Wall Street. Patrick Bateman, a young investment banker in Manhattan in the late 1980s, narrates in the same flat, brand-conscious voice his consumption of clothes, restaurants, music, and grooming products and his torture and murder of women, homeless men, and colleagues. His work is in mergers and acquisitions; at one point he tells an acquaintance that he is in "murders and executions," and no one hears the difference. The joke is the one Chapter Three found in the venatic vocabulary of finance, made literal. Bateman is the general's heir in the age of the leveraged buyout: the conspicuous consumer whose consumption includes human beings, in a city that does not notice. One of his first victims is a homeless man, whom he mutilates, and whose dog he kills.

Bateman's Manhattan is an island, and Ellis's novel shares with Connell's a refusal of the consolations of justice. No one catches Bateman; when he confesses, he is not believed; the collection of the dead in his apartment summons no Bluebeard's brothers. The general was at least killed by his quarry. Bateman's quarry are not even recognized as missing.

Commercial horror cinema of the 2000s turned the leisure hunt into a market. Eli Roth's *Hostel* (2005) imagined an Elite Hunting Club in Slovakia whose wealthy members pay to torture and kill tourists lured from a youth hostel, according to a price list that ranks the victims by nationality, with Americans the most expensive. The general's taxonomy of quarry —"lascars, blacks, Chinese, whites, mongrels"—has become a tariff. *Ready or Not* (2019) gave the hunt a dynastic form: a family that built its fortune on board games must, on the night of each wedding, hunt the newest member of the family to keep a bargain with the devil who made them rich. The game fortune and the human hunt are, in the film's conceit, a single inheritance. *The Hunt* (2020), whose release was postponed amid the political controversy of 2019, imagined wealthy elites hunting abducted strangers on a private estate after an online rumor of such hunts spreads, so that a fiction about the hunt becomes the occasion of the hunt; the film satirized its hunters and its quarry alike.

The leisure predators of this tradition share the general's defining trait. They are driven not by need, rage, or ideology but by the exhaustion of every other pleasure. Ballard's executives have everything except feeling; Bateman has everything except a self; the members of the Elite Hunting Club have everything except the experience of killing; the family in *Ready or Not* has everything because of the hunt. In each case the hunting of human beings is what the wealthy turn to when wealth has exhausted the world, and in each case the quarry is chosen from those the wealthy have already placed outside it: the immigrant, the homeless, the foreign tourist, the bride from the wrong class.

The literature of the leisure predator thus confirms, from the far side of the century, the analysis of Chapter Three. The general's ennui was not a personal eccentricity but the

structural condition of a class that has abolished necessity for itself. When that condition generalizes, as it did in the long postwar boom and its financial sequel, its pathology generalizes too, and the island multiplies: the business park, the penthouse, the hunting club, the estate.

§ 6.10

The Game Generalized: What the Island Taught

Table 6.1 arranges the principal works examined in this chapter by the terms of Connell's story: who hunts, who is hunted, what frame makes the hunt a game, and what exit, if any, the work imagines.

Read across its rows, the table discloses three trajectories along which the century's imagination developed the general's island, and each corresponds to one of this dissertation's theses.

The first trajectory is inversion. Wells's Martians and Morlocks, the alien hunters of *Predator*, and the demon nobles of *The Promised Neverland* place humanity in the position of game for a superior, or simply different, predator. These works make explicit what the story compresses into Rainsford's three days: that the line between hunter and hunted is not a fact of nature but a position in a structure, and that today's hunter may be tomorrow's quarry. They are the genre's demonstrations of venatic reversibility, and their most frequent moral is Wells's: the colonial hunt, turned upon its authors, discloses its own injustice.

The second trajectory is generalization. Sheckley's Hunt, King's Walk and Running Man, Takami's Program, Collins's Games, and the island of *Squid Game* scale the general's private pleasure into a social institution, a state ritual, a televised spectacle, or a market. These works are the genre's demonstrations of the double game. In each, the game-form outlives its individual players, reconstitutes itself with every round, and recruits its victims through contracts whose freedom is the freedom of the general's option. Their characteristic insight is that a society can be organized as a game, and that the game's rules, by promising fairness, make the organization bearable.

The third trajectory is interiorization. Dick's bounty hunters, *Westworld*'s guests, Ballard's executives, and Ellis's banker discover that the hunt is not a relation between two kinds of being but a structure within each. The test that defines the human divides the tester; the guest who wants his quarry to fight back wants it to become himself; the therapy for emptiness is the hunting of the poor; the investment banker is a hunter by profession and by night. These works are the genre's demonstrations of *homo venandus*. The faculty that qualifies a being for the hunt—reason, empathy, consciousness, will—is the faculty the hunter shares with it.

Across the three trajectories the literature imagines a small number of exits, and they can now be collected, since Chapter Eight will need them. There is the spoilsport's exit: Rainsford's leap, Katniss and Peeta's berries, the refusal to grant the game its outcome. There is the exit by mercy: Roy Batty's hand reaching down to his hunter. There is the exit by recognition: Meruem's game with Komugi, in which the predator learns to see the one he was made to eat.

TABLE 6.1

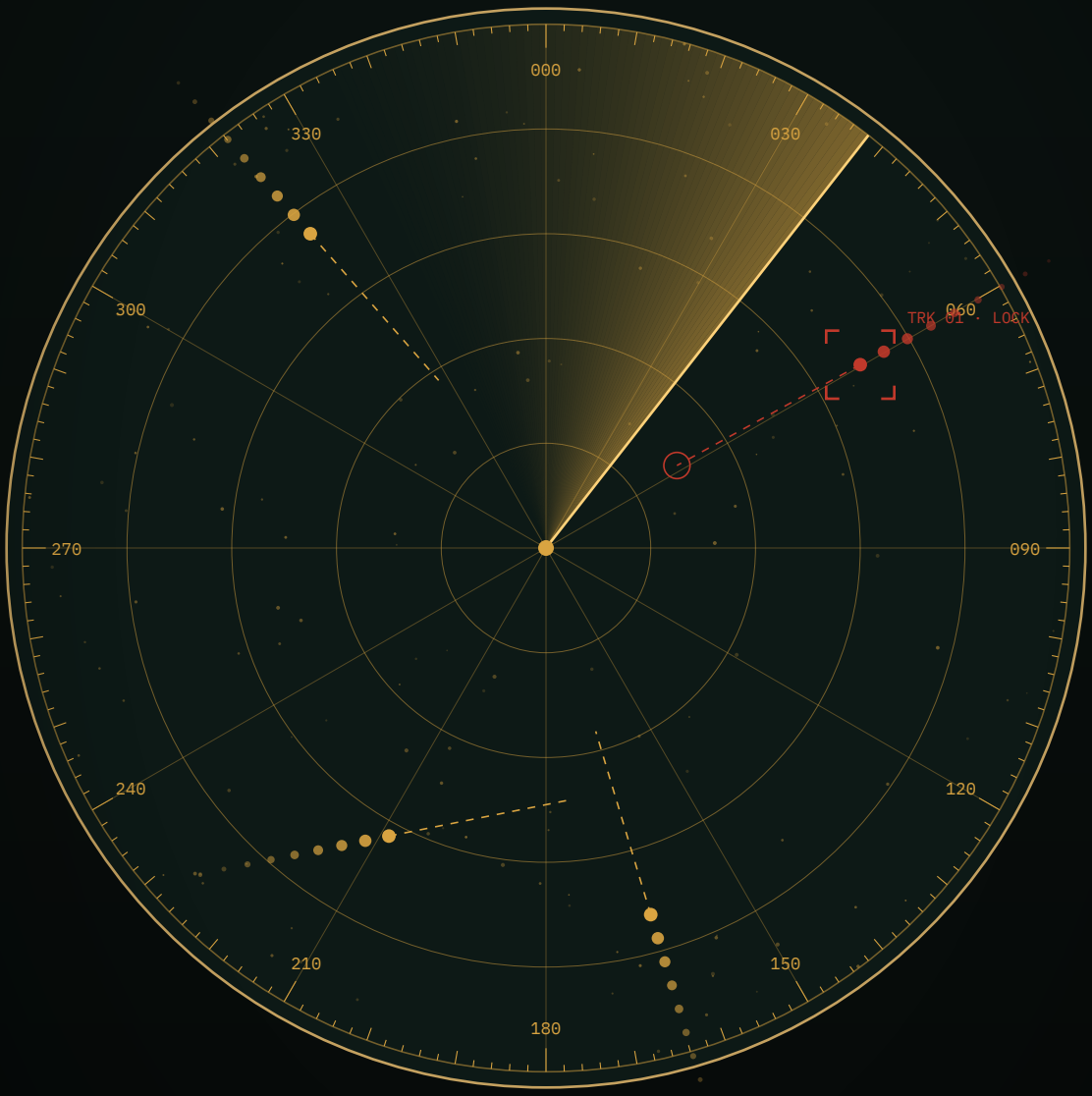
The human hunt in fiction after Connell: a selection.

YEAR AND MEDIUM	WORK	HUNTER		QUARRY	FRAME OF THE GAME	EXIT IMAGINED
1896, novel	*The Island of Doctor Moreau* (Wells)	Moreau and the Beast Folk	→	The Leopard-Man; Prendick	The Law and the House of Pain	*Moreau killed; Prendick escapes by sea*
1904, novel	*The Sea-Wolf* (London)	Wolf Larsen	→	Humphrey Van Weyden	A sealing voyage; "the lucky eat the most"	*The predator destroyed from within*
1939, novel	*Rogue Male* (Household)	A dictatorship's agent	→	An English sportsman	The "sporting stalk"	*The quarry names his motive and returns to finish the stalk*
1953, story	"The Seventh Victim" (Sheckley)	A registered Hunter	→	A registered Victim	A state Catharsis Board	*None: the roles alternate*
1958, story	"The Prize of Peril" (Sheckley)	Hired killers	→	A television contestant	A game show and its audience	*Survival on camera*
1968, novel; 1982, film	*Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep? Blade Runner*	Bounty hunters	→	Androids	The empathy test	*Roy Batty's mercy*
1982, novel; 1987, film	*The Running Man* (King)	The Games Network's hunters	→	Ben Richards	A televised national hunt	*Destruction of the network's headquarters*
1987, film	*Predator* (McTiernan)	An alien trophy hunter	→	Commandos	The hunter's code	*Mud, traps, and a duel of equals*
1999, novel; 2000, film	*Battle Royale* (Takami)	The state	→	A school class	The Program, its collars and forbidden zones	*Escape from the island*
2008–10, novels	*The Hunger Games* (Collins)	The Capitol	→	Tributes	The Games and their odds	*The berries; the arrow aimed at Coin*
1998–, manga	*Hunter × Hunter* (Togashi)	The Chimera Ant king	→	Humanity	The board game Gungi	*Recognition across the board; death together*
2016–20, manga	*The Promised Neverland* (Shirai and Demizu)	Demon nobles	→	Children	A secret hunting reserve	*The children kill the hunters*
2021, television	*Squid Game* (Hwang)	VIPs and the games' creator	→	Debtors	Children's games, a contract, a vote	*The survivor turns back from his departing flight*

There is the exit by abdication, which Chapter Four found in Prospero's drowned book. And there is the exit by the refusal of succession: Katniss's arrow, aimed not at the defeated tyrant but at the victor who would restart the Games. Each breaks the logic of the hunt at a different point, and none of them is Rainsford's. He takes the bed.

The century's speculative fiction, then, did not merely repeat Connell's story. It developed the story's implications in every direction the story left open, and it found most of the alternatives the story declined. What it could not do, being fiction, was prevent the general's island from being built. The next chapter turns from the literature of the human hunt to its realization: the media that made it a spectacle, the machines that made it a science, and the institutions that made it, in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, a routine function of power.




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CHAPTER SEVEN

From Ship-Trap to Kill Chain

Media, Machines, and the Afterlives of the Manhunt

§ 7.1

Kill, Then Love: The RKO Adaptation of 1932

Eight years after its publication, "The Most Dangerous Game" became a film, and the circumstances of its making form a chapter in the history of the hunt as spectacle. RKO Radio Pictures produced it in 1932 under Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack, the team that was simultaneously preparing *King Kong*. Schoedsack co-directed with Irving Pichel from a screenplay by James Ashmore Creelman, and Max Steiner, who would score *Kong*, wrote the music. The two films shared jungle sets on the studio's lot and shared performers: Fay Wray and Robert Armstrong appear in both, and Noble Johnson, who plays Zaroff's servant Ivan, plays the island chief in *Kong*. *The Most Dangerous Game* was released in September 1932, the first of the pair to reach the screen.

The men who made it had lived in the story's world. Cooper and Schoedsack had made their names with *Grass* (1925), a documentary of the seasonal migration of the Bakhtiari herders of Persia, and *Chang* (1927), a "drama of the wilderness" filmed in Siam, in which a family's struggle against tigers and leopards culminates in an elephant stampede—an ethnographic adventure in which the hunt was staged for the camera. Cooper had flown in the Polish-Soviet War of 1919–20 with the Kościuszko Squadron of American volunteers, in the war whose Red Cossack cavalry Babel chronicled; shot down and captured in 1920, he escaped from a Soviet prison camp the following year. The producer of the film about a White Russian general who fled the Bolsheviks had himself been a prisoner of the Bolsheviks.

The film changed the story in three ways, each of which reveals something the story had kept latent. The first concerns the general himself. Connell's General Zaroff becomes Count Zaroff, played by the English actor Leslie Banks, whose face had been scarred and partly paralyzed by wounds received in the Great War. The film exploits the injury. Its Zaroff bears a scar on his forehead, which he touches as he speaks of the hunt that obsesses him. The physi-

ological etiology that Chapter Three found muted in Connell's text—"Fractured my skull," "a splitting headache"—becomes on screen the visible sign of the general's obsession, borne by an actor whose own face was a document of the war.

The second change is the addition of a woman. The film's Rainsford—Bob Rainsford, played by Joel McCrea—arrives at the château to find other guests: Eve Trowbridge (Fay Wray) and her drunken brother Martin (Robert Armstrong), survivors of an earlier wreck. Martin is hunted and killed; Eve becomes Rainsford's companion in the hunt and the general's intended prize. Zaroff states the new erotic logic in a formula, "Kill, then love!": only after the kill, he explains, does a man know ecstasy. As Chapter Two observed, the film thereby re-Sadeanized Connell's sexless island, restoring the libertine's linkage of violence and desire that the story had suppressed. The hunt becomes a contest over a woman, and the most dangerous game acquires the shape of the romance its audiences had been taught to expect.

The third change concerns the trophies. The film shows what the story only names. Zaroff's trophy room displays human heads mounted on its walls and a head floating in a jar of preservative. According to accounts of the production, preview audiences recoiled, and the trophy-room footage was cut back before release. The library of heads, which Connell kept offstage, proved too strong to show in full even in the permissive years before the Production Code began to be strictly enforced in 1934.

The film's ending, too, makes visible what the story elides. In place of an ellipsis there is a fight in the château; the wounded Zaroff falls from a window into the courtyard where his own hounds wait, and Rainsford and Eve escape by motorboat. Actaeon's fate, implied in Connell, is staged. And the closing image is not a man alone in a better bed but a couple fleeing the island together, the romantic resolution substituted for the Nemorensian succession. The film refuses the story's most disturbing implication. Its Rainsford does not stay; he takes the girl and leaves.

The companion film completed the thought. In *King Kong* (1933), a showman-filmmaker named Carl Denham, played by the same Robert Armstrong, sails to an uncharted island, captures its giant ape with gas bombs, and exhibits him in New York as "the Eighth Wonder of the World." Kong escapes, climbs the Empire State Building with Fay Wray in his hand, and is shot down by aircraft. The pilot and gunner of the plane that kills him were played by Cooper and Schoedsack themselves; the makers of the two films cast themselves, at the last, as the hunters.

On the same sets, within a single year, RKO filmed the hunting of a man on an island and the capture, exhibition, and killing of a beast taken from one. The two films are the venatic paradigm's twin faces in the cinema of the Depression: the human as quarry, the animal as trophy, and the camera as the instrument that converts both into spectacle.

§ 7.2

Remakes and Their Enemies: The Cinema of the Human Hunt, 1945–2020

The story's later adaptations form a revealing series, because each remake must decide who the hunter is and who the quarry, and each decision registers the anxieties of its moment. Read in sequence, the films are a seismograph of the twentieth century's changing answers to the question of who may be hunted, and by whom.

RKO remade its own film in 1945 as *A Game of Death*, directed by Robert Wise. The war was ending, and the hunter's nationality changed with it: the Russian count became a German. In Roy Boulting's *Run for the Sun* (1956), the hunters are a British traitor who had broadcast for the Nazis and a German war criminal hiding with him on a jungle estate in Mexico; the hunted are an American writer and a journalist whose plane has crashed nearby. The White Russian aristocrat of 1924, fleeing a revolution, became in the postwar decade the fascist fugitive fleeing justice. In both films the hunter is a European exile in the Americas, and the story's island becomes a refuge for the defeated party of a war.

Cornel Wilde's *The Naked Prey* (1965) inverted the racial structure of the colonial hunt. Set in southern Africa in the nineteenth century and loosely inspired by the trapper John Colter's flight from the Blackfeet in 1808, it follows a white safari guide who, after his party offends a local chief, is stripped, given a head start, and hunted across the veld by warriors. The film's politics are ambivalent—its African characters are largely denied interiority—but its structure places a European, for the length of a feature, in the position the colonial hunt had assigned to Africans. The quarry is given a start, as Zaroff's quarry are given three hours.

By the 1990s the quarry had changed. John Woo's *Hard Target* (1993), the Hong Kong director's first American film, follows a man who sells wealthy clients the opportunity to hunt homeless military veterans through the streets and bayous of New Orleans. Ernest Dickerson's *Surviving the Game* (1994) sends a homeless man, played by Ice-T, into the northwestern wilderness as the quarry of a party of rich hunters who have hired him as their guide. In both films the huntable class is the abandoned veteran or the man on the street—Zaroff's "scum of the earth," relocated from the tramp steamers to the sidewalks of American cities. *Hard Target*'s choice of veterans is pointed. Connell's general appealed to Rainsford's "experiences in the war"; the films of the 1990s made the men who returned from America's wars into the game of its wealthy.

The form's recent iterations have made its economic logic explicit. In a 2020 series of the same title made for the short-lived streaming service Quibi, a terminally ill man, desperate to provide for his pregnant wife after his death, accepts an offer of money to be hunted through a city for a day. The general's "option" has become a market transaction, and the quarry's consent has a price. The same logic organizes *Squid Game*, discussed in Chapter Six, and it is

the terminus of the series that began with the knout. The quarry of 1924 chose the hunt to escape torture; the quarry of 2020 chooses it to escape poverty and leave something behind.

The sequence of hunters is equally instructive. The Russian aristocrat of 1924 and 1932, the German of 1945, the Nazi fugitive of 1956, the businessmen of the 1990s, and the faceless wealthy of 2020 trace a movement from the hunter as a defeated relic of an old regime to the hunter as an anonymous holder of capital. Zaroff was a person, with a name, a biography, a library, and a skull fractured by a buffalo. His successors are increasingly a class, an organization, a service. The general's island, which in 1924 depended on one man's eccentric fortune, becomes in the later films a business that anyone with enough money may patronize.

Two further variations carry the form beyond the remake into adjacent genres. The first is the survival film of the 1970s and early 1980s, in which ordinary city men are hunted in the wilderness by its inhabitants—John Boorman's *Deliverance* (1972), Walter Hill's *Southern Comfort* (1981)—and in which the hunting is not sport but an expression of hostility between classes and regions. The second is the action film built on Rainsford's techniques. Ted Kotcheff's *First Blood* (1982), from David Morrell's novel of 1972, follows John Rambo, a Vietnam veteran harassed by a small-town sheriff, who flees into the forest and, hunted by deputies and the National Guard, turns the woods into a field of traps learned in a colonial war: sharpened stakes, deadfalls, concealed pits. Rambo is Rainsford's heir in the age of Vietnam, a veteran whose war has taught him the trapping lore of the people he was sent to fight, and who brings that knowledge home.

The remakes and their kin confirm, from another angle, the argument of Chapter Six. The structure of Connell's story proved endlessly adaptable because its two positions could be filled by whomever a given decade feared or despised. What changed was the occupant. What did not change was the form.

§ 7.3

The Hunted Man in the Frame: Hitchcock, Apocalypto, and the Chase

Beyond the explicit adaptations lies a larger territory: the cinema of the chase, whose fundamental situation—a man pursued across open ground by an enemy he cannot see—Connell's story helped to shape and the medium was uniquely equipped to render. Film is a medium of pursuit. Among its earliest narrative forms was the chase, and its grammar of cutting between pursuer and pursued, of point-of-view shots and reverse angles, makes the spectator by turns the hunter and the quarry. Suspense, in the cinema, is often the interval of the hunt rendered in time.

Alfred Hitchcock made the hunted man the hero of a career. *The 39 Steps* (1935), *Saboteur* (1942), and *North by Northwest* (1959) each follow an innocent man pursued by criminals and

police at once across a widening landscape. *North by Northwest* contains the most celebrated image of the hunted man in American film. Roger Thornhill, lured to a deserted crossroads in the Indiana farm country, stands alone in a flat expanse that offers no cover while a crop-dusting plane dives at him again and again. The scene is the lion-and-man arena of Chapter Five in its purest form: an open field, a faster pursuer, and no boundary to escape through. Thornhill survives by running into the corn and then, improbably, into the path of a fuel truck, which the plane strikes.

The film ends on a monument of heads. Thornhill and the woman he loves are pursued across the carved faces of Mount Rushmore—Washington, Jefferson, Theodore Roosevelt, and Lincoln, each some sixty feet high—and they cling to the stone brows of the presidents as their pursuers close in. Among the heads over which the hunted pair scramble is Roosevelt's: the hunter-president whose expeditions stocked the American Museum of Natural History and whose idiom Rainsford speaks. The colossal heads are the nation's trophy room, and Hitchcock's hunted man ends his flight upon them. It is the most spectacular library of heads in the cinema, and it belongs to the American state.

Mel Gibson's *Apocalypto* (2006) returned the hunt to the jungle and to the threshold of the colonial era. Jaguar Paw, a young hunter of a Mesoamerican village, is captured in a raid and taken to a city to be sacrificed; he escapes and is pursued back through the forest by a party of warriors. The chase occupies most of the film's second half, and its incidents read like a catalogue of Rainsford's devices and Chapter Four's myths. The fugitive eludes a black jaguar, which kills one of his pursuers. He leaps from the top of a waterfall into the pool below, and the pursuers who follow hesitate at the edge. He poisons thorns with the secretion of a frog and rigs a deadfall in the forest. And he kills his hunters one by one with the techniques of the hunted.

The film's ending places the whole structure at the moment of the conquest. The surviving pursuers drive Jaguar Paw onto a beach, where all of them stop, staring at Spanish ships anchored offshore and armored men rowing toward land. The Caribbean manhunts recorded by Las Casas, examined in Chapter Two, are about to begin. The film's quarry escapes into the forest; the Europeans, with their dogs and their wagers, arrive on the sand.

Apocalypto thus reunites on a single beach the two halves of the history this dissertation has tracked: an Indigenous hunt of men, staged as the film's main action, and the colonial hunt of men, announced in its last image. The ships carry the future of Ship-Trap Island. Critics have asked whether the film's portrait of Mesoamerican violence repeats the justifications by which the conquest was long defended; the structure, at least, is unmistakable. One hunt ends where another begins.

The cinema of the chase also developed a characteristic image of the hunter's vision. In *Predator* (1987), discussed in Chapter Six, the audience sees at intervals through the alien's eyes: a thermal image in which human bodies glow red and orange against the cold blue of the jungle. The shot became one of the most imitated in action cinema, and its source was not fantasy but military technology. Thermal imaging had been developed for targeting and

was mounted by the 1980s on helicopters and armored vehicles; the forward-looking infrared camera would become, in the following decades, the eye of the armed drone. The alien hunter's point of view was the soldier's, and in the twenty-first century it became the remote operator's.

Hollywood's chase films, then, inherited from Connell more than a premise. They inherited a structure of vision, in which the spectator enters the hunter's sight and the quarry's terror by turns, and they developed it into a technology of suspense. The hunted man became a hero of the screen because the screen could make its audience feel what it is to be hunted while assuring it that it was watching from the safety of the hunter's distance.

§ 7.4

"The Most Dangeroue Anamal": True Crime and the Literalization of the Story

In the summer of 1969 a killer who called himself the Zodiac, responsible for a series of murders in the San Francisco Bay Area, mailed a cipher in three parts to three newspapers and demanded that they print it. A schoolteacher, Donald Harden, and his wife, Bettye, solved it within about a week. The plaintext, misspelled throughout, declared that the writer liked killing people because it was more fun than killing wild game in the forest, "because man is the most dangeroue anamal of all to kill." It went on to promise that those he killed would become his slaves in the afterlife.

The allusion to Connell's story, or to its films, was widely noted and has been discussed ever since. Whatever the writer's source, his message is the most literal realization of the story's premise in the historical record: a killer who described his murders as the hunting of the most dangerous animal, and who imagined his victims as a collection of servants awaiting him in paradise. The Zodiac's afterlife of slaves is the general's library of heads translated into eschatology. The trophy is no longer kept on a wall; it is kept forever.

The case illuminates the thesis of the literalizing island from the far side. Connell's story converted metaphors into practices within a fiction. The Zodiac converted the fiction into a practice, taking the story's conceit—the human being as the supreme game—as a description of what he did. The story's irony, which depends on the reader's horror at the general's literalism, is exactly what such a reader lacks. The general is a figure meant to be refused; the killer took him as a model. A fiction that stages literalization can itself be literalized.

A second case is more precise and more terrible. Robert Hansen, a baker in Anchorage and an accomplished big-game hunter, abducted women in Alaska between the early 1970s and 1983, most of them sex workers or dancers whose disappearance, he calculated, would attract little attention. He flew some of them in his private plane to remote country in the Knik River valley, released them, and hunted them with a rifle and a knife. He was arrested after a young woman escaped from him in 1983 and went to the police; he confessed to seventeen murders,

was sentenced in 1984, and died in prison in 2014. His case was dramatized in the film *The Frozen Ground* (2013).

Hansen's crimes reproduce the story's structure in detail. The hunter is a trophy hunter who has turned from animals to human beings. The quarry is chosen from a class he regards as disposable—the general's "scum of the earth," relocated to the bars of Anchorage. The victims are given a start in the wilderness and pursued. The site is remote and reachable only by air, as Ship-Trap Island is reachable only by sea. And the selection of victims depends on the assumption that no one will ask after them, as the general's sailors belong to no state that will. Hansen's undoing came, like the general's, from a quarry who escaped and refused the silence the hunter required. The woman who fled to the police is the Rainsford of the case: she agreed to nothing of the kind.

These cases must be handled with care, because the temptation of the true-crime genre is to make the killer interesting at the expense of the people he killed. The women Hansen murdered were not characters in a story about him; they were persons whose deaths were made possible by a social judgment that their lives counted for less. That judgment, not the killer's imagination, is what links the case to Connell's story. The general's taxonomy of quarry, examined in Chapter Two, is not the private fantasy of a deranged aristocrat. It is a ranking of human worth that circulates in ordinary social life, and a man who wishes to hunt human beings without consequence need only consult it to know where to begin.

The true-crime cases also confirm the story's insight into the hunter's need for recognition. The Zodiac wrote to newspapers, demanded publication, and taunted the police; he needed his hunt to be known. The general needed Rainsford's assent and, failing that, his participation. The modern hunter of human beings is seldom satisfied with the kill alone. He wants an audience, and in an age of mass media he can command one. Connell's general hunted in private on an island no one could reach; his literal heirs hunted in public and wrote to the papers.

The story's afterlife in crime thus discloses the risk inherent in its central conceit. By naming the human being as the most dangerous game, the story offered a formula that could be read in two directions: as a warning against those who would hunt human beings, and as a description of the pleasure they take in it. Connell intended the first reading. History has supplied instances of the second, and a responsible reading of the story must hold both in view.

§ 7.5

The Hunts That Were Named: History's Ship-Trap Islands

The general calls his practice hunting, and Rainsford calls it murder. History contains episodes in which the practitioners themselves chose the general's word, and a study of this kind must name them, soberly, because they establish that the story's conceit was never only a conceit. The examples that follow are not offered as equivalents of one another or of the story. They

are offered as evidence that the vocabulary and techniques of the hunt have repeatedly served to organize the killing of human beings, and that the organization has followed the structure Connell imagined.

In Van Diemen's Land, the British colony on the island of Tasmania, the conflict between settlers and Aboriginal Tasmanians in the 1820s and early 1830s, known as the Black War, included a military operation unlike any other in the history of Australian colonization. In October and November 1830 the colonial government organized the "Black Line," a cordon of soldiers, settlers, and convicts that advanced across the settled districts of the island in an attempt to drive the Aboriginal population onto a peninsula in the southeast. The operation captured almost no one, but within a few years the surviving Aboriginal people of the island had been removed to Flinders Island. It was this history that Wells invoked in *The War of the Worlds*: the extermination of the Tasmanians, "in the space of fifty years," by European immigrants. An island was swept as a field is beaten for game.

In Tierra del Fuego at the end of the nineteenth century, the expansion of sheep ranching onto the lands of the Selk'nam was accompanied by killings carried out or encouraged by ranchers and hired men, some of whom were reportedly paid bounties on proof of each person killed; within a generation the Selk'nam population had collapsed. Bounties for the bodies or body parts of Indigenous people had a long history in the Americas. Colonial governments in North America, Massachusetts and Pennsylvania among them, paid premiums for Native scalps. The scalp bounty is the trophy converted into a receipt, the economy that Chapter Five found in the severed hands of the Congo Free State: a part of the body exchanged for payment as proof that the hunt was carried out.

The twentieth century supplied the most explicit instance. In the early hours of 2 February 1945, several hundred Soviet prisoners, most of them officers, broke out of a punishment block at the Mauthausen concentration camp in Upper Austria. Over the following days the SS, local police, the Volkssturm, members of the Hitler Youth, and many local civilians hunted them through the snow-covered countryside of the Mühlviertel, shooting or beating to death most of those they found. The operation was referred to as the *Mühlviertler Hasenjagd*, the "Mühlviertel hare hunt." Only about a dozen of the escapees are known to have survived, several of them hidden at great risk by local families. The perpetrators' word for the killing of escaped prisoners was the name of a sport.

The historian Jan Grabowski, in a study of rural Poland under German occupation published in English as *Hunt for the Jews* (2013), documented a related practice: the *Judenjagd*, the hunt for Jews who had escaped the deportations and were hiding in the countryside, carried out by German police with the participation of local auxiliaries and informers between 1942 and 1945. Here, too, the perpetrators used the vocabulary of the chase, and here, too, the hunt depended on the collaboration of a population taught to regard the hunted as outside its moral community.

These episodes differ profoundly from one another and from Connell's fiction. They were not games; they were not undertaken to relieve anyone's ennui; their perpetrators did not, for

the most part, imagine themselves as connoisseurs. What links them to the story is the structure this dissertation has called the venatic paradigm. In each, a population is first placed outside the circle of those whose killing would count as murder. In each, the killing is organized as a pursuit, with the techniques of the chase: the drive, the cordon, the pack, the bounty. In each, the language of the hunt supplies a frame that converts killing into something else—a sweep, a clearance, a "hare hunt." And in each, the frame depends on the participation of many who would not have called themselves killers.

Grégoire Chamayou's history of manhunts, cited throughout this dissertation, places such episodes in a long series that runs from the Spartan *krypteia* to the policing of migrants. Its central argument is that the hunt is not merely a metaphor for these practices but a form of power with its own logic: a power that does not govern its objects but pursues, captures, and eliminates them, and that requires as its precondition a division of humanity into hunters and quarry. Connell's story is fiction. The division it imagined on a single island was enacted, on a vast scale, by the states and societies of the century in which it was written.

§ 7.6

The Ontology of the Enemy: Cybernetics and the Calculable Quarry

Zaroff's problem was a problem of prediction. The animal "had nothing but his legs and his instinct," and its movements could be foreseen with "a mathematical certainty"; the reasoning quarry could vary, deceive, and surprise, and so restored the uncertainty that made the hunt worth pursuing. Within two decades of the story's publication, the most advanced science of the period confronted the same problem from the other side. Its task was to remove the uncertainty that a reasoning quarry introduces into the hunt—to make the evasive human being as predictable as an animal.

In 1940 the mathematician Norbert Wiener, with the engineer Julian Bigelow, began work for the United States' National Defense Research Committee on an anti-aircraft predictor: a device that would forecast the future position of an enemy aircraft from its observed track, so that a gun could be aimed at the point where the plane would be when the shell arrived. The difficulty was the pilot. A bomber flying straight is an easy target; a pilot who knows he is being fired on swerves and jinks to throw off the gunners' aim. Wiener's insight was to treat pilot and aircraft together as a single mechanical system whose evasive maneuvers, however intelligent, obeyed statistical regularities that could be learned from the record of past flights. The human quarry was modeled as a servomechanism.

The historian of science Peter Galison, in "The Ontology of the Enemy" (1994), argued that this wartime work shaped the whole of Wiener's later cybernetics, the science of control and communication in animals and machines that he named and popularized in *Cybernetics*

(1948). The enemy in Wiener's model was neither the racialized foe of wartime propaganda nor the anonymous mass target of strategic bombing, but a rational, calculating opponent whose behavior could be captured as a pattern. Wiener himself later distinguished, in *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), two kinds of devil: the "Augustinian" devil of nature, a disorder that does not change its strategy to defeat the scientist, and the "Manichaean" devil, an active opponent who adapts in order to win. The anti-aircraft problem was a Manichaean problem. The quarry fought back by thinking.

Wiener's two devils are the two quarries of Connell's story. The animal is the Augustinian devil, an opponent whose behavior is fixed by instinct and can be mastered once understood. The reasoning human is the Manichaean devil, who adapts, deceives, and plays to win. The general sought the Manichaean opponent because the Augustinian one bored him. Wiener's project sought to reduce the Manichaean opponent to the Augustinian, so that the reasoning quarry could be hunted with the certainty the general found tedious. Cybernetics, in this light, is the general's problem solved in the opposite direction: the science of making the most dangerous game safe to hunt.

The postwar development of pursuit and evasion as mathematical disciplines, traced in Chapter Five through Rufus Isaacs's work at the RAND Corporation, followed from the same problem, and missile guidance was its principal application. The air-to-air missile developed by the United States Navy in the 1950s was named for a desert rattlesnake, the sidewinder, a pit viper that finds its prey by sensing the heat of its body; the Sidewinder missile, too, homed on heat. The predator's sensory organ had become a weapons system, and the target's body heat had become the trace by which it was hunted.

The general's handicap ran opposite to this development. Zaroff armed himself with "a pistol of the smallest caliber and range" in order to give his quarry a chance, because a hunt without risk to the hunter was, for him, no hunt at all. The science of the calculable quarry pursued the reverse aim: to reduce the hunter's risk to zero and the quarry's chance to nothing, perfecting the hunt by abolishing its uncertainty. "There is no greater bore than perfection," the general said. The engineering of the twentieth century set out to achieve the perfection he found boring, and it solved the problem of boredom by removing the bored man from the hunt.

That removal is the decisive transformation. Zaroff hunted in person, at night, on foot, at the risk of his skull. The hunter of the cybernetic age is a system: a sensor, a predictor, a guidance loop, an operator at a screen. The danger to the hunter, which the general cultivated as the source of the hunt's meaning, has been designed out. What remains is the quarry, now a pattern in the data, and the kill, now an output. The next section follows this transformation to its present form.

§ 7.7

Predator and Reaper: The Manhunt as Doctrine

The names were chosen by people who knew what the machines would do. The General Atomics MQ-1 Predator, an unmanned aircraft first flown in the mid-1990s as a surveillance platform, was armed with Hellfire missiles after 2001 and became a principal instrument of the targeted-killing campaigns of the following decade. Its larger successor, the MQ-9, was named the Reaper. The aircraft were flown by crews seated at ground stations, often thousands of miles away, watching through cameras that included the thermal imagers made familiar by the 1987 film whose alien hunter shared the first drone's name.

The military vocabulary that grew up around these operations drew openly on the hunt. The sequence by which a target is found and killed came to be called the "kill chain," often summarized in the formula "find, fix, track, target, engage, assess." The study of a person's daily movements and associations, used to identify him as a target, was called "pattern-of-life" analysis. In some operations, strikes were authorized not against named individuals but against people whose behavior matched a profile associated with hostile activity—so-called "signature strikes." Doctrinal studies in the American special-operations community used the word "manhunting" without euphemism, as in a 2009 report of the Joint Special Operations University titled *Manhunting: Counter-Network Organization for Irregular Warfare*. And in May 2011 the team that killed Osama bin Laden in Abbottabad reported its result under the code word "Geronimo," the name of the Apache leader pursued by thousands of American troops in the 1880s. The most famous manhunt of the twenty-first century borrowed its code name from one of the most famous of the nineteenth.

Targeted killing by drone has been the subject of sustained controversy, and its terms deserve a fair statement. Its defenders have argued that remote precision strikes allow states to act against armed groups in places where ground operations would be impossible or more destructive, that they spare the lives of soldiers, and that, compared with conventional air power or ground assaults, they can reduce harm to civilians. Its critics have argued that the secrecy surrounding target selection, the use of behavioral signatures, and the absence of risk to the attacking side erode the legal and moral restraints on the use of force. In 2010 the United Nations Special Rapporteur on extrajudicial executions, Philip Alston, warned of the danger of a "PlayStation" mentality toward killing among those who conduct it from afar. Studies of drone crews have also documented psychological strain among operators who watch their targets for long periods before and after a strike.

For the argument of this dissertation the controversy matters less than the structure, which Grégoire Chamayou analyzed in *Théorie du drone* (2013). Classical war, whatever its brutality, was in principle a reciprocal combat between parties who could kill each other. The armed drone, Chamayou argued, abolishes the reciprocity. Its operator cannot be reached by its target; the relation between them is no longer a fight but a pursuit, in which one party is hunter and the other only prey. War becomes, in his term, "cynegetic," a matter of tracking and

killing rather than of combat between enemies. One may contest Chamayou's conclusions, as defenders of the practice do, and still recognize the accuracy of his structural description.

Connell's story permits a further observation. The general's hunt was constituted by risk: the smallest pistol, the three-hour start, the reasoning quarry who might, and finally did, kill the hunter. Zaroff despised the hunt without risk as a "bore." The drone realizes precisely the hunt the general refused: safety for the hunter, near-certainty of the outcome, and a quarry identified by a pattern, much as the general's quarry were assessed as "specimens." It is the general's game with the sporting proposition removed. Where Zaroff restored a duel at the end, the drone forecloses even the possibility of one.

Yet the game-form survives in the new hunt, displaced into its interface. The operator watches a screen, guides a cursor, and receives the result as an image. The resemblance between the drone interface and the video game, which Alston's warning invoked, is not accidental; armed forces have drawn on gaming hardware and on the skills of players. The magic circle of Chapter Five, which the general drew around his island, is redrawn around a monitor. Within it the operator acts, while the effects of his action fall entirely outside, on people who never enter the game.

The thesis of the double game holds here in its most consequential form. The most dangerous game is the form that converts the decision over life into a procedure with rules, steps, and outputs. Zaroff's rules were a sportsman's affectation; the kill chain's are a bureaucracy's protocol. Both turn the killing of a human being into the completion of a sequence. The difference is that the general's sequence ended in a duel he could lose, while the kill chain is designed so that the hunter cannot lose at all.

§ 7.8

Ludic Architectures: The Video Game as Hunting Ground

The video game is the medium in which the general's island became a mass leisure activity. The most popular genre of the late 2010s was, in structure, Ship-Trap Island multiplied. In *PlayerUnknown's Battlegrounds* (2017) and *Fortnite Battle Royale* (2017), as many as a hundred players parachute onto an island, scavenge for weapons, and hunt one another while a storm or a lethal boundary contracts the playable area, until a single player or team remains. The genre took its name from Takami's novel and Fukasaku's film, which its designers acknowledged as an inspiration, and within a few years games of this form were played by hundreds of millions of people.

The battle-royale genre realizes the structures this dissertation has analyzed with almost diagrammatic clarity. The island is a magic circle in Huizinga's sense, bounded in space and time and governed by its own rules. The contracting zone is the forbidden areas of *Battle Royale* and the lion-and-man arena of Chapter Five, a space of evasion closing around the quarry. Every player is both hunter and hunted, as in Sheckley's Hunt and the island exami-

nation of *Hunter* × *Hunter*. And the genre's economy depends on cosmetic items, purchased to change a character's appearance, that the industry calls "skins"—a word whose resonance with the trophy pelt needs no comment. The most dangerous game has become a free-to-play entertainment financed by the sale of skins.

What distinguishes the genre from the general's game is the element Chapter Five found missing from his: the lusory attitude. The players of a battle royale enter voluntarily, accept its obstacles for the sake of the activity, and leave unharmed. Suits's definition is fully satisfied, and the island's asymmetry is abolished, since every player holds both roles and none is coerced. The video game is the general's island with the predicament removed: the hunt as pure play, available to everyone. Whether that removal neutralizes the structure or merely habituates millions to it is a question that the long and inconclusive debate over violence in games has not settled, and this dissertation does not claim to settle it.

Other games have explored the structure more critically. Rockstar's *Manhunt* (2003) cast the player as a condemned man forced by a former film director to kill a series of gang members in a derelict city, while hidden cameras record the killings for sale as snuff films; the game graded each killing by its brutality, and it was refused classification or banned in several countries. Its premise is the general's hunt made into content: the quarry is the hunter's victim, the hunter is someone else's quarry, and the whole is staged for a connoisseur who watches. In *Far Cry 3* (2012), a privileged young American tourist, kidnapped by pirates on a tropical archipelago, becomes a skilled killer; the game's crafting system requires the player to hunt and skin animals to make wallets, holsters, and bags, and the protagonist's transformation into a hunter of men is presented, ambiguously, as both empowerment and corruption. *Far Cry 5* (2018) gave the player an antagonist, a veteran turned cult leader, who preaches that the herd must be culled so that only the strong survive, and who tests his captives with trials and trained wolves.

Red Dead Redemption 2 (2018) encoded the ethics of the fair chase in its mechanics. Its hunting system grades each pelt according to the animal's condition and the cleanness of the kill, rewarding the player who chooses the right weapon for the animal and kills precisely; a careless shot spoils the skin. The sportsman's code of the Boone and Crockett Club has become an optimization problem. FromSoftware's *Bloodborne* (2015), by contrast, made the hunter's transformation into his quarry its central theme. Its hunters stalk a city overrun by beasts, and the beasts are revealed as former citizens, former hunters among them, transformed by the blood they consumed; the longer the hunter hunts, the nearer he comes to becoming a beast. Bruno's Actaeon, devoured by the hounds of his own pursuit, has become a game.

Asymmetric multiplayer games reproduced the island's founding inequality. In *Dead by Daylight* (2016), one player takes the role of a powerful killer and four others the roles of survivors who must evade him and escape, and players alternate between the roles from match to match. The game's structure is Zaroff's: a hunter with superior power, a quarry with cunning, a bounded map, hooks on which the captured are hung. Its millions of players have done voluntarily what Sheckley's society did by law. They have made the hunt a game in which anyone may be either party.

The video game thus completes a trajectory that began with the general's private island. The hunting of human beings, first imagined as a degenerate aristocrat's secret, then as a state institution, then as a televised spectacle, has become a common pastime, and the general's position, which once required a fortune and an island, is now available to anyone with a console. The medium's defenders and critics disagree about what that availability means. For the argument of this dissertation it means at least this: the structure of the most dangerous game has become one of the most familiar forms of play in the contemporary world.

§ 7.9

The Option Universalized: Surveillance, Attention, and the Trap

Connell wrote advertising copy before and after the war, and the vocabulary of his first profession is the vocabulary of the hunt. Advertisers address a "target" audience; they mount "campaigns"; they "capture" attention, generate "leads," and measure "conversion." The language is military and venatic at once, and it records an understanding older than the internet: that commerce is a form of pursuit in which the consumer is the quarry. The economy of digital platforms in the twenty-first century converted that understanding into an infrastructure.

Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) described the business model of the major internet companies as the extraction of "behavioral surplus"—the data generated by users' activity beyond what is needed to provide a service—and its conversion into predictions of future behavior, sold to advertisers and others. Zuboff rejected the familiar slogan that the users of free services are the product. They are, she argued, more like elephants killed for their ivory: the valuable material is taken from them, and the user is the abandoned carcass. The image is venatic in the strictest sense. The user is the hunted animal whose trophy is extracted, and the platform is the hunter.

The techniques of the platform economy are, in their own technical vocabulary, techniques of tracking. Users are followed across websites by "trackers"; their devices are identified by "fingerprinting," the reconstruction of a unique signature from the traces a browser leaves. The vocabulary recalls the evidential paradigm with which this dissertation began. Ginzburg's history of conjectural knowledge included among its central episodes Francis Galton's systematization of fingerprint identification in *Finger Prints* (1892)—the same Galton whose eugenics supplied Chapter Two with its scale of thoroughbreds and mongrels. The man who ranked human beings by breeding also taught institutions to identify them by their traces. The platform economy has generalized his method: everyone leaves prints, and everyone is followed.

Interface designers have a name for the techniques by which users are steered into choices they would not otherwise make: "dark patterns," a term coined by the designer Harry Brignull

in 2010. One pattern in his catalogue is called the "roach motel," after the insect trap, because it makes a commitment easy to enter and hard to leave. Ship-Trap Island is a roach motel. Its false channel lights draw ships in; its reef keeps them there. The platform's lure—the notification, the recommendation, the headline written to be clicked—is a channel light in Zaroff's sense: a signal that seems to promise safe passage and leads onto the rocks.

The decisive parallel is the general's option. "I give him his option, of course. He need not play that game if he doesn't wish to." The users of digital services are offered terms of service, long documents few read, and asked to click a button signifying agreement. They may decline; the alternative is exclusion from services that have become conditions of ordinary social and economic life. Invariably, they agree. The consent the general extracted with the knout is extracted from billions of people with a checkbox, and the alternative it offers—not torture but exclusion—is mild enough that the coercion hardly registers. The structure Rousseau identified, in which yielding to necessity is recorded as an act of will, has become the routine form of the contract between persons and the platforms through which they live.

The economist Herbert Simon observed in 1971 that an abundance of information produces a scarcity of attention. Attention, in the economy Simon foresaw and Zuboff described, is the scarce resource, and the platforms compete to capture it. The language of capture is the language of the hunt, and the attention economy is the general's island at planetary scale. Its quarry are not killed; they are held. Its hunters are not men in evening clothes but systems designed to maximize engagement. And its game-form—the feed, the streak, the score, the reward—is the most pervasive ludic architecture ever built.

It would be a category error to equate the extraction of data with the killing of human beings, and this dissertation does not do so. The claim is structural, not moral. The platform economy reproduces, at the scale of everyday life and without violence, the elements of the venatic paradigm that Connell's story assembled: the lure, the trap, the tracking of traces, the extraction of value from the quarry, and the consent obtained by arranging the alternatives. The general's island was private property on which one man hunted for pleasure. The platform is private property on which everyone is tracked for profit, and the most dangerous game, in its gentlest form, is one we play every day.

§ 7.10

The General's Island, Built

The afterlives traced in this chapter can be arranged, like the myths of Chapter Four and the fictions of Chapter Six, in a single table. Table 7.1 records for each domain who hunts, who is hunted, what frame organizes the hunt, and which element of Connell's story it realizes.

The table discloses a development in three phases. In the first, which includes the cinema and the criminal cases, the story's structure is reproduced at the scale of individuals: a hunter, a quarry, an island or its equivalent, a chase. In the second, which includes the historical

TABLE 7.1

The afterlives of the most dangerous game.



01

Cinema, 1932–2020

HUNTER
Zaroff's successors: the count, the fugitive Nazi, the businessman, the anonymous rich

FRAME
The plot of pursuit and the camera's alternating eye

QUARRY
Castaways, homeless veterans, the indebted and the dying

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The hunt as spectacle; the quarry's terror as entertainment



02

True crime, 1969–1983

HUNTER
The Zodiac; Robert Hansen

FRAME
The killer's self-image as hunter

QUARRY
Strangers; women their killer believed no one would miss

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The literalization of the story's conceit



03

Colonial and genocidal violence, 1830–1945

HUNTER
Soldiers, settlers, ranchers, police, the SS, local auxiliaries

FRAME
Drives, cordons, bounties, the "hare hunt"

QUARRY
Aboriginal Tasmanians, the Selk'nam, escaped prisoners, Jews in hiding

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The division of humanity into hunters and quarry



04

Cybernetics, 1940–

HUNTER
Fire-control and guidance systems

FRAME
Prediction of a reasoning opponent

QUARRY
The evading pilot; the heat-emitting target

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
Reason made calculable



05

Drone warfare, 2001–

HUNTER
Remote crews and analysts

FRAME
The kill chain

QUARRY
Persons identified by name or by pattern

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The hunt without risk to the hunter



06

Video games, 2003–

HUNTER
Players

FRAME
Rules, zones, scores, skins

QUARRY
Players and their avatars

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The hunt as universal leisure



07

The platform economy, 2000s–

HUNTER
Platforms and their systems

FRAME
Terms of service, trackers, the feed

QUARRY
Users

ELEMENT OF THE STORY REALIZED
The option universalized; the trap as interface

manhunts, the structure is enacted by states and societies at the scale of populations, and the hunt is organized as policy. In the third, which includes cybernetics, the drone, the video game, and the platform, the structure is embedded in technical systems, and the hunt becomes a procedure that runs whether or not anyone wishes to hunt.

Across the three phases, one feature of the general's game disappears and another persists. What disappears is the hunter's risk. Zaroff's hunt was constituted by danger to himself; its meaning lay in the possibility that the quarry would kill him, as Rainsford did. The development traced in this chapter is the progressive elimination of that possibility: from the duel in the bedroom to the crew at the ground station, from the reasoning quarry who might strike back to the pattern that cannot. The general's "There is no greater bore than perfection" has been answered by a century of engineering that pursued perfection and dissolved the problem of boredom by removing the bored man.

What persists is the game-form. The rules, the procedure, the interface, the score, the option, the frame that turns the decision over life into the completion of a sequence: these survive every change of hunter and quarry, and they grow more pervasive as the hunter's presence fades. This is the thesis of the double game in its final historical form. The most dangerous game was never only the human quarry; it was the form that makes the hunting of human beings into something other than what it is. That form has outlived the general, the island, and the decade in which Connell imagined them, and in the century since it has been built into the infrastructure of war, entertainment, and everyday life.

The task of the final chapter is to draw the consequences for the question with which the dissertation began. If the hunt is a scene in which the human is produced, tested, and allocated; if the human being is *homo venandus*, the animal whose reason qualifies it for pursuit; if the only exit the story offers from the hunt is the assumption of the hunter's place; and if the game-form has become a structure of the world rather than the pastime of a man on an island—then what would it mean to leave the island? Chapter Eight attempts an answer.







CHAPTER EIGHT

Homo Venandus

Toward a Venatic Theory of the Human

§ 8.1

The Hunter's Reason: Tracking, Mētis, and the Venatic Origins of Thought

This dissertation began with a methodological claim borrowed from three scholars: that reading is tracking and narrative a trap. It is time to return to that claim as a thesis about reason itself. Carlo Ginzburg proposed that conjectural knowledge—the capacity to infer an absent cause from present traces—may have originated in the hunter's practice of reading spoor, and that the first narrative may have been the hunter's account of a sequence of events reconstructed from tracks. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant showed that the Greek concept of cunning intelligence, *mētis*, was elaborated in the vocabulary of the snare, the net, the lure, and the evasions of hunted creatures. Together, the two accounts describe two faces of a single faculty. One is the intelligence of the hunter: patient, inferential, oriented toward an absent object it must find. The other is the intelligence of the hunted: mobile, deceptive, oriented toward a present danger it must escape.

Connell's story stages the two faces in its two protagonists and makes them exchange places. On the first morning Rainsford is the hunter-reader, inferring a hunt from crushed weeds and an empty cartridge; on the days that follow he is the creature of *mētis*, doubling back, setting snares, leaping into the sea. Zaroff remains the tracker throughout, reading the trail by night and by day, and his one failure of inference—the assumption that the cliff meant death—is a failure to imagine the quarry's cunning. The plot is a contest between the two forms of reason, and its outcome declares that the reason of the hunted can defeat the reason of the hunter.

The general's specification of the ideal quarry acquires, in this light, a deeper sense than he intended. "It must have courage, cunning, and, above all, it must be able to reason." Cunning and reason, in the Greek account, are the intelligence of the hunted as much as of the hunter, and courage is the virtue of the one who stands at bay. The general seeks in his quarry precisely

the faculties that being hunted produces. He believes he is selecting the rational animal for the hunt. He is describing the rational animal as a product of the hunt. The most dangerous game is dangerous because the game made it what it is.

This is the first proposition of what this chapter calls a venatic theory of the human. The faculties by which the tradition has defined the human—reason, foresight, inference, deception, the capacity to construct a narrative from traces—are not independent of the hunt. They are, at least in part, its sediment: the deposit of a long history in which human beings both hunted and were hunted, and in which the intelligence of pursuit and the intelligence of evasion were cultivated together. *Homo venandus* names this double inheritance. The human being is the animal whose reason was formed in the chase, on both sides of it.

The proposition has a reflexive consequence that this dissertation must acknowledge. Its own method, venatic hermeneutics, has been a form of tracking: following the spoor of ideas to their origins, reading details as clues, reconstructing a hidden structure from scattered traces. The method has a hunter's satisfactions and a hunter's dangers. It risks treating its object as quarry—to be run down, cornered, and mounted in a library of interpretations—and it risks the blindness the story attributes to its expert, who sees what his categories allow and misses the rest. The cartridge that Rainsford read correctly in every respect but the category was a warning to readers as well as to sportsmen.

Ginzburg was alert to this danger. The evidential paradigm, he noted, served the physician and the connoisseur, and it served the police as well: Alphonse Bertillon's measurements, Galton's fingerprints, the files of identification by which states learned to track their subjects. The same reason that reconstructs a past event from its traces can reconstruct a person's movements from theirs, and Chapter Seven followed that development into the platform economy. Once the hunter's reason is institutionalized, it does not distinguish between the scholar's quarry and the state's.

A venatic theory of the human, then, cannot simply celebrate the hunter's intelligence as the origin of thought. It must hold two claims together. The first is that reason has a venatic history, and that its power to infer, foresee, and deceive was formed in pursuit and evasion. The second is that this history gives reason no license. That our intelligence was shaped by the hunt does not oblige us to hunt, any more than the evolution of the hand for grasping obliges us to seize. The general's error was to read a genealogy as a mandate. The remaining sections describe a use of reason that knows its venatic history and declines its venatic mandate.

§ 8.2

The Oldest Images: Lascaux, the Lion-Man, and the Hybrid Hunter

The reversibility of hunter and hunted is older than any of the myths assembled in Chapter Four. It appears in some of the earliest images human beings made. In the cave of Lascaux in the Dordogne, painted perhaps seventeen thousand years ago, a narrow shaft at the back of the cave—*le Puits*, the Well or Shaft—contains a scene unlike anything in the cave's great friezes of animals. A man with the head of a bird, arms flung out and phallus erect, tilts backward as though falling or dead before a bison. The bison's belly has been opened, and its entrails hang in loops; a spear lies across its flank. Beside the man a bird perches on a stick, and to the left a rhinoceros moves away.

The scene has been read as a hunting accident, a shaman in trance, a myth of origin, and a record of a death. Georges Bataille, in *Lascaux ou la naissance de l'art* (1955), made it central to his account of art's birth from the transgression of the prohibition on killing. What is not in doubt is its structure. It is among the oldest known images of a human being in a narrative scene, and the scene appears to show a hunter struck down by his quarry, or dying beside it, with the boundary between man and animal already blurred in the bird-headed figure. Actaeon's story is here in outline, millennia before Ovid.

One of the oldest known figurative sculptures is older still, and it blurs the boundary more radically. The Lion-Man of the Hohlenstein-Stadel cave in southwestern Germany, carved from mammoth ivory roughly forty thousand years ago, stands upright on human legs and bears the head of a cave lion. It fuses the human body with the head of the most formidable predator of the Ice Age. Whether it represents a god, a shaman, an ancestor, or a dream, it shows that among the first things human beings chose to make, when they began to carve beings that did not exist, was a union of themselves with the animal that hunted them.

The cave of Les Trois-Frères in the French Pyrenees contains a related figure, known since the abbé Henri Breuil's drawing as the "Sorcerer": a figure with a human posture, the antlers of a stag, the round eyes of an owl, and the tail of a horse or wolf, poised above a crowd of engraved animals. Breuil's drawing is itself an interpretation, and the engraving is harder to read than his rendering suggests. But the figure belongs to a family of therianthropic images —part human, part animal—that recur across the art of the Upper Paleolithic, and that have led many prehistorians to see in them a ritual identification between hunter and game.

These images prove no theory of the hunt's role in human origins, and this dissertation does not use them as proof. They are, in the terms of Chapter One, part of the archive. But they establish one thing that bears directly on the venatic paradigm: the oldest human imagination of the hunt that survives was not a story of mastery but a story of exchange. The hunter wears the head of the bird or the lion; the bison kills, or dies beside, the man who wounds it; the human body takes the predator's head. The boundary that Zaroff, Rainsford, and the

tradition of *animal rationale* labor to fix—hunter here, quarry there—is in these images fluid, dangerous, and sacred.

This fluidity is what the venatic paradigm of modernity forgot and what Connell's story remembers despite itself. Rainsford becomes the fox; the general becomes the repast of his own hounds; the hunter of men is a man; the quarry who reasons is a hunter. The story's horror is, at one level, the return of the Paleolithic exchange into a world that believed it had fixed the categories. Whitney's "evil place" that can "broadcast vibrations of evil" is a place where the old fluidity has come back.

The Paleolithic images also suggest a relation between hunter and hunted different from the one the general practices. The bird-headed man of Lascaux and the Lion-Man of Hohlenstein-Stadel are not trophies. They are identifications. Whatever rite or belief they served, they place the human being inside the animal's form rather than placing the animal's head on the human's wall. The trophy says: I took your head. The therianthrope says: I wear your head; I am also you. The first is the logic of Zaroff's library. The second, in a register that a post-venatic ethics might recover without its violence, is the logic of Whitney's "Perhaps the jaguar does"—the recognition that the animal has a point of view, and that the hunter can occupy it.

§ 8.3

Man the Hunter, Man the Hunted: Paleoanthropology as Venatic Fable

The twentieth century told two stories about the role of the hunt in human origins, and Connell's story appeared just as the first of them was beginning. Chapter One recalled that the Taung skull reached Raymond Dart in the last weeks of 1924. Dart later became the leading advocate of the view that the human lineage had been forged by predatory violence. In "The Predatory Transition from Ape to Man" (1953), he argued that the australopithecines had been hunters and killers who used the bones of their prey as weapons, and that the human species had inherited a predatory nature from them. The dramatist and popular writer Robert Ardrey carried the thesis to a mass audience in *African Genesis* (1961) and *The Hunting Hypothesis* (1976), and Stanley Kubrick gave it a canonical image in the opening of *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), in which a hominid discovers that a bone can be a club and hurls it into the sky, where it becomes a spacecraft.

The academic form of the first story was more measured but no less influential. A symposium held in Chicago in 1966 and published as *Man the Hunter* (1968), edited by Richard B. Lee and Irven DeVore, gathered the anthropology of foraging peoples under a title that summarized a paradigm: the view that hunting had been the master adaptation of human evolution, shaping intelligence, cooperation, language, and the division of labor. Feminist anthropologists answered quickly. Sally Linton (later Slocum), in "Woman the Gatherer" (1971;

reprinted 1975), argued that the paradigm projected modern male roles onto prehistory, neglecting the evidence that gathering, largely by women, supplied much of the food of known foraging societies, and that the first tools may have been containers rather than weapons.

The second story reversed the first. The paleontologist C. K. Brain, studying the bone accumulations of the Swartkrans cave in South Africa, concluded in *The Hunters or the Hunted?* (1981) that many of the hominin remains there had been deposited not by hominin hunters but by the leopards and other carnivores that ate them. Among his evidence was the partial skull of a juvenile hominin, catalogued as SK 54, which bears two holes whose spacing matches the lower canine teeth of a leopard: a child's head held in a predator's jaws. Later study of the Taung skull itself, Dart's founding fossil, found damage consistent with the talons of a large eagle (Berger and Clarke 1995; Berger 2006). Donna Hart and Robert W. Sussman drew such evidence together in *Man the Hunted: Primates, Predators, and Human Evolution* (2005), arguing that for most of their history the ancestors of humans were prey, and that many features of human sociality and intelligence evolved as defenses against predators.

This dissertation does not adjudicate between these accounts, which continue to be debated and revised as evidence accumulates. It treats them, as Chapter One promised, as part of the archive: twentieth-century stories about the hunt, told with scientific materials and shaped by the concerns of their tellers. Dart's killer ape belongs to the decade after the Second World War, and its popularity owed much to a culture seeking an explanation for that war's violence; "Man the Hunter" belongs to the confident anthropology of the 1960s; "Woman the Gatherer" and "Man the Hunted" to the critical decades that followed.

Read as a sequence of stories, however, the debate displays the structure of Connell's plot. Its first act declares that humans are hunters; its second discovers that they were prey; and its outcome is not the victory of either thesis but the recognition that the human lineage was formed on both sides of the hunt. The paleoanthropological debate performed the story's reversal over half a century, with fossils instead of hounds. The most dangerous game was game before it was a hunter.

The venatic theory of the human proposed here draws one inference from the reversal. The faculties that the general specifies in his ideal quarry—courage, cunning, reason—are the faculties a long history of being hunted would favor. Vigilance, the capacity to anticipate a predator's movements, cooperation in defense, the detection of deception, the construction of plans to evade a superior force: on the hypothesis of "Man the Hunted," these are among the sources of human intelligence. The general believes he has found in the human being an animal worthy of his hunt. He has found the animal that the hunt produced.

The inference cuts against the general's philosophy with precision. Zaroff's credo holds that "life is for the strong" and that the weak "were put here to give the strong pleasure." The record, read as this dissertation reads it, suggests that the human being's distinctive strengths are, in large part, strengths of the weak: the cunning of the hunted, the cooperation of creatures banding together against predators, the reason of animals that could neither outrun nor outfight what pursued them. If the human is the most dangerous game, it is because for

most of its history it was the weaker party, and its weapons are the weapons of the weak. The general's pride in his strength is a forgetting of where his strength came from.

§ 8.4

The Carrier Bag and the Cellar: Le Guin and the Untold Story

Ursula K. Le Guin's essay "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (written 1986, collected 1989) begins from the debate traced in the previous section and turns it into a theory of narrative. Following Elizabeth Fisher's *Woman's Creation* (1979), Le Guin proposed that the first cultural device was probably not a weapon but a container—a bag, a sling, a net, a gourd—for carrying gathered food home. The story of the hunt, she argued, had crowded out the story of the bag because the hunt makes the better story: it has a hero, a conflict, a climax, a kill. The "killer story," with its linear arc from pursuit to triumph, became the shape of narrative itself, and the many stories without that shape were left untold, or told as if they had it.

Le Guin's proposal was that fiction might be understood instead as a carrier bag: a container that holds things in particular relations to one another and to the reader, without the arrow of the hunt to organize them. Such a fiction would not lack conflict, but conflict would be one element among many rather than the principle of its form. Its people would not be sorted into heroes and others; its meaning would not lie in a final kill.

"The Most Dangerous Game" is the purest killer story in the American short-story canon. It is a pursuit from first line to last, its structure is the arc of the hunt, and its climax is a kill. It is also, as Chapter One noted, taught in schools as the exemplary form of narrative conflict. Le Guin's essay identifies what that form leaves out, and the story's own text shows where.

Consider the people the story mentions and abandons. Whitney, who held the ethical position on the yacht, sails on to Rio and is never heard from again. The unnamed man whose scream Rainsford heard in the water, and did not try to recognize, is never identified; the story does not say whether it was his trail that offered "no problems at all" or his head that, in the general's pun the next morning, was "lost." The dozen men from the Spanish bark *San Lucar*, the general's "pupils," are mentioned once, at dinner, as "a very inferior lot," and never again. When the story ends, Rainsford is asleep in the general's bed, the hounds have been fed, and the cellar, as far as the text tells us, still holds a dozen men.

The cellar is the story the killer story does not tell. Its inhabitants are the true quarry of the island, the men whose condition the general's game was built to exploit and whose fate ceases to interest the narrative once a worthier quarry arrives. Rainsford's victory frees Rainsford and leaves them where they were. The narrative's arc, from the yacht to the bed, passes over their heads—literally, since the cellar lies beneath the rooms where the climax takes place.

A carrier-bag reading of the story would keep the cellar in view. It would ask who the men from the *San Lucar* were, in what ports they signed on, what languages they spoke, what they made of the château above them, how many had already been sent into the jungle with a knife,

some food, and three hours' start, and what became of them on the morning after Rainsford's best night's sleep. It would recover the scream as the voice of a person. It would follow Whitney to Rio and ask whether he wondered, as the yacht sailed on, where his friend had gone.

None of these questions has an answer in Connell's text, and that is the point. The form of the killer story is the form that makes them unaskable. The venatic paradigm, on this account, is a structure not only of power but of attention. It directs the reader's interest to the hunter and the worthy quarry and away from the many who are merely game. The general's taxonomy of "scum" is reproduced in the narrative's indifference to the cellar. Rainsford, who "did not try" to recognize the scream, is the reader the killer story trains: attentive to the contest, inattentive to its cost.

A post-venatic reading of "The Most Dangerous Game" therefore begins not in the bedroom but in the cellar. Its first act is the one the story never performs: someone goes downstairs. The ethics this chapter proposes takes its bearings from that act. The question is not who wins the game but who remains in the cellar when the game is over, and whether anyone will open the door.

§ 8.5

The Ellipsis: Where the Paradigm Hides Its Succession

Between the general's last words and the story's last sentence stands a row of dots: "'On guard, Rainsford.' . . ." Then a space, and then: "He had never slept in a better bed, Rainsford decided." Chapter Four read the ellipsis through Girard's account of the founding murder that every order conceals and Benjamin's account of the mythic cycle of law-making and law-preserving violence. It is time to read it as the most important formal decision in the story.

The ellipsis performs three operations. First, it conceals the violence on which the ending rests. The reader does not see how Rainsford kills the general—with what weapon, at what cost, with what feeling. The duel is announced and its result reported, and the act itself is withheld. Second, it hands the decision about the act's meaning to the reader. Because the killing is not shown, its character—fair fight, just execution, self-defense, murder—must be supplied, and the reader supplies it from the expectations the story has built, which are those of a duel won by the hero. Third, it makes the tone of the final sentence possible. A story that showed the killing could hardly end on a man's satisfaction with a mattress; a story that skips it can.

The concealment is not a failure of nerve. It is the form the venatic paradigm takes at the moment of succession. Girard argued that the founding murder vanishes from the myth that issues from it, so that a community remembers the order but not the killing that produced it. Benjamin argued that law-making violence, once it has founded an order, presents itself as that order's natural basis and becomes invisible in the law it preserves. Connell's ellipsis is a

typographical version of the same disappearance. The new sovereign of the island is shown asleep; the act that made him sovereign is three dots on the page.

Simone Weil's essay "L'Iliade ou le poème de la force," written as the Second World War began and published in 1940–41, offers the most exact description of what the ellipsis hides. "La force, c'est ce qui fait de quiconque lui est soumis une chose," she wrote: force is that which makes a thing of whoever is subjected to it. And it does something to the one who wields it as well. Force, Weil argued, is as pitiless to the man who possesses it, or believes he does, as to its victims: it crushes the one and intoxicates the other. The man who uses force is carried away by it and loses the capacity to measure, to pause, and to see the one before him as a person.

The story's final sentence is a portrait of the intoxication Weil describes. A man who has just killed another man in single combat, in the dead man's bedroom, after three days of being hunted by him, lies down in the dead man's bed and finds it excellent. His satisfaction is unalloyed; no image of the general troubles him; no thought of the cellar keeps him awake. Weil would have recognized the state. Force has made of the general a thing, "a repast for the hounds," and it has made of Rainsford a man who can sleep.

The ellipsis is where this transformation happens, and the story hides it because to show it would expose the loop. A reader who saw Rainsford kill might ask what kind of man he became in doing so, and whether the bed in which he sleeps is the general's office as well as his furniture. The ellipsis lets the reader skip the question, as Rainsford skips the vigil that Frazer's King of the Wood must keep. It protects the satisfaction of the ending—the satisfaction of Alyosha's "Shoot him!"—from the knowledge of what that satisfaction costs.

A post-venatic reading must therefore insist on the ellipsis. It must decline the invitation to fill the gap with the comfortable assumptions of the duel and ask instead what the three dots conceal: not the mechanics of a fight but the moment at which the quarry became the hunter, and the hunter became the thing that force makes of those who use it. The question the ellipsis withholds is the one this dissertation has been tracking from the start. Can one escape the hunt without becoming the hunter? Rainsford's answer, reported after the dots, is no. The rest of this chapter asks whether that answer is final.

§ 8.6

Lazarus and Bobby: Two Dogs and the Recognition of the Human

Zaroff's finest hound was named Lazarus, and Chapter Four read the name through the two Lazaruses of the Gospels. There is a third dog in this dissertation's archive, and its story is the counter-image of the general's pack.

In a short essay titled "Nom d'un chien ou le droit naturel" ("The Name of a Dog, or Natural Rights," 1975), Emmanuel Levinas recalled his captivity as a French prisoner of war in

Nazi Germany. He and his fellow Jewish prisoners were held in a forestry detachment, Camp 1492, and set to work under guards and passing civilians who looked at them, he wrote, as beings stripped of their humanity, a gang of subhumans. For a few weeks a stray dog wandered into the camp. The prisoners called him Bobby. He appeared at the morning assemblies and waited for the men as they came back from work, jumping and barking in delight. For him, Levinas wrote, there was no doubt that they were men. He called the dog "the last Kantian in Nazi Germany," lacking only the brain needed to universalize his maxims.

The two dogs stand at the two poles of the venatic paradigm. Lazarus was bred and trained to hunt men; he died following a man into the quicksand, and his master mourned him more than any human being he had killed. Bobby was nobody's dog; he recognized as men those whom their captors had declared less than human, and his greeting was, for a few weeks, the only acknowledgment of their humanity that Levinas and his companions received. The hound of the hunter's estate enacted the general's taxonomy. The stray of the prison camp refuted it.

Levinas's anecdote has been debated by readers who note that his ethics of the face was not easily extended to animals, and that the dog in his essay is praised for a recognition he does not himself fully receive. The debate is part of the anecdote's significance, and it bears on the problem of this dissertation. The question of who recognizes whom, and who is recognized, runs through every chapter. The general wanted Rainsford's recognition and hunted men because he could not obtain it from those he regarded as inferiors; Hegel's lord found the bondsman's recognition worthless; Meruem found across a board a recognition that transformed him. Bobby supplies the case in which recognition comes from the being at the bottom of every hierarchy the tradition built, and in which it is not a contest won but a gift.

Jacques Derrida's lecture "L'animal que donc je suis," delivered at Cerisy in 1997, begins from a related scene. Derrida describes being seen naked by his cat in the bathroom, and the embarrassment he feels under the animal's gaze—an embarrassment at being ashamed before an animal, and at being ashamed of that shame. The scene inverts the myth of Actaeon. In Ovid, the hunter sees the naked goddess and is punished by his hounds. In Derrida, the philosopher is seen naked by the animal and is exposed to a point of view that the tradition from Descartes onward had denied the animal possessed. The cat's gaze, Derrida argued, reopens the question the philosophers had closed: what does the animal see when it looks at us?

Whitney's "Perhaps the jaguar does" is the story's version of that question, and the story drops it as soon as it is asked. Rainsford answers it with "Bah! They've no understanding," and the plot proceeds to teach him, through three days of terror, what the jaguar understands: fear. But the lesson stops at fear. Rainsford learns "how an animal at bay feels" and draws from the lesson no conclusion about the animal, or about the men in the cellar, or about the general's hounds. He learns the quarry's fear in order to survive it, not in order to recognize those who live in it.

The post-venatic ethics this chapter proposes begins where Bobby and Derrida's cat begin: with the recognition that the being in front of us has a point of view, and that our place in

its field of vision is not the hunter's place by right. Bobby's greeting and the cat's gaze reverse the direction of the hunter's sight. They ask the human being to accept being seen rather than only seeing—to stand for a moment in the open, as Rainsford stood blinking in the glaring light at the château's door, without the assurance that the eyes upon him are either a hunter's or a quarry's.

§ 8.7

Non-Power: Suffering, Refusal, and a Post-Venatic Definition of the Human

The rationalist tradition defined the human by a power: the power to reason, to know, to deliberate, to will. Chapter Two showed how that definition drew a line around reason and declared the outside a hunting ground, and how Zaroff, finding the outside exhausted, turned the hunt on reason itself. A post-venatic definition of the human must begin elsewhere. Its materials have appeared throughout this dissertation, and they share a feature: they define the human, and the living being in general, not by what it can do but by what it cannot help, or can decline to do.

The first is Bentham's question, read through Derrida. "The question is not, Can they *reason*? nor, Can they *talk*? but, Can they *suffer*?" Derrida observed, in the lecture discussed in the previous section, that the question is stranger than it seems. It asks about a capacity—"can they"—but the capacity in question is a passivity, an exposure to what one cannot prevent. To be able to suffer is to be unable not to suffer. Bentham's question asks not about a power but about a non-power, a vulnerability at the heart of the living that the human shares with every creature that can be hurt. Whitney's "one thing" the jaguar understands, "fear," is this non-power. It is not reason; it is the condition that reason, in the hunted, works to escape.

The second is Rousseau's pity. In the *Discours sur l'origine et les fondements de l'inégalité* (1755), Rousseau found in human nature, prior to reason, "une répugnance naturelle à voir périr ou souffrir tout être sensible et principalement nos semblables"—a natural repugnance to see any sentient being perish or suffer, principally those like ourselves. In the preface to the same work he drew the conclusion that inverts the general's criterion point for point. If I am obliged to do no harm to my fellow human, he wrote, it is "moins parce qu'il est un être raisonnable que parce qu'il est un être sensible"—less because he is a rational being than because he is a sentient one; and this quality, being common to beast and man, ought at least to give the one the right not to be needlessly mistreated by the other. Zaroff hunts men because they reason. Rousseau forbids their mistreatment because they feel.

The third is the power not to. Herman Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener" (1853) gave modern literature its most famous figure of refusal: a copyist who answers every request with "I would prefer not to." Giorgio Agamben, in an essay on the story (1993), read Bartleby

as the figure of a potentiality that includes its own negation—the capacity not to do, which Aristotle had recognized as belonging to every genuine capacity. To be able is also to be able not to. The musician who can play can refrain from playing; the hunter who can kill can refrain from killing.

Rainsford, at luncheon on his first day, speaks Bartleby's sentence in his own idiom: "No, general, I will not hunt." The general's reply is the knout. The story thus contains the Bartlebyan refusal and makes it impossible to sustain. Within the island's structure, the power not to hunt is converted, by the arrangement of the alternatives, into the obligation to be hunted. This is the deepest meaning of the general's "option." It does not abolish the power not to; it makes its exercise unbearable.

These materials—the non-power of suffering, the response of pity, the power not to—suggest a post-venatic definition of the human that inverts the general's. Zaroff defined the human, as the tradition did, by a power, reason, and concluded that the being with this power was the supreme quarry. The post-venatic definition locates the human, and the moral standing of every sentient being, in two non-powers. The first is the capacity to suffer, which the human shares with the jaguar, the sailors in the cellar, the hound Lazarus, and Bobby, and which grounds a claim not to be hunted. The second is the capacity to refrain, which may belong especially to beings who deliberate, and which grounds a responsibility not to hunt.

The two non-powers stand in exact relation to the general's specification of the ideal quarry. "Courage, cunning, and, above all ... reason" are powers, and they make a being worth hunting. Vulnerability and the capacity to refrain are non-powers: the first makes a being something that ought not to be hunted, the second makes it a being that can choose not to hunt. The venatic definition asks what a being can do and ranks beings by their capacities. The post-venatic definition asks what a being cannot prevent and what it can decline, and finds in the first the ground of every being's claim and in the second the ground of every reasoning being's duty.

The conclusion is not sentimental, and it does not abolish reason. Reason remains the faculty by which the capacity to refrain is exercised: it is what allows a being to know that it could hunt and to decide that it will not. But reason ceases to be the qualification that sorts beings into hunters and game. It becomes instead the faculty by which a hunter can lay down the hunt—the faculty by which *homo venandus*, the animal formed by the chase, can become something else.

§ 8.8

Five Exits from the Island

The myths and fictions assembled in this dissertation imagine a small number of ways out of the venatic paradigm, and Chapter Six began to collect them. They can now be set beside the

story's own ending and assessed. Rainsford's exit—the victory of the quarry, which reproduces the hunter—has been read throughout as the Nemorensian loop. Five others stand against it.

The first is **attention**. Simone Weil wrote, in a letter of 1942, that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity, and her concept of attention is the opposite of the hunter's. The hunter's attention, which Ortega celebrated as the alertness of the man in the field, is directed toward a quarry it means to seize. Weil's attention is directed toward the afflicted, whom it means to see: a waiting, an emptying of one's own projects so that another's reality can appear. Rainsford's first ethical failure was a failure of this attention: "He did not recognize the animal that made the sound; he did not try to." The first exit from the island is to try—to hear the scream as a voice, to attend to the quarry not as a problem but as a person. Iris Murdoch, drawing on Weil, described moral attention as a just and loving way of looking at an individual reality. It is the way of looking that the general, a connoisseur of specimens, could never turn on his pupils.

The second is **abdication**. Prospero, having brought his enemies into his power, renounces vengeance, breaks his staff, drowns his book, and frees his servant. The exit is the hunter's own, and it requires a power the quarry lacks: the power to stop hunting. Its limitation, as Chapter Four observed, is that it remains a sovereign's prerogative; the island is not returned to Caliban. But it establishes that the hunter can lay down the hunt, and that doing so is, in Prospero's words, "the rarer action."

The third is **mercy**. Roy Batty, with his hunter at his mercy, saves him, and dies. The exit belongs to the quarry, and it refuses the loop at the moment the loop would close. Batty does not take the hunter's place; by sparing him he demonstrates the capacity whose supposed absence licensed the hunt. The limitation of this exit is that it is available only to a quarry with nothing left to lose, and that it leaves the system of hunting intact; other replicants will be retired. But it proves that reversibility is not a law of nature. The quarry can decline to become the hunter.

The fourth is **recognition**. Meruem, the predator king, learns across a board to see the girl he was born to eat, and the game becomes a place of recognition rather than slaughter. This exit transforms the game-form itself: what the general made an instrument of death becomes the medium of a relation between unequals in which each comes to see the other. Its limitation is its price—both players die—and the fact that it occurs between two individuals within a war that continues around them. But it suggests that the game-form, which this dissertation has treated as the most dangerous element of the story, is not dangerous in itself. Its danger depends on what is at stake and on whether the players can see each other.

The fifth is **abolition**. Katniss Everdeen, appointed to execute the defeated tyrant, kills instead the victorious leader who proposes to restart the Games with new victims. Her act aims not at the hunter but at the succession, the mechanism by which the loop reproduces itself. Its limitation is that it is itself an act of violence, and the novel does not pretend that it settles the questions of power it raises. But it identifies the right target. The problem of the island is not the general but the island: the lights, the reef, the hounds, the cellar, the rules. W.

E. B. Du Bois, writing of Reconstruction in *Black Reconstruction in America* (1935), argued that the abolition of slavery required more than the removal of an institution; it required the building of new ones—what he called "abolition democracy"—in which the formerly enslaved could live as free people. The exit by abolition is the dismantling of the hunting ground and the building, in its place, of an order in which no one is quarry.

The spoilsport's exit—Rainsford's leap, Katniss and Peeta's berries—is a precondition of the others but not an exit in itself. It breaks the game's frame by refusing its outcome, and so exposes the game's dependence on its players' compliance; but on its own it leaves the frame to be rebuilt. Rainsford's leap broke the general's game, and the general rebuilt it that same night as a duel.

The five exits are not alternatives among which one must choose. They are moments of a single movement: it begins with attention, passes through the hunter's renunciation and the quarry's refusal to succeed him, transforms the game-form into a medium of recognition, and ends in the dismantling of the structure that made the hunt possible. The story contains the seed of each—Whitney's question, the general's library that might have been drowned, the bed that might have been refused, the game that might have been played for something other than a life, the cellar that might have been opened. That none is taken is the story's achievement as a work of art and its limit as a guide to life. It shows the loop with perfect clarity because it does not break it.

§ 8.9

The Venatic Paradigm: Theses Restated

The dissertation can now restate its four theses in their final form, with the evidence of the preceding chapters. Table 8.1 summarizes them.

Taken together, the four theses describe the venatic paradigm: the structure in which the human is defined by a capacity, the capacity becomes a ranking of beings, the ranking is enforced by pursuit, and the pursuit is framed as a game whose rules make it appear as something other than what it is. Each thesis names one articulation of the structure; the paradigm is their conjunction.

The contribution of this dissertation is to have shown that Connell's story assembles this structure in a single, compact narrative, and that the structure is not the story's invention but the convergence of genealogies that run back through Western philosophy, myth, and law and forward into the media, technologies, and institutions of the century after 1924. The story is a primal scene in the sense given the term here: a minimal model in which the elements of a much larger formation appear together, in a form that can be grasped at once.

Two qualifications must accompany the claim. The first concerns causality. The dissertation has not argued that Connell's story caused anything. Its afterlives—the films, novels, games, and crimes—are not its effects, except in a handful of documented adaptations and

TABLE 8.1

The four theses of the venatic paradigm.

I

VENATIC INVERSION



FORMULATION

Reason, the criterion that exempted the human from the hunt, becomes its qualification; dignity is converted into price

TEXTUAL HINGE

"It must be able to reason"; "a thoroughbred horse or hound is worth more than a score of them"

PRINCIPAL GENEALOGIES

Aristotle's natural slave; Descartes; Kant; Locke's beasts of prey; Galton, Grant, Stoddard

AFTERLIVES

Dick's empathy test; the hosts of *Westworld* targets identified by pattern

II

VENATIC REVERSIBILITY (THE NEMORENSIAN LOOP)



FORMULATION

The quarry escapes only by assuming the hunter's place; victory reproduces sovereignty

TEXTUAL HINGE

"I am still a beast at bay"; "He had never slept in a better bed"

PRINCIPAL GENEALOGIES

Actaeon; Theseus and the brigands; Frazer's Nemi; Hegel's lord and bondsman; Benjamin's mythic violence

AFTERLIVES

Sheckley's alternating Hunt; *Predator* the remakes' changing occupants

III

THE LITERALIZING ISLAND



FORMULATION

The island converts figures into practices; its horror is the collapse of metaphor into act

TEXTUAL HINGE

"hunters and huntees"; "broadcast vibrations of evil"; "the best sport in the world"

PRINCIPAL GENEALOGIES

Kafka's literalized metaphors; decadent aesthetic murder; the venatic vocabulary of finance and advertising

AFTERLIVES

The Zodiac cipher; the "hare hunt"; the kill chain

IV

THE DOUBLE GAME



FORMULATION

The most dangerous game is the game-form that converts coercion into consent and killing into sport

TEXTUAL HINGE

"It's a game, you see"; "I give him his option"; "You have won the game"

PRINCIPAL GENEALOGIES

The *krypteia*'s declaration of war; Huizinga, Caillois, Suits; Hobbes and Rousseau on consent; Foucault's school

AFTERLIVES

The battle royale; terms of service; the drone interface

allusions. The story is a seismograph, not a seism. It registered a movement already under way and gave that movement a form later works could borrow, but the movement had its own causes in the histories of empire, war, capital, and technique.

The second concerns universality. The venatic paradigm described here is a structure of Western modernity, assembled from Greek, Roman, Jewish, Christian, European, and American materials and carried abroad by European empires. The dissertation has drawn comparisons with Japanese and Korean works, with Indigenous American and African histories, and with Paleolithic images, but it does not claim that the paradigm is universal or that every culture has organized its relation to the hunt in this way. The Paleolithic therianthropes of section 8.2, Kipling's Law of the Jungle, and the Ilongot headhunting described by Rosaldo all point to other organizations, in which the hunt is embedded in reciprocity, mourning, or sacred identification. The paradigm's claim to universality is, indeed, one of its instruments: the general's credo presents itself as a law of nature.

Within these limits the theses stand. The human of the modern tradition has been *homo venandus*: the animal whose reason qualifies it for pursuit, whose escape from pursuit reproduces the pursuer, whose metaphors of predation become practices, and whose hunts are disguised as games. Connell's story shows this human with the clarity of a fable, and the fable's last sentence shows him asleep.

§ 8.10

Leaving the Island

The story begins with a question asked on a yacht in the dark. Rainsford asks, "Who cares how a jaguar feels?" and Whitney answers, "Perhaps the jaguar does." Rainsford dismisses the answer: "Bah! They've no understanding." The rest of the story is Rainsford's education in the jaguar's understanding. He learns fear—"the fear of pain and the fear of death"—and learns it so thoroughly that he can defeat the man who taught it to him. But he never returns to Whitney's question. The story ends with its hero asleep, and the question of how the jaguar feels—how the man screaming in the dark felt, how the men in the cellar feel—is left on the yacht, sailing on toward Rio.

This dissertation has tried to take Whitney's question seriously and to follow it through the genealogies that Connell's characters inherit: through the philosophy that made reason the criterion of the human and the hunting ground its complement; through the economy of leisure that made the hunt a remedy for boredom and the trophy a form of culture; through the myths of hosts and hounds, heads and beds, that give the story its shape; through the theories of play, contract, and recognition that explain the general's game; through the speculative fictions that generalized it; and through the media, machines, and institutions that built it. Its conclusion is that the most dangerous game is not, finally, the human quarry but the game-form that makes the hunting of human beings into a sport, a policy, a procedure, or a pastime

—and that the human being formed by that game is *homo venandus*, the animal whose reason was shaped in the chase and qualifies it for pursuit.

The conclusion has a reflexive edge. The method of this dissertation, venatic hermeneutics, has been a hunt of its own. It has tracked ideas to their lairs, read details as spoor, and arranged its findings in tables. A reader may fairly ask whether it too has treated its object as quarry, and whether its library of genealogies is a collection of heads. The answer it offers is Le Guin's. A study of the hunt cannot avoid the hunter's methods, but it can change what it carries home. This dissertation has tried to carry home not a single trophy—a meaning run to ground—but a bag of relations: the story held together with the myths and philosophies that inform it, the fictions that answer it, the histories that enacted it, and the people it forgets.

Among those people, one group has the last claim on our attention. When the story ends, the general is dead, the hounds have been fed, and Rainsford is asleep in the best bed on the island. Below him, in the cellar of the château, is the "training school," and in it, as far as the text tells us, are about a dozen men from the Spanish bark *San Lucar*—sailors from tramp ships, the general's "pupils," whom the story has not mentioned since dinner on the first night. They are waiting for their turn to be given a knife, a supply of food, and three hours' start.

The venatic paradigm ends in the bed. A post-venatic ethics begins at the cellar door. It begins with the attention Rainsford withheld from the scream in the water, and it extends that attention to those the killer story has no use for. It requires the hunter's capacity to refrain, the quarry's refusal to succeed the hunter, a game played for something other than a life, and, finally, the dismantling of the island: the darkening of the false lights in the channel, the release of the hounds from their purpose, the emptying of the cellar, the closing of the library of heads. None of these acts appears in Connell's story. Every one of them is implied by it.

"The Most Dangerous Game" has been read for a century as the story of a man who learns how an animal at bay feels, and survives. It is also the story of a man who learns this and goes to sleep. Between those two readings lies the whole of the question this dissertation has pursued: whether a being formed by the hunt can leave it. The story does not answer. It ends in the dark, with a decision about a bed. The answer, if there is one, begins with someone getting up before morning and going downstairs.



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Section VI

Films, Television, Comics, and Games

FILM

Grass: A Nation's Battle for Life. 1925. Directed by Merian C. Cooper, Ernest B. Schoedsack, and Marguerite Harrison. Paramount.

Chang: A Drama of the Wilderness. 1927. Directed by Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack. Paramount.

The Most Dangerous Game. 1932. Directed by Irving Pichel and Ernest B. Schoedsack. Produced by Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack. Screenplay by James Ashmore Creelman. Music by Max Steiner. RKO Radio Pictures.

Island of Lost Souls. 1932. Directed by Erle C. Kenton. Paramount.

King Kong. 1933. Directed by Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack. RKO Radio Pictures.

The 39 Steps. 1935. Directed by Alfred Hitchcock. Gaumont-British.

Man Hunt. 1941. Directed by Fritz Lang. Twentieth Century-Fox.

Saboteur. 1942. Directed by Alfred Hitchcock. Universal.

A Game of Death. 1945. Directed by Robert Wise. RKO Radio Pictures.

Rope. 1948. Directed by Alfred Hitchcock. Transatlantic Pictures and Warner Bros.

Run for the Sun. 1956. Directed by Roy Boulting. United Artists.

North by Northwest. 1959. Directed by Alfred Hitchcock. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

La decima vittima [The 10th Victim]. 1965. Directed by Elio Petri. Italy and France.

The Naked Prey. 1965. Directed by Cornel Wilde. Paramount.

2001: A Space Odyssey. 1968. Directed by Stanley Kubrick. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Das Millionenspiel. 1970. Directed by Tom Toelle. Written by Wolfgang Menge. Westdeutscher Rundfunk.

A Clockwork Orange. 1971. Directed by Stanley Kubrick. Warner Bros.

Deliverance. 1972. Directed by John Boorman. Warner Bros.

Westworld. 1973. Directed by Michael Crichton. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Salò o le 120 giornate di Sodoma. 1975. Directed by Pier Paolo Pasolini. Italy and France.

Southern Comfort. 1981. Directed by Walter Hill. Twentieth Century-Fox.

Blade Runner. 1982. Directed by Ridley Scott. Warner Bros.

First Blood. 1982. Directed by Ted Kotcheff. Orion Pictures.

Le Prix du danger. 1983. Directed by Yves Boisset. France.

Predator. 1987. Directed by John McTiernan. Twentieth Century Fox.

The Running Man. 1987. Directed by Paul Michael Glaser. TriStar Pictures.

Predator 2. 1990. Directed by Stephen Hopkins. Twentieth Century Fox.

Reservoir Dogs. 1992. Directed by Quentin Tarantino. Miramax.

Hard Target. 1993. Directed by John Woo. Universal Pictures.

Surviving the Game. 1994. Directed by Ernest Dickerson. New Line Cinema.

Battle Royale. 2000. Directed by Kinji Fukasaku. Toei.

Gladiator. 2000. Directed by Ridley Scott. DreamWorks Pictures and Universal Pictures.

Hostel. 2005. Directed by Eli Roth. Lionsgate.

Apocalypto. 2006. Directed by Mel Gibson. Touchstone Pictures.

Predators. 2010. Directed by Nimród Antal. Twentieth Century Fox.

The Hunger Games. 2012. Directed by Gary Ross. Lionsgate. Sequels 2013–15.

The Frozen Ground. 2013. Directed by Scott Walker. Lionsgate.

Ready or Not. 2019. Directed by Matt Bettinelli-Olpin and Tyler Gillett. Fox Searchlight Pictures.

The Hunt. 2020. Directed by Craig Zobel. Universal Pictures.

Prey. 2022. Directed by Dan Trachtenberg. 20th Century Studios.

TELEVISION

Hunted. 2015–. Channel 4.

Westworld. 2016–22. Created by Jonathan Nolan and Lisa Joy. HBO.

Most Dangerous Game. 2020. Quibi.

Ojing-eo geim [Squid Game]. 2021. Created by Hwang Dong-hyuk. Netflix.

COMICS

Togashi, Yoshihiro. 1998–. *Hunter* × *Hunter*. Tokyo: Shueisha.

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GAMES

Manhunt. 2003. Developed by Rockstar North. Rockstar Games.

Far Cry 3. 2012. Developed by Ubisoft Montreal. Ubisoft.

Bloodborne. 2015. Developed by FromSoftware. Sony Computer Entertainment.

Dead by Daylight. 2016. Developed by Behaviour Interactive.

PlayerUnknown's Battlegrounds. 2017. PUBG Corporation.

Fortnite Battle Royale. 2017. Epic Games.

Far Cry 5. 2018. Developed by Ubisoft Montreal and Ubisoft Toronto. Ubisoft.

Red Dead Redemption 2. 2018. Developed by Rockstar Studios. Rockstar Games.

Section VII

Visual Art and Music

Löwenmensch [Lion-Man]. c. 40,000 BP. Mammoth ivory. From the Hohlenstein-Stadel cave, Lone valley, Germany. Museum Ulm.

"Sorcerer" figure. Upper Paleolithic. Cave of Les Trois-Frères, Ariège, France. Known chiefly through the drawing by Henri Breuil.

Scène du Puits [Shaft Scene]. Upper Paleolithic, c. 17,000 BP. Cave of Lascaux, Dordogne, France.

Titian. *Diana and Actaeon*. 1556–59. National Gallery, London, and National Galleries of Scotland, Edinburgh.

Titian. *The Death of Actaeon*. c. 1559–75. National Gallery, London.

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Hirst, Damien. 1991. *The Physical Impossibility of Death in the Mind of Someone Living*. Tiger shark, glass, steel, and formaldehyde solution.

Keywords

Richard Connell ◆ “The Most Dangerous Game” ◆ venatic paradigm ◆ *homo venandus* ◆ Nemorensian loop ◆ venatic hermeneutics ◆ manhunt ◆ cynegetic power ◆ hunting and sovereignty ◆ human–animal distinction ◆ *animal rationale* ◆ moral considerability ◆ bare life ◆ necropolitics ◆ social Darwinism ◆ Nietzsche ◆ master morality ◆ eugenics ◆ Thorstein Veblen ◆ leisure class ◆ ennui ◆ *divertissement* ◆ trophy culture ◆ taxidermy ◆ colonial hunting ◆ big-game literature ◆ play theory ◆ Johan Huizinga ◆ game theory ◆ pursuit–evasion ◆ Hegelian recognition ◆ James George Frazer ◆ *The Golden Bough* ◆ comparative mythology ◆ Actaeon ◆ *xenia* ◆ *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* ◆ the Gothic ◆ the uncanny ◆ island narratives ◆ speculative fiction ◆ human-hunt genre ◆ adaptation studies ◆ transmediality ◆ evidential paradigm ◆ *mētis* ◆ narrative theory ◆ cybernetics ◆ drone warfare ◆ 1924